

Philosophy of Religion

Religionsfilosofi

Harald Høffding

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Alte dubitat, qui altius credit.

(He doubts more deeply who believes more deeply.)

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Preface to the Third Edition

When I worked out my *Philosophy of Religion* in the years 1896–1901, I had not yet given any fuller account of epistemology. Nor had I arrived at one when the second edition was due to appear (1906). Later I set out my epistemological position in “The Human Thought” (1910) and in a series of investigations bearing on the subject of the present book (on Totality 1917, on Relation 1921, and on Analogy 1923). It has thereby been possible, in this third edition, to shorten the epistemological section; on several points I could now simply refer to the works named, which would otherwise have required detailed justification. Only the strictly necessary epistemological content has been retained. In the religious-psychological section too I was able to refer to works that threw light on the topics (“The Great Humour” 1916; “Experiences and Interpretations” 1918; “Leading Thoughts in the Nineteenth Century” 1920; together with the essay “Foreword and Postscript to my Philosophy of Religion,” printed in “Minor Works”). I have besides carried out a consolidation of the two groupings of religious-psychological types, determined by different points of view, between which I earlier thought it possible to distinguish. Of the notes, a number have been omitted as outdated or superfluous. Where it was necessary, I have added new notes.

The book’s fundamental thought has remained the same. Its significance has confirmed itself to me over the years by what I have experienced or learned. Often it is precisely objections that have led to fresh corroboration. The book’s fundamental thought is not a key that unlocks everywhere, but it leads one to pose fruitful questions and to enter upon investigations that one would otherwise be inclined to think superfluous. It warns against dogmatism of every kind, and it points at the same time to a deep-lying human need that can hardly die out so long as the life of the spirit is not being extinguished. It does not solve the great problem it treats, but it can lead to ever-renewed reflection. And I hope that the book will continue to work in the direction here indicated.

Carlsberg, 28 February 1924.

HARALD HØFFDING.

Chapter 1

Problem and Procedure

Οὐκ ἔστι λύειν ἀγνοοῦντα τὸ δεσμόν.

ARISTOTLE.

(One cannot loose a knot without knowing where the binding lies).

1. By *philosophy of religion* one could mean either a thinking that springs from religion and builds on religion, or a thinking that takes religion as its object. It is in this latter sense that the term shall be taken here. The thinking that springs from and builds on religion itself belongs to the subject matter of the philosophy of religion and should not be called philosophy of religion.

By religion we think first of all of a state of mind in which feeling and need, fear and hope, enthusiasm and devotion play a larger role than reflection and inquiry, and in which intuition and image hold more sway than investigation and reasoning. To be sure, again and again in the religious life there will arise an involuntary need to give an account of one's condition and of its content—of the worth of one's motives and the validity of one's thoughts. But the religious thinking that thus arises does not pose the religious problem in a decisive way. Its problems arise within religion, but religion itself does not become a problem. No other starting point is yet recognized than religion itself; in any case other starting points are so subordinate in relation to religion that they do not acquire decisive significance. Of this kind is religious thinking in those times in which religion is everything on the spiritual plane. These are the classical times of religion: partly the great times of origins, in which religion with all the power of originality draws all strength and interest to itself; partly the great times of organization, in which all existing culture is shaped or bent into obedience under the highest religious ideas. In such classical times there is a great unity, or at least a great harmony, in the domain of

spiritual life; the division of labour that sets in at a certain stage of cultural development has not yet made itself felt in this domain. Christianity had such a classical time in the age of the primitive Christian community, and later in the great organizational period at the height of the Middle Ages. A religious problem forms only when other sides of spiritual life—science and art, morality and social life—begin to free themselves and to appear with the claim of having independent value. They then judge religion from their points of view and by their standards, whereas religion in its classical times either simply ignored them—as in the times of origins—or—as in the times of organization—valued them from its own point of view and by its own standard, so that the question became whether these two different evaluations could be brought into mutual harmony.—There must be definite historical conditions present before the religious problem can be posed in a decisive way. It is, if one will, only in unhappy times that a religious problem exists. For this problem is the expression of a spiritual disharmony: the different elements of spiritual life no longer work together in so unified a way as before; they lead in different directions, among which one must perhaps ultimately choose. But then both the necessity and the possibility of an investigation are also present.

That religion is made into a problem will be offensive to many. But thought must have the right to investigate everything, once it has awakened, and only thought itself can mark out its boundaries. Who else should mark out its boundaries? He who perceives no problem has of course no reason to think; but neither has he any reason to prevent others from thinking. He who fears losing his spiritual support must keep away. No one wishes to rob the poor man of his only lamb—but then the poor man must not unnecessarily come dragging it along the highway and demand that traffic be stopped on his account. Experience shows, moreover, that it is rather the oxen than the lambs that loudly announce themselves with their indignation in season and out of season (especially out of season). It is not so much the genuinely poor in spirit as the stiff and blustering dogmatists who take offense when free inquiry claims the right to stir on the religious plane as on any other.

The investigation I wish to undertake here addresses itself neither to those who are finished nor to those who are fearful. The finished are found in every camp, not least among the so-called “freethinkers”—a class of people who, like the “Worms” in Linnaeus’s system, can be characterized only by negative predicates, because the class is supposed to encompass so many different forms. The finished are in possession of a definite negative or positive solution to the religious problem and have thereby lost the sense for further thinking about it. The fearful dare not think about it.—Rather, the

investigation addresses itself to those who are *becoming*. “One who is becoming will always be grateful”—no matter in which direction his becoming goes.

Philosophy is, as is well known, richer in ideas, perspectives, and discussions than in definitive results, and the philosopher would often be in a sorry state if he did not believe that the constant striving after truth belongs to the highest spiritual values, which it is the task of all true religion to uphold. Even if we could learn nothing else from a philosophy-of-religion investigation, we could perhaps learn something about the causes of the strife that rages over religious questions, and about this strife’s significance for the development of spiritual life. And should the religious problem prove insoluble, we might perhaps learn why it is insoluble.

2. The philosophy of religion should not proceed from a finished philosophical system. In a certain sense all thinking must be systematic, for “system” literally means “that which stands together,” and it is an inexorable demand placed on our thoughts that they must be able to “stand together” with one another. There is an inner coherence and consistency which in every domain is the ultimate mark of truth, and which must therefore also be required in the domain of the philosophy of religion. But the philosophy-of-religion enterprise will be most fruitful where religion and its phenomena are not placed in relation to some completed philosophical conception or other, but are illuminated by a philosophizing that is itself in the process of investigating whether a completion is possible at all. The task is to discuss religion’s relation to spiritual life. Religion is itself a kind of or form of spiritual life, and it is judged rightly only when seen in its relation to other kinds or forms. It is no alien standard that is thereby applied to religion. For there is a service from which no spiritual power—even if it appears under the greatest names—can exempt itself, namely to serve the deep and rich development of spiritual life. The philosophy-of-religion task will therefore above all be to find the means for investigating whether religion, under the conditions of our spiritual culture, can continue to render such service. In solving, or better: in treating this task, the philosophy of religion cannot come equipped with other presuppositions than those which every other science brings to the treatment of its subject. Very often it will surely be compelled to declare that there are questions that cannot be answered, because the conditions in the spiritual domain are more complex and more diverse than positive and negative dogmatists suppose. Yet it is not without significance that the problems are discussed. The conscious insight into the impossibility of a solution (*docta ignorantia*) naturally invites one to investigate whether it is then so absolutely necessary that a solution be found. In addition, one’s eye will be sharpened for the particular conditions under which

our spiritual culture lives, and above all for the significance of the division of labour in the spiritual domain, through which the religious problem becomes a special form of the general problem of culture.

A philosophy-of-religion investigation can suitably be arranged so as to consist of an epistemological, a psychological, and an ethical part.

In its classical times, religion satisfies all of humankind's spiritual needs, including its drive for knowledge. Religious ideas then contain for human beings the explanation of existence in its entirety and in its individual parts. But when an independent science has developed, another kind of understanding or explanation appears alongside the religious one, and the question becomes whether these two kinds are compatible. Many hold that the relation is this, that the new, scientific mode of explanation increasingly replaces the religious explanation where particulars are concerned, but that it cannot be applied to existence considered as a whole—to what one customarily calls the “first” or the “last” questions. Then one must discuss whether religion is able to solve the riddles that science cannot solve. If it should then turn out that religious conceptions, whether with respect to the whole or to the particular, cannot help with anything that could rightly be called understanding or explanation, then one must raise the question what significance these conceptions can still have.

This last question leads from the epistemological philosophy of religion to the psychological. For if religious conceptions no longer have cognitive value, the value they might possess must consist in being expressions of sides of the life of the soul other than the intellectual. An attempt must then be made to describe the religious life of the soul, especially the relation of conceptions to religious experience and religious feeling. Through this it will become apparent that religion in its innermost nature has to do not with the understanding of existence but with the *evaluation* of it, and that religious conceptions express the relation in which factual existence, as we know it, stands to that which for us gives life its highest value. The core of religion is—according to the hypothesis to which we are led—a faith in the persistence of value in existence. This faith appears in great, vivid images in the popular religions, especially in the highest among them. Even in those who stand outside every popular religion, such a faith may stir, even though it does not here take definite shape.

The transition from psychological to ethical philosophy of religion is naturally motivated by the question: what ethical value does it have that one believes in the persistence of value? Ethics concerns the production of values, and the possibility cannot be dismissed that the work of producing values leaves no time and no strength for living

in the thought of their persistence. The ethical philosophy of religion forms a parallel to the epistemological. In its classical times, religion directly and indirectly determines the evaluation of all actions and all conditions of life. The religious problem arises on this point when an independent ethics has developed that seeks, by its own path, the grounding and motivation for the evaluation of human actions. And on this point the problem is posed in the sharpest and most pressing way, for the ultimate standard for judging religion must belong to the ethical domain, where the final reckoning of the spiritual account takes place.—

Within the framework here indicated, we shall be able to find room for all essential aspects of the religious problem. I wish to treat this problem not only with the intellectual interest that is aroused by a great and comprehensive subject, but also in the mood that comes from the consciousness of standing before a spiritual form of life in which the human race through millennia has deposited some of its deepest and most inward experiences.

3. Before we enter upon the individual parts of the philosophy of religion, it will be useful to give a somewhat more detailed characterization of the content of the religious problem.

In the Protestant world it is fairly generally acknowledged that one must distinguish between knowledge and faith. The Catholic Church does not acknowledge this distinction in its full extent and therefore does not acknowledge any religious problem in the intellectual domain. It maintains that God's existence can be proved by the paths that Thomas Aquinas, supported by Aristotle, pointed out, and it has even declared it a matter of faith to accept that these proofs suffice. The tradition from the great time of the Middle Ages, when "one did not doubt and was therefore nearer to the truth" (to use a sentence from one of Thomas Aquinas's modern biographers), is continually upheld, and it is not acknowledged that a disharmony has really entered into spiritual life. The distinction between knowledge and faith concedes that such a disharmony is present—that the unity of spiritual life is broken. Is this distinction itself then only a station on the way, in that development will lead to an elimination of all religion from spiritual life, because only that can endure which can enter into a harmonious relation with the other elements of life?—Whether one now assumes that it is only the classical time of religion that is past, or that its time is altogether past, the question cannot be set aside whether spiritual value is lost in the process of dissolution that has set in, or whether a replacement can be found for the spiritual unity and self-containment that was lost. This consideration alone shows that the question of the persistence of value is an essential aspect of the religious problem,

whatever solution one inclines toward. It is not least from this side that philosophy in the last century and a half (from the time of Rousseau, Lessing, and Kant onward) has treated the religious problem. Both Romantics and Positivists have been attentive to this aspect of it.—It must of course be remembered that even if one could show that no spiritual energy was lost in the dissolution of religion, it does not follow that the energy would under the new conditions receive as valuable an application as in the classical times of religion. In the spiritual domain no less than in the material, the conservation of energy is not without further ado the same as the persistence of value. Energy can persist without value persisting, while the reverse cannot well be imagined, since energy in and of itself will be a condition for the persistence and development of what is valuable. Many freethinkers proceed without further ado from the assumption that human life will become more powerful and richer when religion falls away—an assumption that is not self-evident and that rests on the presupposition that psychic equivalents are present—equivalents both in terms of value and in terms of energy. The task will then be to demonstrate these equivalents and thereby establish the persistence of value. But it is a great question and an essential aspect of the religious problem whether such equivalents can be demonstrated.—Moreover, the problem of the persistence of value will also arise within the Church, for religion and the religious life undergo constant changes; and the question becomes whether the values from the classical times of religion persist through these changes—e.g., whether primitive Christianity, both in terms of value and in terms of energy, is preserved in the Christianity of our day. In its sharpest form this problem has appeared in the assertion: “the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists.”—

But the religious problem concerns not only the persistence of value within the human world. It raises not only a psychological but also a cosmological question, namely about the relation between that which stands as the highest value for human beings and the whole of existence. Is there any connection between values and the laws and forces of existence? Are these laws and forces perhaps even ultimately determined by the highest values? Or can we perhaps not ascribe any validity to the concept of value beyond the domain of human life?

The hypothesis that will later (in the psychological philosophy of religion) be sought to be grounded holds that the proposition of the persistence of value is the actual religious axiom, which is expressed in different ways in the different religions and at the different religious standpoints. The religious problem thus concerns the question whether this axiom can really be taken to hold. And at the same time this axiom, insofar as it expresses the fundamental thought of all religion, can be used as a standard for the consistency and

significance of the individual religion or the individual religious standpoint. Finally—as already noted—the relation between ethics and religion can, with the help of this axiom, be expressed in a very simple way: how does faith in the persistence of value relate to the work of finding, producing, and preserving values?—

If the proposition of the persistence of value were to be discussed in its full scope, the discussion would become interminable, and clear starting points for conducting it would soon be lacking. I therefore emphasize at once the limits within which my investigation will move, and which must be kept in mind throughout all that follows.—When I attempt to show that the said proposition is the fundamental thought of all religion, this attempt will not have failed because it turns out that no religion expresses the proposition with clarity and consistency. It will be sufficient if an explicit need or tendency to hold fast to this fundamental thought can be demonstrated, so that the standard for the evaluation of religions in their mutual relations becomes the degree to which they are able to articulate and carry through the proposition.—When the persistence of value is spoken of, this could be understood to mean that value does not vanish, but that there is constantly value in existence, whether it decreases or increases or alternates between decrease and increase. But I understand the expression *the persistence of value* in analogy with the expression *the conservation of energy*, such that the proposition asserts a constant persistence of value through all changes of form. It will perhaps be necessary here to distinguish between potential and actual value, just as one distinguishes between potential and actual energy, and the one distinction is just as clear and just as justified as the other.—But the persistence of value through all changes of form and despite the difference between possibility and actuality is nonetheless only a minimum. It may be maintained that the mere persistence of value is not satisfying and actually contains a contradiction, since value can persist only by growing, since mere repetition dulls, while on the other hand change is valuable only when it brings enhancement. That an increase of value does not conflict with the conservation of energy needs no further demonstration; the increase of value presupposes only a new and more perfect application of energy, not an increase of energy as a whole. It is for the sake of simplicity that I limit the investigation to the persistence of value. And it will also turn out that religious consciousness has at bottom limited itself to this as well. The persistence of value will present us with difficulties and tasks enough, even if we do not enter into everything that lies in the unavoidable consequence that value can persist only if it increases. Yet we must not forget that this consequence is present.—Finally, when the persistence of value is under discussion, one might ask: which value and how much value? I enter into these questions only insofar

as the difference between the different religions and religious standpoints essentially depends on the different answers they give to them. It is clear that the proposition of the persistence of value can be accepted whatever answers one gives. The hypothesis that the persistence of value is the fundamental religious proposition is not shaken by the fact that the different religions and religious standpoints diverge greatly from one another with respect to the character and extent of the valuable in whose persistence they believe.

Value is the property of something that it brings about a real satisfaction or can become the means to such. Value can therefore be immediate or mediate. Immediate value we seek to hold fast when it is given, and to produce when it is not given. We thus make it our end. That we make something an end presupposes, conversely, that we have an experience or a supposition of its immediate value. Mediate value belongs to that which serves the attainment of an end—that is, of an immediate value. Mediate value need not be potential value. For what serves as a means for attaining something of immediate value itself acquires value in our eyes, even though its value stands as derived. There are all possible transitions between mediate and immediate value, and through the shifting of motives the former passes over into the latter, so that what at first had value only as a means now acquires value as an end. Potential value, on the other hand, often means only the possibility that something will acquire value as a means—that is, the possibility of mediate value.—Which values are experienced and therefore acknowledged at the different standpoints will depend on the different character of those standpoints. It is a being's nature that determines its need, and it is its need that determines what acquires value for it. The religious axiom thus shows the necessity of a religion's character being determined by the nature and need of the human beings who profess it. For one cannot seriously believe in the persistence of values that one does not know at least approximately from one's own experience.—

Every application of the concept of value presupposes a relation to a whole whose persistence and development require definite conditions. Such wholes are organisms, personalities, societies, and finally the human race. In an individual whole endowed with consciousness (a personality), feelings of pleasure and displeasure, in all their various degrees and forms, appear as symptoms of a need to maintain or to call forth the conditions of the whole's persistence. Here, then, value is known by immediate experience. But by way of analogy the concept of value—and with it the concept of wholeness, which makes rational discussion of values possible—can be applied to all wholes.—A fuller demonstration than can be given here of the significant connection

between the concepts of value and wholeness I have attempted in *Den menneskelige Tanke* (pp. 238–241; 346–349) and in *Totalitet som Kategori*, ch. 5.

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Chapter 2

Epistemological Philosophy of Religion

2.1 Understanding

Ihm ziemt's die Welt im Innern zu bewegen.

GOETHE.

(It befits him to move the world from within.)

4. Against the supposition I have put forward, that the core of religion is faith in the persistence of value, it might seem to tell that theoretical motives have after all played, and still for many play, a considerable role in the development of religious ideas. I have moreover already remarked that since religion in its classical times is everything for the human being, it in such times also satisfies its drive for knowledge—that is, provides it with means for and forms of understanding and explanation of existence. In the classical times of religion there exists no independent drive for knowledge, any more than special means and forms for satisfying such a drive. The distinction between knowledge and faith, between understanding and evaluation, comes forward only in the critical times—that is, in the times when religion has become a problem. This distinction began to make its way only after a number of violent collisions between religion and science. Only reluctantly has one begun, from the religious side, to learn that it is not religion's business to give us a scientific understanding of the world. What all theologians now repeat, that the Bible is not to teach us natural science, no one would hear when Bruno, Galileo, and Spinoza said it. The persecution of heretics ran its course, and only afterwards did one see the rightness of what the heretics had said. In other domains the same conflict

repeats itself; in our days it is the humanities whose independence is at stake.

Every great religion appears in history with a world-view, in that it gathers up within itself, in a distinctive manner, the whole circle of ideas of its time. Christianity, for example, stood in the first centuries as attractive to many by its intellectual content as well. TATIAN thus went over to Christianity because this “philosophy of the barbarians,” as he called it, seemed to him to explain what he had not before understood: “the coming-to-be of the world.” The old apologists stood generally at the standpoint that Christianity contained the best solution to the riddles of thought. When Plato and other Greek philosophers seemed to hint at similar solutions, this was to be explained, according to Justin Martyr, either by their having been influenced by the Israelite prophets, or else by the fact that “the Word” (Logos), before it became flesh, had worked illuminatingly within human beings. In comparison with the earlier religions, Christianity had—as is generally the case with the higher religions in relation to the lower—a certain rational character, and above all a simplicity, a plain grandeur, which could not but work attractively on many who knew only the earlier religions with their motley mythologies. In so far as the world-view given in the biblical writings was not detailed enough, the Church Fathers and the Schoolmen supplemented it by the aid of Greek science.

Just as Christianity does for the western portion of humanity, so Buddhism stands for the eastern portion not merely as a great religion, but as a great world-view, whose ideas have a certain rational character and cannot be understood without acquaintance with the antecedent Indian thought.

When the opposition between religious and scientific understanding of existence is spoken of, the weight is as a rule laid on the fact that science—especially in the domains of astronomy, geology, and biology—has led to results that conflict with religion’s transmitted teachings. A great part of the work of the modern apologists accordingly goes to showing the compatibility of the transmitted religious ideas with those scientific results that really stand firm. Towards modern natural science one applies, with greater or lesser success—and with greater or lesser taste—the same process of accommodation that the apologists of antiquity applied towards Greek science. But for the illumination of the religious problem as a whole, this entire discussion for and against is of slight interest, except perhaps in so far as it furnishes characteristic examples of the accommodation which the life of religious ideas—like everything living—undergoes, or strives to undergo, in the face of new conditions of life. What is the main matter, on the contrary, is that it is two wholly different kinds or types of “understanding” that here stand over against one another. They are two ways of thinking and of explaining events—two ways so

different that once one has begun with the one, one will not be able to find any point at which it is justified and possible to go over to the other. The whole mental condition is so heterogeneous that the word “understanding” is in reality used here in two wholly different senses. Let me take a single example. A sudden storm and tidal flood, which brings about the destruction of many fishermen at sea, is explained in natural-scientific fashion by the states of the air and the sea in the preceding days. But in the funeral oration over the drowned, the “understanding” of what has happened is found in this, that God wished to give the survivors a sign, that they should be converted.¹ At what point in the series of natural causes can one now suppose that this divine intervention has taken place? The natural causes form a connected series, from which no link can be taken out. A choice must be made between the two “understandings.” The one kind of understanding aims, so far as possible, to form connected series of links, each of which can be pointed out in experience. The more the state of the air and the sea at the moment of the catastrophe has been brought into connected sequence with their states in the preceding days, the better—according to the one type of understanding—one is said to understand the catastrophe. According to the other type, it is understood by the value it acquires through its influence on the minds of those who suffer under it, and this value is regarded as intended—as the purpose of a divine intervention.

The scientific type of understanding has developed in a clear and fruitful manner especially in the course of the last three centuries. It does not exclude a religious evaluation, but it excludes a confusion of this evaluation with explanation proper. It is the task of philosophical epistemology to investigate the presuppositions and the forms of thought that lie at the foundation of scientific knowledge, and it will be of philosophy-of-religion interest to bring out these presuppositions and forms of thought and to compare them with the foundation of religious “understanding.” Through this we shall be able to obtain information as to how far religion will still be able to have significance for the satisfaction of our drive for knowledge.

2.1.1 Causal Explanation

5. When one sets up the proposition that every event has its cause—the so-called causal principle—one thereby establishes the principle that existence is intelligible. This proposition can never become more than a hypothesis, since we can never understand everything, never point out causes for all events. But it contains the presupposition with which we involuntarily meet events that awaken our attention; at any rate it is the presupposition that brings us to look about for earlier events when an event has

occurred.

We can here disregard entirely the question of the causal principle's justification and origin, since the mutually divergent conceptions here offered need not acquire any philosophy-of-religion significance. Whether the acknowledgement of this proposition is due to habit or to an inner necessity in our nature, the need to find causes stirs more or less in everyone, and the religious conception bears witness to it as well as the scientific. Indeed, religious ideas have a peculiar epistemological interest precisely in this, that they testify how deeply the need to find causes lies in human nature, since it expresses itself even there where no independent scientific interest has yet arisen. The opposition between religion and science comes forward only when regard is had to the *character* of the causes one acknowledges as right, real causes (*veræ causæ*). *Both religious and scientific understanding are a leading back of the unknown to the known; the difference between them rests on what this known is.*

Scientific understanding requires that the cause of an event be demonstrated in events that themselves establish themselves in experience just as well as the event to be explained. The task here becomes to interpret the series of events by finding as many individual links in this series, and as close a connection between them, as possible. The aim is to interpret nature by nature itself, just as one interprets a passage in a book by comparing it with other passages in the same book. Religious understanding does not make the demand that the cause should stand in continuous connection with the effect and itself be demonstrated as an experience just as well as the event to be explained. It does not investigate its causes in the critical manner that science does. It does not explain nature by nature itself, but by something that is different from or stands outside nature, that "pushes in from without." Thus, at any rate, religious understanding most frequently appears in history. In contrast to this religious understanding, the special form that empirical science—in both the mental and the material domains—gives to the causal principle can be designated as *the principle of natural causes*. If it cannot be applied, we understand nothing, when it is the scientific type of understanding and the corresponding intellectual habit that prevail in us.

Only the principle of natural causes satisfies the need for a special explanation of the particular, determinate event. Galileo thus showed that in the debate between the different contending astronomical hypotheses it could be of no use to appeal to God's intervention, since for God's omnipotence it is just as easy to let the sun move round the earth as to let the earth move round the sun. This cause therefore cannot help us to a choice between the hypotheses. It is a key that unlocks everywhere; but it is not such a

master key that science seeks; science's interest is to investigate the peculiar character of the different locks, and it therefore demands a key of its own for every lock. If a master key were sufficient, the difference of the locks would become meaningless—and would contain an unsolved problem!—To appeal to God's will gives no scientific understanding, but is—scientifically regarded—an admission that one does not understand the event.

The deepest justification for the principle of natural causes I find in a need for continuity, which lies in the nature of our consciousness and which already shows itself in the general need to find causes. Our consciousness strives involuntarily to gather up and hold together its elements and to preserve unity with itself, even when it stands before a new content. This new content it then strives to shape, alter, and arrange, so that the new shows itself to be a new form of something old. Self-recognition then becomes possible in spite of the shifting of content, and the unity of the personal life mirrors itself in the continuity thereby brought about. The work of knowledge is here closely bound up with the work on the development of character. We speak of a character—in the pronounced sense—only where unity and continuity prevail in the whole striving, and where there is not again and again a leaping over to something new. In analogy with this, knowledge seeks to find as much unity and continuity as possible, to exhibit the new as a transformation or continuation of the old; and only where this succeeds is a full appropriation and understanding won. The principle of natural causes, which leads one to build series as long and as continuous as possible, is therefore no accident, but is closely bound up with the very nature of personality. It is therefore incorrect when personality and science are set in sharp opposition to one another. Scientific work is a work of personality. And the more this work succeeds, the more does causal explanation approach grounding and recognition. The differences in existence are reduced to the least possible when we survey, at a single glance, “under the form of eternity,” great regions of existence.

Religious understanding too—in the mythical and dogmatic forms in which it most frequently appears in history—leads the unknown back to the known. But this known is here as a rule the will of one or more personal beings. The religious consciousness supposes itself to know what the divine will aims at, and recognizes in events the expression of this will. Its interest is not to find an inner connection among events themselves, but to see all events (in the whole of nature, or in some single domain) as the expression of one and the same power. It places itself at the centre, or supposes itself to be at the centre, and from there it surveys the whole circle of existence.

The difficulty for the religious conception here becomes this, that the radius with

which this circle is described is not known. From one and the same centre many different circles can be described. Therefore every “central” consideration (as it has moreover been attempted not only on religious presuppositions, but also in speculative philosophical form) will be powerless with respect to the understanding of the special events. A theological or speculative epistemology will therefore not be able to be carried through. There do not even exist serious attempts at one; but we must hold to the epistemology that empirical and critical philosophy has developed on the basis of the history of empirical science.

6. When the scientific type of understanding has begun to prevail, but is excluded at certain selected points where religious understanding still claims dominion, there arises the bastard concept called wonder, *miracle*. The miracle presupposes that both types make themselves felt, but that there is a leap over from the one type to the other. Where either a certain degree of scientific understanding or of knowledge is not present, the miracle can only mean a deviation from the accustomed. The natural man wonders when the hitherto unseen or unheard-of happens. But the miracle proper presupposes a certain knowledge of natural laws—a continuity that is broken—a rule from which an exception is made. Miracles must therefore occur according to the law of parsimony; if they come so frequently that they become the rule, they form a continuous connection, and the concept of miracle is abolished.

If one does not set up the principle of natural causes in a wholly dogmatic manner, one cannot maintain in advance the impossibility of miracles. But the decisive thing is here again the way the problem is posed and the intellectual habit. For him who asks and sets up his problems according to the scientific type, for him a miracle can never come to be. He may come to stand before something he cannot explain, since no cause (in the sense in which he speaks of cause) can be found, or at any rate has hitherto been found. But he can never discover that there is no natural cause. The religious consciousness itself cannot—without ascribing omniscience to itself—maintain that an event *cannot* be explained according to natural laws. To know that something falls outside the laws of nature, one must know them all and know all possible special applications of them. Only by a revelation could one come to know that in the particular case a miracle is present. It is not the miracle that confirms the revelation, but the revelation that decides what is a miracle. And since a revelation is itself a miracle, one can only by a miracle come to know whether a miracle has happened.—It is consistent when the Catholic Church, which decides what is revelation, also demands to decide what is a miracle and what is not. Nothing may be taken for a miracle unless it is sanctioned as such by “apostolic and

ordained authority.”²

In the case of miracles of which one is not oneself an eyewitness, the question will particularly be whether the report is so securely transmitted, and whether the eyewitness has been so keen an observer, that one will sooner be able to assume a deviation from the laws of nature than an error in transmission and observation. A report that does not derive from an observer who has sufficient acquaintance with the natural conditions and natural laws in question has no scientific significance.

7. The preceding consideration rested on the scientific concept of cause, according to which an event is understood by being seen in its inner connection with other events, as a continuation of them or as a transformation into new form of their content. The presupposition of all such causal explanation is a principle of unity that makes connection possible. We reach this principle by analysis of the very concept of causal connection or reciprocal action. It is the bond that holds existence together and makes it a whole, more than a chaos of elements—even if it is a whole we cannot survey.

The principle of unity at which we have thus arrived recalls the concept of God. But the customary line of thought often reaches its concept of God by another road: not by going back to the presupposition of the causal series, to the principle that makes such a series possible at all, but by continuing the causal series backwards to a “first cause.” By virtue of this line of thought one will say, in the face of the preceding development: “Religion gladly leaves it to science—a few supernatural events excepted—to find the finite causes and to spin out the causal series as far as possible. The causes that science can find are nevertheless always subordinate, derived causes (*causæ secundæ*). What religion maintains is that existence becomes meaningless if we do not at last find the origin of the whole causal series in a first cause, an absolute cause, in which thought finds rest—where all further questioning falls away—and from which the full, clear light streams out over everything.”

This line of thought stems from ARISTOTLE and is taken up by THOMAS AQUINAS, on whose authority it is still espoused by Catholic theology,³ as well as by many Protestant theologians. It is the so-called cosmological proof of God’s existence—the most important of all “proofs”—that we here stand before.

That the series of causes must be limited is inferred from the consideration that otherwise no complete explanation of any link whatever in the series of events would have been reached. “If there is no first,” says ARISTOTLE, “there is no cause at all.” It is thus the condition of existence’s intelligibility that one here supposes oneself to be relying on. It is a rationalistic tendency that lies at the foundation of this theological

line of thought. Existence must be comprehensible!—that is the underlying postulate. Aristotle does not, however, assume that the first cause began to work at a definite point of time, so that “the world” has a beginning. And Thomas also concedes that it is only by the way of faith that one comes to assume that the world has a beginning (*mundum incepisse, sola fide tenetur*).

KANT has subjected this proof to a criticism that leads him to the result that it rests on “a false self-satisfaction of human reason.” In the main his criticism stands in force to this very day. In what follows I make use in part of his objections, adding to them some other misgivings.

Even if we could build a connected causal series, at what point should we then break off our search for finite causes in order to hang the whole chain on a “first cause”—as Zeus in Homer threatens to hang the whole world on a peak of Mount Olympus? What mark can we have that we are at the “next to first” cause, so that we must now set about making the decisive leap?—And why should the causal series not be able to be infinite? That an infinite series is unthinkable is a dogmatic assertion. There can be series which, by virtue of the law that holds for the relation between their links, can always be continued. Such series we think—not by running through all the links, which is of course impossible—but by thinking the law of their connection. Such a series is the causal series. It is built by virtue of the causal principle, which says that everything that happens has its cause. This proposition must—if it is accepted at all—also be accepted as holding for every single link in the series, for the “first” one has gone back to as well as for all the others. The assumption of an absolutely first cause would thus conflict with the causal principle—although it was precisely to be justified by existence’s absolute intelligibility, and so by the causal principle!—

Popular theology will especially hold to the form of the cosmological proof that runs thus: “Since everything has its cause, the world too must have its cause.” One operates here with the concept “world” without noticing that it contains the same or similar difficulties as those that just showed themselves in the concept of God. If by “world” one understands the sum total of all that exists, or at any rate of all “finite” existing things, then it is a concept that can never be completed. The given is never completed; new experiences are always coming in, which make new conceptual determinations necessary. We therefore never come, by the road of scientific inquiry, to a point at which there could be a question of a cause of “the whole world.” The given constitutes a whole, which we analyse in order to find its laws and its elements; but every given whole points over to other wholes; we seek to work all given wholes together into a still higher whole;

but however far this work be continued, the same task will always present itself anew. There is here a series of like kind with the causal series—a series that by virtue of its own law cannot be completed. The concept “world” is therefore properly a false concept, though one operates with it so briskly, plays with it as with a ball.

2.1.2 The World of Space

8. When the religious consciousness historically shows a tendency to limit the series of causes, this is in part to be explained by the need for intuitive vividness. The religious consciousness wants a vivid image of its object, and such an image presupposes limitation. With this in turn hangs together its tendency to refer the divine to definite places in space. Spatial ideas are our clearest ideas, and what we wish to represent clearly we therefore seek to shape into spatial images or schemata. With this there naturally combines the idea that everything that exists must belong at a definite place in the world, must be localized. What is not at some definite place seems, to the childlike conception, which is decidedly realistic, not to be at all. Just as, with respect to the explanation of the world, it would be the simplest thing if we could come upon the deity by following the series of causes link by link, so also, with respect to the conception of the world, it would be the simplest thing if the human being needed only to lift his eyes upward to find the deity, or at any rate could behold its dwelling.

Antiquity's conception of the world met this need. For it the world was limited. The earth stood at the world's centre, and the vault of heaven, which was not thought to be extraordinarily far off, formed the world's outermost boundary. The bright sky has, especially for the Indo-Germanic peoples, been regarded as deity or as the seat of the deity. The stem from which many of the Indo-Germanic languages form their word for “God” properly denotes sky or heavenly. Thus the Indian *devas*, the Persian *deva*, the Greek Ζεύς (Δίος), the Latin *deus*, and so on. Herodotus says of the Persians that they call the sky Zeus, and with this agrees the fact that the natural background of the god Ahura Mazda (Ormuzd) is assumed by the more recent history of religion to be the sky. The Greeks supposed, indeed, in the oldest time, that the gods dwelt more particularly on Mount Olympus, but later thought of the sky or “the aether” as their dwelling. Aristotle says: “All human beings assume that there are gods, and all, both barbarians and Hellenes, assign to the deity the uppermost place.” The opposition between heaven and earth thus became quite naturally, for antiquity, one with the opposition between the divine and the human, between the eternal and the changeable, between the perfect and the imperfect. The expressions “the higher” and “the lower” had originally a literal meaning;

the symbolic meaning is here, as everywhere, the later one. Aristotle's incorporation of antiquity's astronomical conception into his system became of decisive importance. Since both this conception and his whole system seemed to be compatible with the biblical circle of ideas, and capable of serving for the further working-out of it, they were taken up by ecclesiastical theology and through it became dominant right into the modern age.

Among the Jewish people too we meet with the great religious significance of the opposition between heaven and earth. In the opinion of some, Jahveh was originally a thunder-god; at any rate he reveals himself with special majesty in the heavenly phenomena. Heaven is his seat, and the earth his footstool. The New Testament conception stands here entirely on the ground of the Old. There is sometimes talk of several heavens (2 Corinthians XII, 2; Ephesians IV, 10), and God's dwelling is then the heavenly holy of holies, which is above all the heavens. Accounts such as that of Jesus's visible ascension and of Paul's rapture to the third heaven testify that the ancient picture of the world is presupposed. As these accounts stand, they are plainly to be taken literally, though the more recent theology (even the orthodox) is on this point inclined to apply the rationalistic explanation.

There was both vividness and security in the narrow frame within which the picture of the world thus presented itself. Without being disturbed and disquieted by infinite distances, the religious consciousness could give itself wholly to the great experiences of life and regard the all-decisive process of redemption—resolved on in heaven and accomplished on earth—as that about which the whole outer life of the world also turned. There was as it were a ladder between heaven and earth; the two worlds, the world of the highest value and the world of contending values, stood in vivid reciprocal action. Poets like Homer and Dante are testimony to what foothold and what support the limited picture of the world afforded the human imagination.

But within the religious consciousness itself there shows itself, at a somewhat higher stage of development, an opposite tendency, which at the cost of vividness aims at abolishing the localization of the content of religious ideas. It came to appear an imperfection that the deity should really have its dwelling at a definite place, so that it must either move through space in order to come to the human being, or the human being must travel long roads to meet his God. God must be omnipresent and all-embracing if he is not to be limited and imperfect, as a human being is. However short the distance between heaven and earth was thought to be, it nevertheless became too long for the religious need. The deity had to stand in a far more intimate relation to the human being

than localization at definite places made possible.

In the biblical writings and among the ecclesiastical theologians we find, then, a double current. Vividness is held fast; but where it is the inwardness of feeling, rather than the imagination's need for intuition, that leads the word, there the significance of the spatial relation is abolished. God dwells in heaven—but he is truly not far from us, for in him we are and live and move. Jesus ascends to heaven and shall come thence again—but he lives in believers and is with them all their days.

The religious conception has here, in its classical times, a *Both—And*, which later is gradually replaced by an *Either—Or*.

9. What made it possible for the theologians of earlier times to hold fast to this Both—And was the bold use they made of allegorical or symbolic interpretation. An allegorical interpretation did not, according to their conception, exclude the literal meaning. The relation between the two remained in a certain indeterminacy, which not seldom could lead to violent collisions. "There was lacking," says ADOLF HARNACK in his history of dogma, "a definite rule for how far the letter of Holy Scripture should hold. Has God human shape, has he eyes, has he a voice, does Paradise lie on the earth, do the dead rise with all their limbs, with hair too, and so on?—to all these questions and a hundred like them no certain answer was given, and therefore there was strife between the adherents of one and the same confession. Allegorize all had to, but all had on the other hand also to take certain passages of Scripture literally. But what a difference there was between an Epiphanius and a Gregory of Nyssa, and how many nuances there were between the crude anthropomorphists and the spiritualists! These last for the most part feared the arguments of the former, often also their fists, and they had to be anxious about their own orthodoxy."⁴

AUGUSTINE is certainly the one who has contributed most to displacing the merely literal conception. His Platonic studies have here had decisive influence and have—in conjunction with his profound and strongly agitated inner life—led him to a clearer view of the difference between the spiritual and the material, and thereby led him to utter thoughts in which he stands as the precursor of Descartes and Kant. What in this connection especially interests us is his rejection of all spatial determinations as invalid for the divine. Where he speaks of his own earlier conception, he says: "I did not know that God is a spirit that has no limbs with length and breadth, any more than bodily mass (*moles*). The bodily (*moles*) is less in a part than in the whole, and if it is infinite, it is less in a limited part than in the infinite, and it is not everywhere as a whole (*tota ubiqve*), as God is." "God is present in his wholeness everywhere, and is yet nowhere in

place (*ubique totus, et nusquam locorum*)!" "God dwells further within my being than my own inmost self, and he is more exalted than the highest I can reach (*interior intimo meo, superior summo meo*). "God stands above my soul, but not in the same way as heaven stands above the earth."⁵

When thoughts such as these were appropriated and carried through, they had to lead to strife with the old picture of the world and its childlike opposition between heaven and earth. The Schoolmen of the Middle Ages held fast to the immaterial concept of God, independent of spatial determinations, and from them it passed over to the Mystics, who besides were influenced by Neoplatonic thoughts.—"Lord," Suso's female disciple asks him, "where is God?" The answer runs: "The masters say: God has no Where.... God is a circle whose centre is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere."⁶ Thus, through inner contradiction, the validity of the spatial relation is abolished.

Towards accounts such as that of the visible ascension one took up in the Middle Ages this position: that one held fast that the events reported had taken place as they were described, but that they had a spiritual meaning which was the essential thing. HUGH OF ST. VICTOR explains that by "the highest" is meant the inmost in us, and that ascending to God means that we sink ourselves into ourselves and there find something that is "higher" than ourselves. But he will not therefore deny that heaven and hell are definite places in the world. His contemporary ABELARD maintains (in his remarkable "Dialogue between a Philosopher, a Jew, and a Christian") that what is said of God in bodily form is to be understood—not, as the common man understands it, bodily and literally—but mystically and allegorically. By heaven's exaltation above the earth is meant rather the exalted character (*sublimitas*) of the life to come than the situation of the material heaven, and that Jesus sits at God's right hand denotes not a spatial position (*localis positio*), but equality of dignity (*æqualis dignitas*). Jesus's ascension has indeed taken place bodily as it is reported, but it denotes nevertheless "a nobler kind of ascent" (*melior ascensus*), namely that which takes place in the souls of believers. Unlearned and simple people would not understand what is not presented in vivid form.⁷

The characteristic Both—And here comes clearly forward. It had its great advantages in a pedagogical respect, since one did not need to make any sharp distinction between idea and reality, symbol and truth. With his bodily eyes the human being could look up to heaven, the seat of power and grace, but the same heaven he had in the inner states in which the divine made known its authority and bestowed its consolation. The evangelical narratives could be taken according to the letter and yet at the same time be interpreted spiritually and edifyingly. The absolute differences of place in the world of

space appeared immediately as the expression of differences of value.

10. There came, however, the time when one had to choose. There arose a conflict between an idealistic conception, which inculcates the purely spiritual significance of religious ideas, and a realistic or materialistic conception, which held to vividness and literalness. Such a conflict is known in many religions. In the *Upanishads*, the idealistic interpretation of the Vedic religion, it is said that Bráhma, the deity, is imperishable, while “name, place, time, and body” perish, wherefore none of these determinations holds for Bráhma. In Xenophanes’s and Plato’s criticism of the Greek popular faith a similar tendency shows itself. Within Mohammedanism it comes forward when, for example, the sensuous and vivid depiction of the joys of Paradise is interpreted allegorically as a presentation of spiritual enjoyments.⁸

When it began to dawn on thought that there are no absolute determinations of place, since every place is determined by its relation to other places, these again by their relation to others, and so forth, the old picture of the world was moving towards its dissolution. It went with the series of places as it went with the series of causes; one could not get the series absolutely completed, so that the picture could be bounded. And when now Copernicus showed that the simplest picture of the world was obtained by thinking of the earth as moving round the sun, so that it was no longer the world’s centre, there fell away the clear and secure frame within which the content of religious ideas had hitherto been able to be localized. It was besides soon shown—by Giordano Bruno—that it was inconsistent to hold fast to the limitation of “the world” when one accepted the relativity of all determinations of place and the Copernican astronomy. An infinite horizon opened.⁹ The difference between heaven and earth fell away, and an Either—Or had to replace the earlier Both—And: only the idealistic meaning of the word “heaven” was now tenable, if this word was to express a religious idea.

To this there now came also another movement of thought. Just as one had hitherto found spiritual differences of value expressed in a vivid way by spatial distances, so one had generally made no sharp difference between the spiritual and the material. With the beginning of natural science this difference came forward more clearly, and it came—with Kepler and Descartes—to stand as a chief mark of the material that it is extended in space. It had now to become a special problem, not merely how the spiritual and the material stand related to one another, but also whether the spiritual world is as comprehensive as the material world, according to the new picture of the world, showed itself to be. The security with which one had hitherto been able to find spiritual things expressed in material forms was quite particularly shaken by this. Formerly one had

been able literally to see “spirits”; after the Cartesian reform of psychology this was no longer possible. The spiritual world came to stand in opposition to the world of space, of extension, and of vividness, however one might think of the inner relation between them. Everything vivid could now at last, that is to say, from a religious point of view, acquire only symbolic significance.

But it was easier for philosophy than for theology to draw this consequence. With thinkers like Bruno and Spinoza the religious ideas underwent an inwardization and an infinitization that corresponded to the new conception of the world and carried further what Augustine and the Mystics had already hinted at. After long resistance and misgiving, theology began to strike into the same road. And often we now see the assertion put forward that the idealistic meaning of such expressions as “heaven” (or “hell,” and so on) is the only valid one, and the only one that the Bible and the Church have ever approved. CARDINAL NEWMAN declares, for example, that the Council of Trent does not teach that Purgatory causes sensuous pain, though he concedes that this was the Latin Church’s tradition, and that he himself has seen in the streets of Naples paintings that represented souls burning in Purgatory. But in an ecclesiastically sanctioned handbook on the doctrine of Purgatory the question is raised: “Is the flame of Purgatory really a bodily flame?” And to this it is said: “Cardinal Bellarmine answers that the general opinion of theologians is that the flame of Purgatory is a true and real flame, of the same kind as our earthly fire.” And it is added that the great majority of Church Fathers, Schoolmen, and theologians teach that Purgatory, like hell, is found at the earth’s centre, and that this doctrine is built on Holy Scripture and has always been maintained by the Church.¹⁰—Here idealism and realism stand sharply over against one another. One may by particular distinctions seek to veil the breach in spiritual development that let an Either—Or replace a Both—And (just as this had in its time replaced the immediate, childlike localization); but history will always bring it forth anew, and it is of the very greatest importance for the right understanding of the religious problem that it not be forgotten.

By the Copernican and the Cartesian reform there have been drawn more definite boundaries than could be drawn before, between thought and intuition, reality and symbolism. The philosophy-of-religion significance of this is easy to see. Of quite special significance is the expansion of the world, the infinite horizons that the material world has gained, and in relation to which the spiritual world now seems to be so limited. How will one—the question arose naturally—now be able to hold fast to the conviction that spiritual values are the highest thing in existence, that about which everything turns?

Now the outer world no longer turns about the home of the only spiritual life we know from experience!—There arose an opposition between psychology and cosmology which the past did not know. Great spirits like JACOB BÖHME and BLAISE PASCAL felt keenly the problem that lay in this, and which in religion's classical times could not be posed.—It is not, however, only for positive religion that a great, perhaps insoluble problem is here posed. For every view of life the same problem must present itself in one form or another. Naturally there are problems at all only for those who have not from indolence or anxiety given up thinking. To the problem itself we shall later return.

2.1.3 The Course of Time

11. The need for intuitive vividness makes itself felt with respect to time as well, and here too it leads to a shortening and a closing-off of the ideas. In this respect, however, we meet with one of the most significant differences that the history of religion anywhere exhibits, in that the idea of a completed course of time has no significance for so religious a people as the Indians, whereas in the faith of Zarathustra and in Christianity it is of quite decisive significance. For the Indians, time was only resultless movement, change and unrest, from which it was a matter of freeing oneself. Historical development therefore acquired no value; the abolition of temporal existence by the attainment of "Nirvana" was the highest thing. A similar trait is found in Greek thought; Plato's doctrine of ideas especially is a classical example of it: true reality is the unchangeable, that which always is what it is; the changeable phenomena of the world of experience, caught up in becoming, are at last only appearance. In the Zarathustra faith of the Iranians, on the other hand, the development of the world stands as a historical process which through a comparatively short span of time (12,000 years) reaches its conclusion, when the great struggle between good and evil—in nature, in human life, and in the world of spirits—has been carried to its end. Here the idea of a world-history in the literal sense of the word appears. All human work and all human conduct of life thereby come to stand in a mighty, cosmic illumination. The course of time, surveyable by the imagination, exercises a concentrating influence on the minds of human beings. There stands a goal before thought, towards which all striving is directed, and the human being stands as the fellow-worker of the gods. How and where this faith in the significance of history first arose is uncertain. It is not certain that it is of Indo-Germanic origin; possibly it is due to influences from the Semitic or pre-Semitic side.¹¹ It is likewise uncertain how far this faith came from the Persians to post-exilic Judaism and through this to Christianity. But the Zarathustra faith stands at any rate as the first great popular religion in which the

idea of life as historical development towards a goal determines the whole conception. The courage of human beings is strengthened in the struggle of life by the great visions of the future, by the thought of a kingdom that is to come and that is to be consummated through a judgment of the world.

In the New Testament this conception prevails in a pronounced way especially in the three first Gospels, in the Pauline epistles, and in the Revelation of John. In the Gospel of John the weight is laid with great emphasis on the point that eternal life is not merely a future but an already present life. He who believes has already passed over from death to life. The judgment, the decision, is first and foremost an inner one; the outer, future decision comes rather to stand as a concluding consequence. With respect to this idealism, which already in the present sees the ideal realized, there is indeed only a difference of degree between the various New Testament writings; but this difference of degree is of great significance; it grounds two different types of doctrine, and it is a psychological and literary-historical riddle that both the writing ("the Revelation of John") in which the consummation of "the kingdom" is most depicted as future, and the one ("the Gospel of John") in which its ideal presence is most profoundly maintained, could in tradition be ascribed to one and the same author. The opposition comes forward in the New Testament all the more strongly because the conclusion and the judgment were expected within the then living generation, whereby the tension between present and future had to be sharpened, and the living, forward-directed expectation came to form a stronger contrast to the inner possession.

In the Zarathustra faith the idealistic conception does not—presumably on account of the sober and practical character of the Iranians—come forward so clearly. But in the New Testament there appears on this point—as with respect to space—a characteristic Both—And. And here there is greater possibility that a Both—And can be maintained. For there is in itself no contradiction in the ideal's having taken root and so far being already present, and its being successively unfolded in its whole extent. The question—a question we shall later come back to—is whether such a longer successive unfolding is foreseen and taught in the New Testament. It is, according to the New Testament conception, only a short time that is to elapse before the conclusion, and it is generally a comparatively short time that lies between the creation and the judgment. The whole course of time lies between these two fixed points; in the interval the great religious events find their place, and the whole time rounds itself off into a natural whole for the imagination. There is a beginning, and there is an end, and there is no dizzying distance between them.—But when the two fixed points of support are taken away—when it is

asked what was before the “beginning” and what will be after the “end”—vividness is abolished, and there easily sets in a dizziness, just as when it dawns on consciousness that space can have no absolute boundaries.

12. It follows from the very concept of time that every moment must lie between two other moments. Thus neither a first nor a last moment can be thought. Just as the causal principle must find application to every link in the causal series, and the spatial relation hold for every place in space, so must the temporal relation too hold for every link in the temporal series. Every course of time that we represent to ourselves—the one from “the creation” to “the judgment” as well—can then only be a wave in time’s great, unsurveyable sea. A completed course of time means a period that is filled out by the realization of a certain result, a certain goal. It is the content that makes time be divided into periods. But the temporal relation spreads itself, by virtue of its own inner law, out beyond the “beginning” and the “end”; and if our thoughts can give no content, and therefore no division into periods, beyond the points of support that have hitherto stood fast for us, then we end at any rate with a question, a problem, just as with the series of causes and of determinations of place.

That the religious consciousness finds an imperfection in the temporal relation is easily intelligible. The misfortune of development in time is always more or less this, that the one period of life comes to stand as a mere means for the other. Means and end are separated, and life is divided between joyless labour and idle enjoyment. Just as little as any individual human being ought to be made a mere means for other human beings, just as little ought single moments within a human being’s life to be mere means for other moments, past and present mere means for the future. This can be avoided if the work and the development themselves acquire immediate value and can thereby themselves become the end or a part of the end. The child is then not merely a future grown human being; childhood becomes an independent period of life with its own peculiar tasks and its own distinctive value. And so must every period of life, every part of the course of time, be conceived. In this way it becomes possible “in the midst of time to live in eternity,” without falling into mystical contemplation. What is external in the differences of time thereby falls away. “Eternity” then stands not as time’s continuation or as a distant time, but as the expression of the continuity of the valuable through the changes of the times. It then becomes possible to look time’s incompleteness and infinity in the face without becoming dizzy and without receiving the impression of the restless and the purposeless. As with causal explanation and with the world of space, the only possible solution of the difficulties in the case of the temporal relation lies in the

direction of an inwardizing conception. It is the inner law and the valuable content, not the external differences, on which the weight must at last be laid. And here is something that can subsist independently of the limited frame to which the religious consciousness, in its mythical and dogmatic forms, is inclined to cling.

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2.2 Concluding Thoughts

By speculative philosophy one obtains not so much answers to the questions that common human understanding poses, as one comes to recognize that the questions themselves, being founded on concepts that have no truth, must fall away.

POUL MØLLER.

13. The final presupposition of the scientific understanding of existence is, as I have sought to show, a principle of unity that lies at the foundation of all connection in the course of time, in spatial extension, and in the causal series. Can thought now give a closer determination of, a concluding conceptual form for, this principle of unity? This question is all the more important because in the reference to a principle of unity there might seem to be a possibility of a connection between the religious and the scientific conception of existence.

We are all compelled to bring our knowledge to a close. There are points at which we in fact cannot get further. But this closing-off may be due to purely factual circumstances. The one grows tired before the other, or the one has not so many intellectual requirements as the other. The closing-off is here different for different individuals, for different ages, different peoples. It may be limitation in time and space that hinders knowledge from getting sufficient material. It is not that kind of closing-off I here ask about; I ask rather about a closing-off that does not rest on special, individual, or historical circumstances, but on the laws of thought itself.

The principle of unity is the necessary presupposition of existence's intelligibility. And since the fact that existence is within certain limits intelligible must be assumed to hang together with existence's own nature, we have a right to speak of a force or a power which brings it about that everything that exists, and everything that happens, stands in inner connection, is held together in a relation of continuity. If one defines God as the principle of existence's intelligibility, and therefore again as the principle of existence's

unity, then there seems here to be a possibility of a concept of God harmoniously compatible with scientific knowledge. In the ideas of God of the popular religions there enters—at any rate at the higher stages—this determination as a more or less prominent element. But it must be well noted that in the formation of religious concepts quite other interests than the purely theoretical and intellectual are at work. Every religious standpoint gathers up in its concept of God the highest valuable thing it knows. Ethical and aesthetic interests, but besides and above all the enthusiasm or feeling of dependence awakened during the struggle of life, drive the ideas forward to the most inward and highest concentration, which finds vent in the exclamation: God!—The religious problem arises only through a spiritual division of labour, by which in particular the intellectual interest is separated from the other interests and seeks its satisfaction by the development of special paths and forms of thought.

It is then no wonder that scientific and religious formations of concepts do not correspond to one another. The philosophical and the religious language do not stand related to one another in such a way that one could without more ado translate a thought from the one language into the other, or find, for a concept formed in the one domain, an entirely corresponding concept in the other.

Not only for the philosophical consciousness, but for the religious consciousness too, the great problem of the relation between unity and multiplicity presents itself. But while philosophical thought holds to unity as the necessary presupposition of the law-governed connection between the manifold elements, the religious consciousness in its mythical and dogmatic forms has a tendency to place unity and multiplicity in an external relation of opposition to one another, as though they were two different beings or powers. It thus forms two different concluding concepts, and it calls them: God and the world; the world is thought as a unity, in that all the multiplicity is gathered into a whole. Towards this formation of concepts philosophical thought stands in such a way that it finds one and the same difficulty in both these concepts, and therefore cannot see anything but that all that has been achieved is that the problem has been doubled; indeed there arises thereby into the bargain a third problem, in the relation of the two beings or powers to one another. If it is so, as I shall now try to show, this becomes of great importance for religious discussion. For from it follows that, because a thinker rejects the religious concept of God, one has no right to presuppose that he merely believes in what in religious language is called “the world.” The concept “world” contains philosophical difficulties similar to those the concept “God” contains, when it is to be absolutely concluding. And often it is the case that thinkers who are regarded as

atheists reject the current concept of “the world” rather than the concept of God. This holds of philosophers like Spinoza and Fichte.¹²—Polemical fanaticism naturally does not let itself be corrected, however often this state of affairs be pointed out.

If God and the world are regarded as two different beings or powers, then they must limit one another. The one ceases where the other begins. The clockmaker and the clock he has made are two different things; in a similar external relation the customary conception places God and the world. But then God cannot be an infinite being. “The world” with its laws and forces is the deity’s barrier. It is properly a polytheistic conception that arises in this way; “the world”—as different from “God”—properly becomes itself a god, and a certain personification of the world then also appears involuntarily, even within views that with great pomp proclaim themselves monotheistic.

14. The concept “world” is, as already remarked earlier, not a legitimate formation of concepts. If this concept is to denote a whole, a law-bound totality, then it is an ideal towards which inquiry steers, but which on account of the inexhaustibility of experience it will never be able completely to satisfy. Our thought is always spelling out what reality is. The mark by which a distinction can be drawn between merely subjective idea and objective reality is the law-governed connection that can be pointed out among the given phenomena. But partly there are always arising new phenomena as links in experience, and partly there show themselves to obtain, among the phenomena already given, far more complicated and mysterious relations of connection than we could at first suppose. We therefore never finish applying our criterion of reality, and the concept of reality therefore becomes an ideal concept.¹³ From the religious side one has as a rule not the patience to be content with the progressive work into which this ideal leads inquiry, namely to find ever deeper connection among ever more phenomena. One breaks off the work and regards the structure as completed. The concept “world” is therefore the expression of a half-thought. At the lowest stage of religious development this concept is not yet found. The idea of a cosmos, an ordered whole of existing things, presupposes a certain degree of thought. By a precipitate closing-off there has then been formed the pseudo-concept of an absolute whole, and after it had been introduced into religious language it has figured there ever since, as though it were a good and defensible concept.

But let us for a moment acknowledge this formation of concepts. The question then becomes that of the relation between the two beings or powers. Everywhere where there is a causal relation there must—as we have seen in what precedes—be presupposed a principle that conditions the connection between the links. If there is nothing that brings them into connection, the causal relation is unintelligible. This must hold also for

the causal relation between God and the world. But then the bond, the principle of unity, which makes their mutual relation possible, would itself be the real deity—or, if one prefers, the real world would then consist of God + “the world,” that is, of the whole that the two together form. We then come again into an incompletable series—a sign that one has been at the last thought we can really form, but has gone past it. This last valid thought is the principle of unity, the principle of conformity to law in existence. If one does not heed it, it avenges itself by reporting again—like the goblin who moves with you—every time one supposes oneself to have made an advance. There is something teasing about all limit-concepts, which comes out especially when one wants in an external manner to tie a knot in the thread of thought instead of holding to the inner connection that makes the thread a thread. Only if there could be given us from the theological side a wholly different epistemology from the one we must now work with would this teasing quality of our limit-concepts possibly be able to fall away. As it is, it follows us right up into the highest theological and metaphysical speculations. Plato already has (in the dialogue *Parmenides*) seen in this teasing quality a difficulty for his doctrine of ideas: if it is the ideas that lie at the foundation of sensible things, then there arises a new question with respect to the relation between the ideas and the things; this relation too must have its idea, and so forth. With Spinoza and Lotze the problem comes forward in the relation between substance and the individual beings (*modi*). I cannot see that theology, by its doctrine of God and the world, helps us beyond this difficulty of principle, which epistemologically is an indirect proof that we stand at a limit-concept. In the principle of unity we have a thought that is concluding *for us*, but at the same time a thought that demands ever new applications in incompletable series and series of series. One is deceived if one would find the concluding thing as a link in a series, instead of in the principle of series-formation itself.

The possibility cannot be dismissed that the incompletable of experience and of knowledge hangs together with the fact that existence itself is not finished, but is in constant development. One easily forgets that experience and knowledge themselves also belong to existence. When we speak of knowing existence, it properly means that the whole of existence is to be expressed by a single part of it or a single side of it. So long as this task is not solved, existence itself as a whole is not finished. And conversely, if existence itself is not finished, our knowledge cannot be finished either. Besides: to know the relation between the part or side of existence we call knowledge, and the rest of existence or existence as a whole, there would be needed a new knowledge—and so forth. Seen from this side too, the problem presents itself ever anew.

It is on the whole a fundamental law for all our concepts that they express relations, and that every concept presupposes a relation to other concepts. It is the inner law of all movement of thought. From this law, which may be called the law of relation, it follows that no concept can be formed of anything that does not stand in relation to something else. All movement of thought consists in pointing out likeness or difference, in finding ground or consequence, in deriving cause or effect. But likeness and difference, ground and consequence, cause and effect find application only where different links can be placed together in mutual relation.¹⁴

Every formation of a concept is a limitation, which is again abolished when thought reflects on the larger connection out of which it has taken that which is gathered up in the concept—and without which the concept's content could not be determined. The law of relation itself testifies to thought's unity, in that different terms of a relation are gathered up in one concept. But it testifies also to thought's constant limitation, since besides the terms that are gathered up in the single concept there are always presupposed other terms, whose closer determination becomes a new task. It is the nobility of our thought that it can see its own limit and at the limit always hear—by virtue of its own law—an *Excelsior!* Every concept of God, Fichte has said, is a concept of an idol. But it is precisely a spark of divinity in human thought that, in the face of all pious attempts to formulate the divine, it can recognize that they are idolatry.

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2.3 Thought and Image

*Und deines Geistes höchster Feuerflug
Hat schon am Gleichniss, hat am Bild genug.*

GOETHE.

15. We do not cease to form ideas, even when we have reached the limit of all knowledge, so that clear and contradiction-free concepts can no longer be formed. The religious need in particular will constantly lead to such formation of ideas. It will appear on closer investigation that the arising of all such ideas is due to *analogy*.

The word analogy properly denotes the same as proportion, but one is accustomed to distinguish between the uses of the two words, so that proportion indicates a quantitative likeness of relation (e.g. $1/2 = 2/4 = 3/6$, and so on), while analogy denotes a qualitative likeness of relation (e.g. red stands to orange as orange to yellow). By the help of

proportion we can discover unknown magnitudes, if only we know that they are terms in a proportion whose other terms are known to us. Analogy, on the other hand, is a highly imperfect aid to our knowledge. It cannot give us any positive knowledge of the unknown terms, but serves especially to express the relation between terms we know beforehand. It moreover passes easily from being a conceptual relation over to being a poetic juxtaposition, and it moves generally on the boundary between thought and poetry.¹⁵

In my work *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* I have sought to show that those philosophers who do not concede the correctness of the way in which critical philosophy marks off the limits of knowledge constantly—with a greater or lesser degree of explicit consciousness—operate with analogies in their attempts to solve the riddles of existence. It is the only aid that is left when experience refuses its service. One then conceives existence in its wholeness, or existence's ultimate ground, in analogy with certain elements, phenomena, or relations within the domain of experience. The character of the different systems, of the different metaphysical world-views, rests essentially on *which* elements, phenomena, or relations one lays at the foundation of one's analogizing.

It is often supposed that there is a forced choice between the two possibilities, that existence's inmost essence is of a spiritual kind and that it is of a material kind. But the division of the existent into spiritual and material is purely empirical. No proof can be given that existence should not be able to appear under other forms than these, so that the relation between these two forms of existence should be an Either—Or (what in logic is called a contradictory relation). Perhaps the great difficulty that shows itself to be bound up with reaching a satisfactory hypothesis concerning the relation between the spiritual and the material hangs together with the fact that existence is not exhausted in those two forms of existence, but that there are many—not to say with Spinoza infinitely many—other forms of existence. It might be that the relation between the two forms of existence we know would only be able to be understood if we knew several other forms of existence. We have at any rate not all the data for the solution of the problem of existence. Let us suppose that we knew only two colours. We should then be inclined to believe that all colour that existed at all must be one of these two. Now we know that light can be refracted in more than two ways—and yet the physics, physiology, and psychology of the colours are so extraordinarily rich in problems! Existence's light can surely be refracted in many more ways than the metaphysical systematizers have imagined. This belief (and this analogy) is at any rate as justified as that on which the idealistic world-view supports itself.¹⁶

When one does not take the probative force of analogies so strictly, it is easy enough to speculate. But one then puts images in the place of concepts, poetry instead of philosophy. Epistemologically it is of great importance that a sharp distinction be drawn between concept and image. The image may have its great value; but when it does not stand as an example or as a vivid sign for a concept, the value the image has rests on its relation to other sides of our nature than the cognitive.

16. Only reluctantly does human consciousness give up immediate intuition, as this appears in the form of sensation, memory, and imagination, in order instead to travel the road of analysis and form concepts, which can with difficulty fully make up for what was had in intuition. But it is once for all the case that the objects of the religious consciousness—when this consciousness has reached a higher stage of development—can no longer be apprehended by immediate intuition. The involuntary formation of images must constantly be altered and corrected anew, and it shows itself at last insufficient to render the eternal, infinite, and exalted essence of the religious objects. The religious consciousness here oscillates between two tendencies. On the one hand it scruples to use sensuous and human expressions of its infinite object; on the other hand it scruples to deprive immediate feeling of the living and gripping expressions in which it involuntarily finds vent. In a religious genius like AUGUSTINE, who was at once thinker and prince of the Church, one can study both tendencies in their mutual conflict. For him (as later for Schleiermacher) the expression “mercy,” used of God, has only figurative significance, because it presupposes a suffering at the suffering of others. But in order that the “souls of the unlearned” (*animæ indoctorum*) should not be hardened, Augustine nevertheless thinks that one ought to use it—thus as a kind of pedagogical anthropomorphism. Only those, he adds, who combine religion and inquiry (*religio et studium*) can dispense with the figurative expressions.¹⁷—But how far now does the figurative extend? Is there properly any expression whatever for religion’s objects that is not figurative?—If we look at religion’s history, we find especially two interesting processes of development which aim at eliminating everything figurative, and which culminate in the rejection of all definite expressions, because these are drawn from limited domains of experience and therefore make finite that of which they are used.

The first process of development lies before us in the Indian *Upanishads*. The Vedanta philosophers came to the conviction that no concept and no image could express the deity’s essence. They set up their metaphysical idealism only in order at last to take it back. The deity is “without end, without age, without shore, not outside and not inside.” It is best denoted in a negative manner (*neti, neti*): “it is neither this nor that!” And silence

is the right answer when it is asked what it is. If it could be beheld by us, it would not be what it is. It is the unthinkable—and yet that by which thought thinks! No twoness, no opposition has validity for it; therefore it cannot be known. Neither sight, word, nor thought can penetrate to it, though it works in sight, word, and thought alike. It is neither being nor non-being; it is neither known nor not-known. Only symbolically can it be expressed. But in order to keep off all sensuous ideas, which are easily brought on by symbols that have a definite meaning, the Vedanta philosophers used as an expression for the highest the syllable *Om*, which means “yes,” but does not lead the imagination in any definite direction.¹⁸

The second process of development takes place in *Neoplatonism* and is propagated from this (with the so-called Dionysius the Areopagite as intermediary) to *Christian mysticism* in the Middle Ages. Although more recent investigations have shown that there is not the complete opposition between Scholasticism and Mysticism that was earlier assumed, there is nevertheless one point in which these two medieval tendencies diverge decidedly from one another, and that is precisely the question whether there are analogies that can rightly be used to think God. The Schoolmen held fast to analogy’s justification; the Mystics rejected it. THOMAS AQUINAS teaches, indeed, that it is impossible to use any expression of God quite in the same sense (*univoce*) as that in which it is used of created beings; but there are said to be expressions that can be used of God not merely by a play on words (*pure æqvivoce*). There is said to be a kind of analogy that lies midway between univocity and mere likeness of word. It is that which rests on a causal relation, as when, for example, both a medicine is called healthy, and the one who is cured by it is said to become healthy. A relation of analogy of this kind is said to obtain between the Creator and created beings. Yet it is not a relation of likeness that could make it justified to bring the Creator and the created under the same generic concept. No, every determination—even the concept of being itself—is used in a different sense of the Creator and of the created: God stands outside every genus (*extra omne genus*).—Very clear the knowledge that is thus supposed to be possible evidently cannot be, and it is not easy to form any idea of it. For analogy is (however much one fences it about) a relation of likeness, and in all comparison there must be able to be a question of generic and specific concepts: juxtaposition by the help of analogy is in reality the formation of a generic concept. When Thomas Aquinas names, as an example of theologically applicable analogy, the one that rests on causal connection, it must be remarked that the more heterogeneous, indeed generically different, the cause is from the effect, the less do we understand the causal relation. Where the causal relation is not purely external and

purely factually imposed, there is a continuity and thereby a likeness between cause and effect which makes it justified to subsume them both under the same generic concept. Such a connection one will also on closer investigation find between the medicine and the state it produces in the organism.—The Scholastic assertion of analogy's justification therefore passes consistently over into the mystical denial of this justification. HUGH OF ST. VICTOR already taught that God is better thought by negative than by positive expressions. Later SUSO called God "*eine namenlose Nichtigkeit*"—"a nothing of all the things one can think or name" (though in himself he is "a most essential something"). And the author of *Deutsche Theologia* says: "If the perfect, sole Good [God] were something, this or that, which the creature understood, then it were not all, nor yet the only one, and it would then not be perfect either. Therefore one calls it Nothing. One means thereby that it is nothing of that which the creature can comprehend, know, think, or name."¹⁹—Mysticism was at once a movement of feeling in the direction of inwardness and an intellectual movement in the direction from image to thought and from thought to thought's limit. In that one experienced, in the strong movements of feeling, states in which no definite ideas could form, one was prepared to exercise sharp criticism of every attempt to express the highest in the form of a concept. Mysticism here meets with critical philosophy, which maintains the insufficiency of ideas in the face of that which does not appear in experience's limited form. Already in antiquity we find this kinship between criticism and mysticism, for there is a certain likeness between Carneades and Plotinus in epistemological philosophy of religion.

17. But neither Scholasticism nor Protestant theology will allow Mysticism and Criticism to be right in holding that all religious ideas are figurative. In a certain sense it is also a question of life or death. For the concept of revelation (in the strictest sense) would fall away if at certain points the difference between image and reality did not fall away. Otherwise the old problem of the relation between knowledge and things themselves would at last arise again, and the full conclusion and rest be excluded.—That expressions such as Lord or Father, used of God as absolute being, are figurative, and that the similitudes underlying these expressions fail at definite points, could not in the long run escape reflection. The Lord is Lord only in relation to slaves or servants. The word God, said Newton therefore, is a relative word (*Deus est vox relativa et ad servos refertur*). And the concept of Father presupposes not only the concept of child but also the concept of mother, although in the history of the popular religions there shows itself a tendency to push out this latter concept.²⁰ And yet both the inwardness of feeling and the need of the imagination lead again and again back to the old images, even though

one gradually acknowledges their symbolic character more readily, at any rate in theory.

When reflection develops, one passes from the more vivid and concrete designations to the more abstract. Such a more abstract designation is “personality.” One gives up the more definite characterization for a more indefinite one, which yet is also drawn from human relations.

Psychologically regarded, the determination of what the concept of personality contains will always come back to two chief traits.—Personality (the self, the I), as we know it, is in the first place characterized by its unity. All elements in its being are gathered up and connected with greater or lesser energy, and that in a more intimate manner than the elements of matter are connected according to the laws of outer nature. The very elements that are connected in personality’s unity are not absolutely produced by it; here it is more or less dependent on the conditions of life. New elements may crop up in it without its wish, though not without its own unconscious or involuntary co-operation, and it then depends on how far and in what way they are brought into connection with the elements that are already worked together.—In the second place, in every personality’s content there will be some elements that occupy a more central place and have a more constant character than others. Such central and constant elements are the ruling ends and interests, which express the will’s kind and direction. This is the real side of personality, which especially conditions the individual’s special distinctiveness.²¹—Seen both from the formal and from the real side, personal life as we know it presents an alternating relation of activity and passivity. Activity shows itself in the working-up of a content received with preponderant passivity. During this working-up the peripheral and shifting elements are more or less energetically expressed and mastered by that which in the individual personality (and in the individual period of life) is the central and constant. We know personality only as striving and struggling, as asserting itself against the resistance and the difficulties caused partly by lack or superfluity of content, partly by conflict among the elements themselves. A personality that produces all its content absolutely “out of itself”—that has no ends still unaccomplished—and that has no real resistance to overcome—is not what we understand by a personality, when we hold to psychological experience.

The dispute as to how far the deity (as this is conceived at higher religious standpoints) can be called a personal being—a dispute often designated as the dispute between theism and pantheism—rests on the fact that from the one side one idealizes and extends the concept of personality by taking away the moment of passivity, while from the other side one denies the justification of calling a being a personality when it itself produces

all its elements and therefore knows no real resistance, so that it cannot struggle, cannot strive, cannot hope.

Personal life is the highest form of existence that experience shows us. And the unity we are always at last led to assume in existence on account of its continuity and conformity to law recalls the unity in our consciousness, the formal side of personality. But for all that it is only an analogy, and one that fails at the most essential point, when one uses our idea of the limited I, which is a single link within the great world-order, to express the incompletable principle that manifests itself in the very fact that there is a world-order. And it becomes so much the more difficult to hold fast to this analogy, the greater the inclination is to think the deity as perfect, as “absolute” in the sense of finished and concluded, so that it (as Andreas Sunesøn says in his Scholastic didactic poem) can receive no increase (*natura dei, cui nil accrescere posset*). By the dogmatic absolutizing and the strong emphasis on unchangeableness, the difficulties in holding fast to the analogy with the concept of personality are sharpened and made into downright self-contradictions.

The difference between a theistic and a pantheistic conception rests, in the individual case, not merely on epistemological arguments. Involuntarily other motives play in as well, and to a great extent the difference rests on a difference in the strength with which the need to form vivid images, especially in the boundary regions, stirs in different individuals. From this side we shall later, in the psychological part of the philosophy of religion, come again to touch on this point.—As regards the expression pantheism, it must be remarked that it is used in a somewhat different manner. According to the one usage (which is maintained as the right one by an authority like EDUARD ZELLER) pantheism denotes a world-view that assumes an inner (immanent) relation between God and the world, whether one then conceives God as personal or not. According to this usage a standpoint like Lotze’s would just as well be called pantheistic as Spinoza’s standpoint. According to the other usage (which I follow) the concept has a narrower extent, in that an immanent world-view is called pantheistic only when it does not ascribe personality to the principle of unity in existence (except in poetic speech).—

To go to still more abstract expressions like force, life, substance (being) does not help; they too denote relations and thus presuppose something to which one stands in relation. Such expressions too must, when they are to be applied in the way the religious consciousness in its mythical and dogmatic forms wishes, undergo such an alteration that nothing but the bare word is left.—

It shows itself then undeniably that all analogies fail at the decisive point. We stand at

thought's limit, and it is no wonder that real concepts can no longer be formed, and that the images may indeed satisfy the individual mood, but do not permit of any consistent application. This unknowable is strongly emphasized by so-called *agnosticism*. But this tendency has an inclination to think that "the unknowable" is wholly different from everything that experience shows, so that none of experience's laws should have any significance whatever for that which is nevertheless assumed to be existence's principle. This is a dualistic assumption that cannot be grounded. Although our finite points of view and forms of thought are unable to give a determination of it, let alone an exhaustive formulation of it, they must nevertheless stand in inner connection with it, and we have no right to declare them meaningless. Our thought, our knowledge, belongs once for all to existence, has arisen within it, and is itself one of the facts that must be taken into consideration before we halt our inquiry into existence's nature. The ideas our experience leads us to develop are indeed probably very subordinate and derived in relation to the great connection into which we belong as single links; but meaningless they do not on that account become. Only we are unable to state what degree and kind of metamorphosis our points of view would have to undergo if they were to be taken up into the highest, most comprehensive connection that we could think.

The expression "agnosticism" was in its time formed by HUXLEY, so that he might have a designation ending in *-ism* like all other decent expressions for views. Were I to find such a designation for the conception I strive to make good, I should prefer to call it *critical monism*.

18. In order that concepts, analogies, and images should be able to be used to express that which at higher stages of development is religion's object, they must be subjected to an idealization and sublimation which for religious feeling easily brings coldness and remoteness with it. The religious consciousness has, to be sure, a tendency to represent its object as exalted as possible, to raise it far out beyond all finite relations. But by merely following this tendency it works against itself, since the inner, living relation to its object is made impossible. Of the Hindus an observer reports: "I have often asked: Where is the temple of the highest God? And the answer, plainly enough given with great astonishment at so unexpected a question, has always been: A temple for the highest God! What is that to mean? There is no such temple, because he can have none. He is without shape and without name, inconceivable, and we cannot worship him. We need a visible object in which our spirit can find rest."²² Within Christianity we find again the same two tendencies. In the Catholic Church there is assumed a whole graduated series of beings to whom one can turn and get one's need of a finite, limited

object for prayer and devotion satisfied, if the highest link in the series seems to us to be too remote and exalted. From God the series goes through Jesus and the Madonna down to the special saint who is active in the special kind of case or takes particular care of the individual person. In Protestantism a limit has been set to this tendency, but it has not been abolished. In a Copenhagen church it was once said in a funeral oration that God cannot help us in our great sorrows, "for he is so infinitely far away"; therefore we must hold to Jesus.

Just as the religious consciousness oscillates between literal and figurative meaning of the expressions it uses, so it oscillates between the tendency to exalt and infinitize its object and the tendency to draw the object down into the finite world as fellow-combatant and fellow-sufferer. Often the strongest feeling, the most burning devotion, turns towards the struggling and suffering God, not towards the eternal and perfect one. If now both tendencies are held fast at once in their extreme forms, there appears *the religious paradox*: God is unchangeable and changeable, eternal and becoming, victorious and beaten, blessed and suffering! Often pronouncedly religious spirits heap up such oppositions by preference, sharpening the contrasts to the utmost, partly in ecstatic admiration of the great, partly with scorn towards the thought that vainly seeks to grasp it. The chief opposition to which everything here leads back is the opposition between unchangeableness and changeableness. The typical difference of the two greatest popular religions rests on their relation to this opposition. And the opposition recurs within one and the same religion. Even he who believes in a God "with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning" may yet come to the result that "God is the most changeable of all beings."²³ The paradox does not first come forward with special dogmas, e.g. the dogma of the God-man, as S. KIERKEGAARD has sharply pointed out in his *Filosofiske Smuler*. The paradox lies properly already in every anthropomorphism, in every image that is to be more than an image. For the assertion that any image whatever suffices is an assertion that the unlimited is limited, the infinite finite. One easily forgets the paradox through the power of habituation, when one has let one's imagination settle itself comfortably in the circle of images one has formed for oneself or lived into by the help of tradition. But as soon as the surge of feeling or the speed of thought becomes stronger, the limited form is burst; and when it is nevertheless to be held fast, or rather, when one nevertheless *will* hold it fast, one approaches a *credo qvia absurdum*.

19. A Both—And has on this point too shown itself to be distinctive of the religious consciousness. But where this Both—And sharpens into the paradox, it becomes clear that the interest which has led to the development of the religious ideas in their pronounced

form cannot have been a purely intellectual interest, not the mere need to understand. In every religious standpoint, especially in the great popular religions, knowledge does to be sure play a part. Religion is in its classical times everything for the human being and satisfies his need for knowledge too. But the need for knowledge is here nevertheless subordinate to the need for life, the need to develop and preserve life. "I seek thee, that my soul may live," says Augustine to his God. Only thereby is it explained that ideas can be developed and held fast which defy the intellectual interest in clear, contradiction-free thoughts. We are led to see that the foundation of religion must be sought in other sides of the life of the spirit than in the life of pure thought.

Religion cannot be made or constructed. It grows out of life, springs from the human being's fundamental mood during life's struggle, from his will to hold fast in spite of everything to the validity of the highest valuable thing that his experiences have led him to know.

The hypothesis that religion is essentially faith in the persistence of value presents itself here naturally, after it has shown itself that religion's essence cannot be to give an understanding or an explanation of existence such as the intellectual interest demands. The riddles that science cannot solve, religion does not solve either. It has been shown that it can give no explanation of the special events (section A)—that its ideas are not fitted for the conclusion of scientific thought (section B)—and that these ideas have the character of the image, not of the concept (section C). If the religious ideas are to have any significance, it can then only be that of serving as symbolic expression for the human being's mood, longing, and wishes during the struggle of life. They are thus of secondary, not of primary, significance and origin. The philosophy of religion here combats dogmatics in a manner similar to that in which art history combats the mythology of art. What drives the artist to shape a figure is—the art historian maintains²⁴—the living joy in figures that life has shown him; he wishes now to give them new birth, perhaps in a more ideal form. But what he *calls* the figure he shapes is a subordinate question, which is often only settled long afterwards.

The intellectual interest will naturally, once it has developed, not be able to refrain from influencing the religious interest. If religion is essentially faith in the persistence of value, then this faith constantly needs ideas in order to become clear about what it means; these ideas will—perhaps slowly, but yet steadily—be worked together towards greater consistency and towards greater agreement with the ideas the human being comes to form by other roads and under the influence of other motives. The question then becomes how the two interests really stand related to one another. The intellectual

interest leads one to conceive existence as a great, unsurveyable system of causal groups and causal series; the religious interest leads one to conceive existence as a home for the development and preservation of values. Can these two points of view be united? How does value stand related to causality, the riddle of life to the riddle of the world?—Perhaps this problem is insoluble, and its solution would be the finding of the philosopher's stone. But the epistemological philosophy of religion has nevertheless, it seems, helped us to see more clearly where the problem lies. It is indeed predominantly by an indirect, negative road that epistemology can illuminate the religious problem, but this road too must be travelled if clarity is to be reached. We turn now to a direct study of religion's essence by the help of psychology. What matters is how far the hypothesis of religion as faith in the persistence of value, to which I have several times pointed, can receive a satisfactory grounding and confirmation.

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Chapter 3

Psychological Philosophy of Religion

20. Properly we have already in the preceding section made use of psychology, since there is a constant reciprocal relation between epistemology and psychology. Epistemology investigates the forms and elements of our knowledge with respect to the question of their usability for understanding existence, while psychology investigates them with respect to their factual character and their factual coming-into-being, whether they have any usability and validity or not. In the case of the religious ideas it has now shown itself that their significance cannot be that of making existence intelligible to us (in the sense in which our intellectual interest takes the word understanding). Then the psychological investigation alone stands here remaining. It may possibly lead us to see what positive significance the religious ideas do have.

The psychology of religion is a part of general psychology, a speciality within it. It stands in a reciprocal relation to general psychology.—It is a means for the latter, in that within its own distinctive domain it collects and works up material of great psychological interest. In the religious domain human beings have made some of their deepest, most intensive experiences of the soul. In religion (if it is genuine and original) all the elements of the life of the soul work with an energy and an interplay such as scarcely in any other domain. Therefore the study of the religious life of the soul is of such great importance for psychology as a whole. It is not merely the history of religion, but also—and quite as much—the individual religious life that draws the psychologist's attention to itself. In the history of religion one does not so easily get to see the forces of the soul in their original working. It occupies itself predominantly with the great types, with the forms of religion common to great groups of human beings. For the psychologist, good biographies, and especially autobiographies, of religious personalities are more instructive than the most learned works on the great popular religions. Thus—to name a few single examples—Augustine's *Confessiones*, Suso's and Saint Teresa's autobiographies belong

to the most important material of the psychology of religion. The history of individual religiosity naturally also belongs under the history of religion; but this has hitherto been predominantly occupied with studying the great types.—But the psychology of religion not merely furnishes material for general psychology. Conversely it also uses the latter's points of view and laws in its own special domain. It seeks to understand the phenomena of religious life by a purely psychological road. Here general psychology is a means for the psychology of religion. And it is especially from this last side that we must regard the psychology of religion here, where it appears as a part of the philosophy of religion. It uses the general psychological methods, so far as the subject permits, and rests on the same presuppositions as general psychology.

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3.1 Religious Experience and Religious Faith

Quid est quod amo, quum te amo?

AUGUSTINE.

(What is it that I love, when I love thee?)

3.1.1 Religious Experience

21. The word experience is here taken in the sense of lived experience, the finding of states, as opposed to the working-up by thought. It will first and foremost be a matter of becoming clear about what and how much can be reckoned as religious experience, and what limits this experience is by its nature subject to. I attempt in what follows to characterize religious experience from a purely psychological point of view.

22. Experience in the sense of lived experience cannot be completed so long as life lasts. It can present a series of individual states, but no completed totality, and no general proposition can appear as a fully confirmed result of experience. Totalities and generalizations are due either to a thinking working-up of what has been experienced, or else to an involuntary emphasizing of a single experience or kind of experience as decisive and all-determining. Prior to the arising of a conscious reflection it will especially be this involuntary emphasizing that lies at the foundation of what comes to stand as the results of religious experience. It lies in the nature of feeling that, when it has been awakened by a single event, it seeks to spread itself over the whole life of consciousness and to colour

all other elements in this, whether they stand in connection with that event or not. By such a *feeling-expansion* (thus I have in my *Psychology* named this phenomenon) inner states which in and for themselves have nothing to do with one another can acquire a common stamp, and a whole can come out of the series of inner lived experiences, although this series has not in itself reached a real conclusion. For different individuals and under different circumstances it may be highly different lived experiences that thus come to determine the mood of a whole inner life. However unavoidable and however significant this feeling-expansion may be, it nevertheless contains sources of error that one must be attentive to when one proceeds to a reckoning-up of what experience and lived experience have really yielded.—Naturally such a feeling-expansion is itself a lived experience; but it is derived in relation to the lived experiences whose result it is a matter of establishing.

In the debate between optimism and pessimism, for example, one will find that single lived experiences, which are assumed to be typical, determine the conception that is maintained. Although from both sides one appeals to observation and thought, the result one reaches is determined not so much by logical generalization or induction as by a feeling-expansion. The endeavour aims at holding the underlying lived experiences fast in their freshness and letting them keep their place at the centre of consciousness, fixing attention on them; then the rest follows of itself.

If faith in the persistence of value is the core of all religion, religion will not be able to be built on immediate lived experience. Immediately we come to know only the individual, definite values, as they appear according to our human and individual nature and under our special conditions of life; but about their persistence no experience can immediately instruct us, any more than it can teach us that what has the highest value for us is also the central thing in the whole of existence. What is experienced and lived through may be a *motive* for believing in the persistence of value, but not the *content* of this faith itself. Personal life, especially as it expresses itself in the great breakthroughs where new directions of life are introduced and new forms of life are born, is for us the highest valuable thing we know. The experiences we make of it we therefore use involuntarily to illuminate the whole of existence for us; it is to us as though existence in such breakthroughs revealed its hidden forces. It is a feeling-expansion that here operates. If we try to transpose it into the form of thought, it is an inference from analogy that we get—and an analogy that lies out beyond the limit where thought passes over into poetry.

23. In all experience a distinction must be drawn between what is immediately given,

what serves to explain it, and what serves to express it. These three moments, the state itself, its cause, and its expression, can lie so close to one another that they cannot be separated except by closer and more exact reflection. The relation between them is a similar one to that between a discovery, the proof of what has been discovered, and its formulation. These three moments too can approach one another, though it may be of great interest to keep them apart.

When one appeals to one's experience, one can provisionally support oneself only on *the lived state itself*. That this state may have a *definite cause* is not lived through in so immediate a manner as the state itself is lived through. Precisely when something has intervened strongly in our life of the soul and called forth great effects there, we shall be so taken up with these effects, which are indeed the very thing we immediately live through, that it will be impossible for us to form a clear and exact idea of the state's cause. The real cause always consists of a plurality of conditions and can only be established by critical investigation. It always rests on an illusion when one supposes oneself immediately to experience "the cause as cause." That a causal relation is present one cannot immediately observe; immediate observation always shows us only that the one follows *after* the other, not that it follows *from* it. The presence of a causal relation is established only when it can be shown that *only* when this definite event goes before does this definite state *unavoidably* follow after. But neither an *only* nor an *unavoidably* can be known quite immediately; they must be ascertained by comparison or by experiment. In doubtful cases it is also comparison and experiment that we resort to, and it is indeed in doubtful cases that the appeal to "experience" especially appears.

We do not begin with doubt, either in the domain of inner or of outer experience. Every rising element of consciousness is from the first taken involuntarily as valid, as the expression of reality. It presents itself with a quality of existence that is shaken only when contradictory elements too present themselves with their quality of existence. If such contradiction fails to appear, no doubt arises, and no criterion of reality or validity is needed. But when it does set in, the question becomes which of these elements possesses the true reality, and this can only be decided by there being found an unavoidable connection between one element and other elements whose validity stands fast beforehand. Thus we proceed in doubt about something in the world around us. The difference between a hallucination and a real event is discovered by the fact that the latter, but not the former, can be inserted as a link in a great, connected causal series that is tied to elements whose validity is not drawn into doubt. The more firmly connected a dream is, the more it stands for us as reality; and the more isolated a real event

stands in our experience, the more easily can we take it for a dream. What thus holds of outer experience holds also of inner. Here too an immediate experience of a causal relation is impossible. In every more deeply penetrating discussion of the significance of religious experience it will at any rate show itself expedient, if not necessary, to get the immediately lived experience itself set out with the greatest possible abstraction from the supposed cause. The strictly immediate lived experience itself cannot be any illusion. The illusory arises precisely only through an incorrect causal explanation which is confused with immediate observation. How causal explanation comes about at all we shall later have occasion to discuss.

If there is present a strongly agitated state or lived experience, it will not be exactly the need to find its cause that first of all announces itself, but rather *the need to find vent in outbursts, in exclamations, in words, or in action*. The individual then seeks after thoughts or images that can satisfy this need and give it a definite direction. It is a need for reaction that here expresses itself—a need for reaction in fear or in thanks, in love or in indignation and hatred. The manner in which this reaction takes place will be determined by earlier lived experiences and by the tradition under whose influence the human being stands. Only in especially original natures does a new formation here take place. It is such natures that become prophets or founders of religions.

By a natural displacement, that which satisfies the need for expression and reaction easily coincides with that which satisfies the need for a causal explanation, as soon as this announces itself. In the pronouncedly religious states the need for knowledge does not stir independently, and therefore not in a critical manner either; the need for expression and reaction, which is one with a need for symbolization, has decidedly the preponderance and will therefore become determinative for the content of the religious idea.

When immediate experience cannot give sure direction as to the cause of the lived experience, it can still less contain reliable information as to whether the lived experience is due to a natural or to a supernatural cause. In exact descriptions of religious states it also often becomes clearly evident that one infers a supernatural cause only because one cannot find any natural cause and does not think that one has oneself been co-operative. Thus Saint Teresa says: "I felt my soul kindled with burning love of God; this love was evidently supernatural, for *I did not know* what thus kindled it in me, and *I had not myself contributed* anything to it." It is a trait that constantly recurs among mystics and pietists, that the more they hold back (or suppose themselves to hold back) their own thought and will, the more will that which is lived through in their inner life be assumed to be

of divine origin.²⁵ There lies here the same dualistic conception at the foundation as with the concept of miracle generally. Psychological miracles stand quite on a line with physical miracles, though the belief in the former may hold out longer than the belief in the latter.

24. Religious ideas can stand in a somewhat different relation to the immediate lived experience. It may happen that the lived experience unfolds as a series of states, and that only afterwards is an idea sought which interprets it (that is to say: explains it or expresses it or both). Such an idea can be formed anew, under the impression of extraordinary lived experiences and in original, creative personalities, although even founders of religions are involuntarily guided by traditions with which their lived experiences fuse, yet in such a way that a wholly new direction in the life of the spirit can be introduced.—Most often the interpretation is drawn without more ado from the circle of transmitted ideas—ideas that were indeed possessed and known beforehand, but not particularly attended to. There are examples of persons becoming clear only afterwards that they had been “converted” or “born again,” by comparing their lived experiences with “the statements of trustworthy believers.”²⁶ The change that is noticed is interpreted by the help of tradition, for which one now first gets a practical use and which one transforms from a dead treasure into a living one. But very often the relation is such that the transmitted ideas themselves call forth the lived experiences. For most human beings religious experience is an attempt to live through, in their inner life, the states that transmitted ideas describe and demand. The ideas are thus fully finished beforehand and are merely to be converted into lived experiences. Most human beings make their religious experiences within religious communities with a more or less developed doctrine of faith. Thereby the extent of the experiences is dammed in beforehand. Lived experiences that cannot find their expression or their explanation within the transmitted circle of religious ideas stand as uncertain, or as dangerous, or even as pernicious. In theological expositions this confessional character, which is so frequent in religious experiences, appears clearly and often with full consciousness.

The older Pietism laid—in contrast to the orthodoxy it stood over against—great weight on the inner experiences. But since the Protestant Church maintains the Bible as the highest norm, the ecclesiastical pietists expressly declared that inner experience was to be subordinated to the Bible’s teaching. In his remarkable work *Theologia experimentalis* (1715) GOTTFRIED ARNOLD taught that religious experience stands under Scripture and does not denote a special principle alongside it. Experience’s significance he saw in this, that it was a practising of, or a living into, what Scripture taught. Experience

is thus not ground, but consequence and fruit, and it is to be “judged according to God’s word.” With the clarity that distinguishes Arnold, he then draws from this the conclusion that experience must occupy a different place in religion from that in science: in religion it comes after faith, in science it goes before faith. More recent theologians (for example HENRY USSING in his work *Den kristelige Vished*) have on the other hand attempted to parallel religious and scientific experience without seeing the consequences, disquieting for themselves, to which this must lead. At any rate they are compelled to concede that the individual cannot by the road of experience come to know everything that he is to believe according to his Church’s teaching. And what significance has “the common experience of the church community” for the individual, and can it rightly be called a common experience when not all make it or can make it? Besides, the Church’s teaching contains a great deal, for example the creation, the day of judgment, and so on, which no one can ever have experienced.

The confessional limitation has made religious experience, and indeed all inner experience, one-sided and imperfect. It has kept the eye away from sides of the inner life that had a full claim to come into consideration. And what in a philosophy-of-religion respect is the most important thing: it has made it psychologically inexplicable how the religious ideas came into being in the first place. Religious experience must surely be able to lead to the formation of new ideas, or at least to the valuing of other ideas than the traditionally sanctioned ones. There must in the domain of inner life be discoveries to make just as well as in the domain of outer life. The conditions of inner life change just as well as those of outer life; that follows already from the fact that there is a constant reciprocal action between the inner life and the outer. One cannot then dogmatically assume that all essential spiritual experiences should already have been made, so that all following generations have now only to practise the forms and thoughts that at a certain definite point of time were laid down. A proof that the world of the spirit is closed will never be able to be given.

25. The life-value of an idea is established both by the fact that experience leads one to form or to choose it as the expression of what has been lived through, and by the fact that holding fast to it and sinking oneself into it helps to keep one’s courage up in life’s struggle, to preserve fidelity to the best we know, and to set us tasks that carry us forward in personal development. Whether therefore an idea stands as the effect of experience or as the cause of experience, it is tested through experience. But it must be well held fast that a complete experiential proof of an idea’s life-value is present only where there has been opportunity to test whether the same experiences could not be

expressed in another way, or whether the same or equally valuable experiences could not be made in the attempt to live in ideas other than this definite one. There must not merely be a test made, but also a counter-test— and for that life very seldom gives the individual opportunity. The individual will as a rule be restricted to experiencing that certain ideas under certain circumstances have helped him or not helped him. He will not be able to prove that he could not have been helped by other ideas than those that helped him. Immediate lived experience can at any rate tell him nothing about that. And just as little can it tell him anything about whether that which did not help him might not be able to help others—or to help himself under other circumstances. Experience will here always preserve a personal-individual stamp, and “common experience” is more or less an illusion, because the different individuals in reality interpret and apply “the common” each in his own way. When there is thus already misgiving about the transition from the individual experience to the confessional, it must awaken still greater misgiving when confessional experience makes a claim to be accessible to all human beings, if only they “will” receive it. Here again there lies at the foundation the presupposition that one knows all possibilities, that is to say here: all personal circumstances and conditions.

26. Hitherto we have investigated religious experience *as* experience, that is, according to the conditions and peculiarities it has in common with other experience. Now we shall enter upon what is distinctive of *religious experience* and makes it different from other psychological experience.

Religious experience is essentially religious feeling. It is the mind’s own inner state during the course of inner and outer events that is its immediate object. But there are other experiences of feeling than the religious. In describing the nature of religious feeling it will be a matter of stating its likeness to and its difference from the most nearly related feelings.

All feeling, that is to say, all pleasure and displeasure, of whatever kind it may be, expresses the *value* which something that happens in the inner or the outer world has for us. And conversely: that has value which is the object of immediate satisfaction, or which can also become a means to such. (Cf. §3.) The concepts of end and means presuppose the concept of value, and value again presupposes a subject that can feel pleasure and displeasure. When we ascribe value to things and states, this property, like all properties, denotes a definite relation to a subject, here to one that can feel pleasure and displeasure. This property is derived in relation to other properties that things and states have; for it must be these properties that make the things and states valuable. Value is thus a property in the second power.

The different kinds of value correspond to the different kinds of feeling. One group of values hangs together with self-assertion, from its most elementary to its most ideal forms. Another group of values hangs together with devotion to beings, relations, and tasks that point out beyond the conditions of isolated self-assertion; to this belong the ethical, aesthetic, and intellectual values. The possibility of a third group of values, the religious values, rests on the fact that the two first groups of values, those of self-assertion and of devotion, are to be acquired and held fast within existence, such as it once for all is. Existence thereby comes to stand for the human being as a battlefield on which the fate of values is decided. It is a great drama that is performed, in which the human being is both fellow-player and spectator. Were he merely fellow-player, his whole energy and all his interest would be taken up by the place he himself is to fill in the drama, and he would not have time, strength, and interest to be more deeply affected by the course of the drama as a whole. Were he merely spectator, his mood at the drama's course would be purely intellectual or aesthetic. But when he is both, he will himself have values that are at stake in the struggle, and besides his own participation in this, the picture he forms of the drama's course will also affect and attune him. He will feel himself so drawn in, with his whole inmost being and with respect to the highest values he knows, to the whole great order and course of things, that there will arise in him a living feeling of displeasure or pleasure, according to the fate the values suffer. In its most immediate form this feeling finds vent in outbursts of hope and fear, admiration and disgust, joy and sorrow. Such outbursts are in all domains the simplest value-judgments there are. *This feeling, determined by the fate of values during the struggle of existence, is the religious feeling.* It is thus determined by the relation between value and reality. This relation—as it stands for the human being—determines the value the human being ascribes to existence. The religious judgments are thus secondary value-judgments, are derived in relation to the primary value-judgments in which the two first groups of values are expressed.

The religious values can—in spite of their derived character—be felt just as immediately and just as energetically as the primary ones. They will themselves be able to be the human being's central values, since the relation between value and reality is the strongest relation of tension in which the human being is placed, and which can therefore lay claim to all his energy; for what is at stake here is at last life or death for everything that has shown itself to have value for the human being. In the religious problem the concept of value appears in the second power, derived to be sure, but in the same sense in which a concentration is derived in relation to the forces that are

concentrated towards one and the same point. In religion's classical times, the time of beginnings and the time of organization, such a concentration of all interests and forces towards one point is the most characteristic trait.

And just as religious feeling, in spite of its derived character in relation to other feelings, can be just as immediate and energetic as they, so it can also appear independently over against them, react back upon them. It by no means stands merely passively related to them. There is here a constant reciprocal relation, and the degree of independence may be highly different on both sides. With greater independence the two first groups will be able to appear only at more developed stages of culture, where the spiritual division of labour has come into force. As we have earlier seen, the religious problem presents itself precisely only where the special values acquire a greater degree of independence over against that concentration of all values which is religion's distinctive character, and which psychologically finds its explanation in the fact that it is the fundamental relation between value and reality that in religion is the really determining thing.

The psychological description and analysis of a feeling must naturally not be confused with the feeling's own reality. In order to describe and analyse we need a scaffolding of concepts and points of view which the real state of feeling itself has no need whatever to know. It appears, or can appear, with a closed character of wholeness; it grows forth in the manner in which an instinct forms itself: under the influence of impressions and lived experiences which the human being cannot always account for, and which only the comparative investigation points out.

The feeling whose possibility and general character has now been described constitutes the most essential distinctive mark of all religions and religious standpoints. In relation to it all ideas are subordinate and conditioned.

One might object to this that in the great historical forms of religion it is after all an essential trait that personal beings, on whom the human being feels himself dependent, are represented as ruling in existence, and that the concept of religion therefore presupposes myth, dogma, and cult.—How one will define the concept of religion is at last a free matter. As with all fundamental definitions, it is grounds of expediency that here decide. Now it is not expedient to define a concept in such a way that one thereby cuts off important questions and problems. The religious problem becomes undeniably very much simplified if one will speak of religion only where myths, dogmas, and cult can be pointed out. But if myth, dogma, and cult always have religious significance only by being borne by a feeling such as that described above, then there shows itself a possibility that this bearing element in religion can also be and work

without procuring itself expression in myth, dogma, or cult. It is then natural to lay the chief weight on it, and the wider extent of the concept of religion therefore becomes the most natural. Great importance this question does not moreover have, since the dispute about it easily becomes a dispute about words. If one would rather avoid the word religion than use it in a wider sense, one might, as I have proposed in my *Psychology*, call the feeling that is determined by the relation between value and reality *cosmic life-feeling*. For just as the organic life-feeling immediately corresponds to and is determined by the course of life in our organism, and acquires a different character according as the organic life in us is checked or furthered, so in the feeling described there will be given a symptom of how it goes with life (so far as we know it and tie our weal and woe to it) in existence as a whole (so far as we can form a picture of it). If one will not take the word religion in the wider sense, one may call religion (in the narrower sense) a *distinctive* kind of cosmic life-feeling.—To use the word religion in the wider sense would only be unfortunate if this usage were used for unworthy accommodation to existing forms of religion. But the criticism of the existing forms of religion becomes precisely sharper if it can be shown that these in many ways come into conflict with religion's own essence and therefore point out beyond themselves. Besides, those who wish to compromise will always be able to find their ways out, and there is no reason to give up a usage that is expedient in a scientific respect because it can be misused for unscientific ends.

In his brilliant book *De l'irréligion de l'avenir* (1887) GUYAU holds fast to the narrower usage as regards the word religion, in that he will not speak of religion where myth, dogma, and cult are lacking. But he then distinguishes between *irréligion* (non-religion) and *antireligion* (religion's opposite), and his endeavour aims at establishing that "the non-religion of the future will be able to preserve the purest thing the religious feeling contained." The question is, it seems to me, whether "the purest thing in the religious feeling" is not precisely the really religious thing itself. The American philosopher of religion J. ROYCE, who stands at a different standpoint from Guyau, says in an interesting essay he has written on the young French philosopher who departed so early: "If Guyau's opinions were my own, I should without hesitation call them religious, because in them—like he himself—I should see the rationally formed consummation of what humanity's religious instinct has sought after."²⁷—We find ourselves here in the domain of fine nuances. I for my part would not have so great a misgiving as Guyau about the wider application of the concept of religion, but would not be quite so sure of my case as Royce.

27. The description of religious feeling attempted in what precedes is confirmed partly by the fact that it lets the difference between religious feeling and other feelings come

out clearly, partly by the fact that starting from it one can with ease explain the different forms that religious feeling can assume.

The more the human being is taken up with the very work of asserting himself, or the more he is absorbed in intellectual, aesthetic, and ethical interests, the more does the really religious recede, if it does not wholly disappear. Existence is then a resistance to be overcome, or an object that is understood or contemplated, or a foundation for tasks of the will.—Especially instructive here is the difference between the intellectual and the religious relation to existence. Existence presents to knowledge an unsurveyable richness and multiplicity; it contains far more than human beings will ever be able to bring under the point of view of what they call values. It realizes forms and stages of existence that go far beyond, and often stand in direct opposition to, what that which from a human standpoint stands as the valuable would demand. Intellectually regarded, this overflowing fullness is a good, because the picture of the world at which our knowledge works thereby becomes the more comprehensive, and because the endeavour is the more strongly awakened to understand the individual form or the individual stage in its distinctiveness and in its definite connection with the whole. The religious interest, on the other hand, aims at seeing this whole richness of forms and stages as the expression of the realization of great values in existence. For the religious interest the great multiplicity contains a danger and a temptation, since the reality of values cannot be pointed out so easily as if the content of existence were less luxuriant. The unsurveyable world seems to be too great for the human values. There may then here come a collision between the intellectual interest, which is always on the track of new differences and new connections and therefore rejoices in the fullness, and the religious interest, which in order to be able to hold fast to the point of view of value has a natural tendency to limit the picture of the world (which became a chief point in the epistemological philosophy of religion). This opposition comes out clearly when one compares two natures like PASCAL and SPINOZA. What terrifies the one, nature's infinity, delights and inspires the other. And yet Spinoza was in his way a religious nature. Intellectual interest can, namely, involuntarily bring with it an evaluation of existence. When existence in all its fullness nevertheless shows itself intelligible, it is indeed from an intellectual point of view a home for values, comes in a manner to meet the human spirit. It procures for us the deep joy of knowledge, which becomes of especially penetrating effect when we understand ourselves as distinctive links in the great connection.

Then arises the intellectual love which was the highest thing for Spinoza, the quiet, inspired contemplation in which everything was at last harmonized for him into a total

picture.—It will be easy in analogy with this to develop the relation between religious feeling and the feelings that stand related to it in a similar manner to the intellectual feeling. The religious relation is everywhere characterized by a striving to hold fast the persistence of the valuable in existence: whatever the valuable may be that the human being sets highest, and whatever the conception may be that the human being has of existence. Life, truth, beauty, and goodness must be presupposed to have been experienced in order that a religious relation should be possible. The religious relation comes into force when these values are compared with the rest of reality. From this one sees at once the opposition and the connection between religious feeling and other feelings. It must here be noted that what I here distinguish between as two different acts, the experience of life, truth, beauty, and goodness, and the experience of these values' relation to factual reality, need not appear at different points of time, but may coincide in one act, so that the human being himself does not become conscious of the difference. It is in the psychological description that we make this difference; it need not be made in life itself. The religious strife gets its sharp sting precisely from the fact that at the classically religious standpoint there exists no valuable life, no truth, no beauty, and no goodness outside religion; this has in its concentrated form taken up all valuable elements, so that these do not come to appear in their independent distinctiveness. This happens, as often remarked in what precedes, only when the religious problem is posed as a consequence of a beginning division of labour in the spiritual domain.

The differences between the religious standpoints may rest partly on the different values that are presupposed to have been experienced, partly on the different conception of existence that lies at the foundation, partly on the different degree of energy with which value and reality are compared, so that the relation between them can become the object of penetrating experience. These three sources of differences all spring from the given description of religion as a feeling determined by the relation between value and reality. Every exhaustive characterization of a given religion or religious standpoint will lay these three points of view at its foundation. Both in what precedes and in what follows there are examples of these points of view's significance.

28. If the conception of the world immediately showed us the highest valuable thing realized, or at least clearly showed us existence as the secure home of the valuable, no special religious feeling would arise. There would be an immediate harmony between explanation and evaluation of existence: what could be pointed out as an operative cause in the world would thereby at the same time have been pointed out as a means to the realization of something valuable. There would, to use an expression from political

economy, be no marginal utility. As it is, on the other hand—since the connection of values with the rest of reality is so great a problem—a distinctive exertion is required in order to hold fast the conviction of the persistence of the valuable.

Nor would any special religious feeling arise if the human being's capacity to work for the valuable (in himself and in existence) were unlimited. Religious feeling presupposes a striving to assert the values in us and outside us—a striving that meets resistance. The human being feels himself dependent and divided precisely in the inmost and most intimate domain. The feeling of dependence first properly arises where there is a striving to press forward. The chained animal will not feel itself dependent except when it strives to reach further out than the chain reaches. When the feeling of dependence is something other and more than a lassitude that may derive from dullness, it presupposes that one has gone to the will's limit. The lion in the cage, pacing up and down along the bars, has gone to the limit and feels its dependence; if it kept still at the back of the cage, it would feel no dependence, but would find existence far simpler and more harmonious than it now does. But in order that a religious relation should arise, it is not enough to go to the will's limit. At the very limit and in spite of the limit the wish for the persistence of the valuable must be held fast. There must form ideas of a world of values whose reality is not given up because human thought and human capacity have found their limits. There may arise an intimation that the principle of this world of values is at last one with the principle of existence's causal connection—that what makes it possible for us to find values in existence is the same as what makes it possible for us to find it intelligible.

In SCHLEIERMACHER's famous description of religion as a feeling of dependence it is not sufficiently emphasized that this dependence is conditioned by an activity, and that it arises at this activity's limit. Nor is it sufficiently emphasized that the dependence is felt with respect to the work for those values that for the human being stand as the highest and as those which in spite of everything persist and can therefore be asserted by human striving.

The role that the consciousness of sin plays in several religions is an example of the character of the religious feeling of dependence. In the consciousness of sin the human being feels the disproportion between the ideal of will that his evaluation has led him to acknowledge, and the reality of his will. It is now sluggishness and lassitude, now dividedness or dispersion, now one-sided or impatient concentration, that makes his inner reality so different from the ideal. In the consciousness of redemption or reconciliation there then dawns, often suddenly, the conviction that the valuable in spite of everything persists, persists in his own inner being and will come to be victorious there.

This inner psychological drama stands, in the highest popular religions, in Buddhism and Christianity, as the real world-drama, to whose unfolding in souls the great cosmic processes at last all minister.

3.1.2 Religious Faith

29. Like all other experiences, religious experience too is shaped in more or less definite ideas, whose content depends on the stage of development and knowledge at which the human being stands. The harmonious or disharmonious relation between value and reality gets its most immediate expression in exclamations. When the human being commands a larger circle of ideas, he will involuntarily compare the feeling that the relation between value and other reality awakens in him with other feelings and experiences, and thereby, through likeness (especially analogy) with, or opposition to, these other experiences, closer expressions and designations for religious experience will be able to be won. Thus there are used in religious language expressions like life and death, health and sickness, light and darkness, truth and falsehood, beauty and ugliness, justice and injustice, to denote the oppositions that are lived through in the religious domain. The expressions are drawn from the domain of the two first groups of values, from the domain of life-preservation, truth, beauty, and goodness.

The religious life of feeling oscillates, like all life of feeling, between pleasure and displeasure, between vehemence and lassitude, between inwardness and outwardness. But since in every personal being there is a more or less pronounced striving after unity and connection, there must in spite of these oscillations be certain chief ideas to which the mind constantly returns, and in which it finds expression for what is essential in its experiences. In the dark and weak moments it seeks to hold fast what it has experienced and thought in the bright and strong moments. It strives to preserve continuity in spite of the oscillations and through the oscillations. In religious faith there is expressed not merely the individual expression of religious feeling, but above all an endeavour to hold fast that relation between value and reality which the most strongly intervening experiences have taught the human being to acknowledge.

In the concept of faith there lies the conviction of a continuity, a persistence out beyond the horizon experience has shown us, and through the interruptions and leaps that experience presents. We believe in a human being when we hold fast the conviction that through all changes he will be like himself, although his life does not lie before us as completed or as fully known. We believe in ourselves when we cherish confidence that we shall not fail the best in us, but shall hold fast our decisive resolutions through all

hindrances. And thus religious faith too is a conviction of a firmness, a trustworthiness, an unbroken connection in the fundamental relation between value and other reality, however much the states of reality, and with them the empirical appearance of values, may change. Faith is akin to faithfulness, and presupposes faithfulness (in the sense of firmness) in faith's object as well. Faith is a subjective continuity in disposition and will, which aims at holding fast an objective continuity in existence. Faith's object is the persistence of value—but the very existence of faith is a testimony to the persistence of value within the individual personality.

Faith arises in its simplest and healthiest forms involuntarily. But that does not exclude its being a matter of will, when one takes the word will (as is done in my *Psychology*) in the wider sense. An unfolding of activity is needed when an expression or an explanation is to be held fast in the face of the oscillations of states, in the face of what is incomplete and often contradictory in experiences. But in its simplest forms this activity can appear as instinctive confidence or secure expectation. Only when the opposition between value and other reality assumes sharper and more glaring forms does faith appear as desire, wish, purpose, or resolution, in that the concentration of all the mind's forces upon the leading and saving thought is undertaken with greater consciousness of what is at stake. In faith, moreover, what perhaps can only be realized through long ages is lived through as present, just as in the moment of resolution we already regard ourselves as acting, although there may be a long road still to the carrying out of the action. Through this anticipation the difference between means and end is abolished; the time of preparation and expectation is no longer merely a means for a later time, but the fruit of the work is lived through in the midst of the time of work, because the work itself is the highest reward. In religion's own language this is expressed by saying that eternal life is lived in the midst of time, does not first come after long ages.

There is thus a close kinship between faith and will. In describing any expression of will that lies beyond the purely instinctive, the chief point will be the holding fast of the idea of a goal that is to be reached, whether this goal is again a means for a more distant goal or not. It is by this moment—the holding fast of an idea across greater or lesser distance and resistance—that the concepts of faith and will pass over into one another, so that they can even be said to be names for one and the same phenomenon of the soul. If any difference is to be made, then faith denotes rather a rest, a devotion—the rest and devotion that lie in concentration upon a single idea. One may speak of a “will to believe,” in so far as a definite striving to attain such a concentration may express itself. Conversely one may also speak of a faith in the will, since a confident devotion to

the endeavour of will and the conviction of its energy may be a necessary condition for the will's work to be done.

Significant differences in the nature of religious faith are conditioned—like the differences in the nature of religious feeling—by differences in values and motives of evaluation, by differences in the knowledge of reality, and by differences in the energy with which value and reality are compared and held together. These differences are not all of equally great importance. It will be easy to see that the last-named difference will be the most important.

The motive of evaluation, which determines what comes to stand as valuable for the human being, can vary from individual to individual, from people to people, from time to time, both in kind and in extent. It may be hope or fear; it may be egoistic, or at any rate individualistic, and sympathetic; it may be simple or composite, and if it is composite it may have a different timbre according to the different relation between the elements that co-operate in it. In respect of extent the difference between egoism, individualism, and sympathy will also be decisive: the circle of values that is to be preserved may be attached either to the individual himself, with more or less conscious isolation, or to groups of human beings and endeavours within which the individual's own persistence and striving stands only as a single link.

The conception of the world gets its significance for religious faith by indicating the roads along which values can be unfolded and preserved. It presents the whole stage on which the great drama takes place in which the fate of the valuable is decided, and the stage determines in many ways the kind and course of the play.

But the properly religious moment arises—if the preceding description is correct—only through the comparing of evaluation and conception of the world. Therefore the most important group of differences that acquire influence on religious faith must be that which arises through the different inwardness and energy with which value and reality are placed together in consciousness. One might call them differences in religious synthesis. Naturally all three moments always work together; but this last is the most central. In what follows I shall bring forward some of the most typical differences that are predominantly determined by the varying of the last-named relation.

30. A characteristic and very frequent type of religious faith is that which is determined by the need for rest. And what makes one weary and tired during the course of life is above all unrest and dividedness. We are affected from so many sides and have trouble collecting our thoughts; we are drawn in so many directions and find it hard to hold the will fast upon a single goal; so many different and shifting feelings are set in motion that

the mind's inner harmony threatens to dissolve. There is inner distress on account of the feeling of the disproportion to our ideal, and there is outer distress in pain, infirmity, and dependence on life's elementary necessities.

In the *Upanishad* it is said: "The Self (Atman), the sinless, that which is redeemed from old age, death, suffering, hunger, and thirst—that whose wishes are right and whose resolve is right—that one should explore, that one should seek to know. Whoever has found and known this Self attains all worlds and all wishes." And in another place: "Save me, for I feel myself in this course of the world like the frog in a dry well!"—Jesus of Nazareth says: "Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. . . . Learn of me, and ye shall find rest unto your souls."—"Restless is our heart," says Augustine to his God, "until it finds rest in thee!"—

In passionate form this need for rest appears in natures like Saint Teresa, Pascal, and Søren Kierkegaard.

There is indeed in Augustine too a mighty pathos; but one always notices in him the Platonist and the prince of the Church alongside the intensely strained seeker; it is precisely the union of all these elements that makes him so unique a figure in the history of the religious life. Saint Teresa feels the need for union with God so violently that only death can satisfy it: "I did not know where I should seek this life, except in death. Nothing could answer to my wishes; my heart was every moment on the point of bursting, and it was to me as though the soul were being torn out of me." "I thirst to live, and I live dying! I die because I cannot die! The fish that is drawn up out of the water nevertheless sees its torment end; but what death can be compared with the life in which I languish?" For Kierkegaard too it was *life's strife* that it was a matter of being released from; the lines of the hymn he wished set on his grave express it:

"It is a little while, then I have won, then is the whole strife at once vanished."

Here in life the believer is in an alien element; there is a disproportion between the inner and the outer, between life and its conditions. In him too the image of *the fish on dry land* comes forward in one place; it is characteristic of this type that this same image has thrust itself forward both in the ancient Indian of the *Upanishads*, in the Spanish nun of the sixteenth century, and in the Nordic thinker of the nineteenth. This trait is instructive with respect to the psychology of religion. The human being's goal stands as infinite, but the human being must lead his life in the world of finitude, and from this it follows that his existence acquires a convulsive character. In Kierkegaard, and already in Pascal, the opposition is emphasized in a still sharper manner than in Teresa. In Teresa it awakens longing and inward yearning; her "will" is laid claim to by the

highest object, and only her memory and her imagination work to interpret her lived experiences. But both in Pascal and in Kierkegaard it is precisely the will that is again and again summoned up, in order that they may hold themselves up under the cutting disproportion between the true life and the actual conditions of life, and above all in order that thought may hold fast to faith's object and not succumb to doubt.—As an example of this type John Bunyan (the author of *The Pilgrim's Progress*), who has himself described the story of his conversion, must further be named. Deep melancholy, ungovernable motor impulses, restless vehemence here formed the psychological foundation for a series of spiritual struggles, which were brought to an end only after a stage of despair had led over into a state of complete passivity, in which strength could be gathered for a new and higher life. Even after he had won a firm position and had begun his vigorous activity as a curer of souls, he had again and again to summon up his self-control in order to keep the old chaos down.²⁸

31. In opposition to this type, which is characterized by the fact that it is disharmony that lies at the foundation and awakens the need, stands a type whose distinctive character is an inner need for self-unfolding and devotion, which leads out beyond all oppositions and limitations, almost without touching upon them. Religious feeling here becomes properly no distinctive kind of feeling, but a heightening and widening of the feeling with which the valuable is already beforehand embraced. Religious feeling here arises through a further unfolding of the drive for self-preservation. There is here no opposition between self-assertion and devotion, for devotion arises through the human being's commanding far more strength and feeling than his own purely individual interests can lay claim to. In overflowing joy and enthusiasm he then embraces the life of others, at last the whole of existence. Religion springs here from the strength to live and from the joy in life. It seeks rest here too, but not rest from pain and dividedness—rather rest for a yearning that no limited object can satisfy. The happy man will, said Aristotle, see life about him, a life he can share and bear.

In an interesting manner this type comes forward in the modern age in CAMPANELLA, JOSEPH BUTLER, and ROUSSEAU. Characteristic is especially Butler's statement (in a sermon "on the love of God"): "As we cannot remove from this earth or change our whole business upon it, so neither can we alter our real nature. Therefore no other spiritual exercise can be required of us than the exercise of the faculties of which we are conscious. *Religion does not demand new feelings, but only the direction of the feelings we already have*, though they are limited to objects that do not satisfy their nature."—This type lies at the foundation in Goethe (in Faust's confession of faith and in the Marienbad Elegy) and

in Schleiermacher (in his *Speeches on Religion*). It comes forward in a manner recalling the Gospel of John in the English theologian FR. D. MAURICE, for whom hell consisted in separation from God, and who—in contrast to those who “construct all theology out of sin”—says in one of his letters: “How I long to say to myself and to all, that the hell we are to flee is ignorance of the perfect Good and separation from it, and that the heaven we are to seek is the knowledge of it and the participation in it.”²⁹

32. A third type is characterized by the role the intellectual and the aesthetic element plays. For contemplative natures what matters is to win *a total conception* within which the relation between value and reality finds its illumination. Now it is thought’s need for understanding, now the imagination’s need for vivid images, that predominates. Plato’s doctrine of ideas satisfied both requirements for him and gave his mind rest in the contemplation of the eternal ideas as the true reality, in relation to which the sensible world in its constant change stood at last as an illusion. A tendency in this direction occurs already in the *Upanishads*. From Platonism this type has passed over into Christian theology, where it is traced in Augustine, in the mystics of the Middle Ages, and (in slighter forms, to be sure) in more recent speculative theologians, as with us Martensen. A pronounced representative of this type is SPINOZA. Although his thought, so long as it moves on the ground of experience, has a decidedly realistic character, the highest consummation lay for him nevertheless in the contemplation of things “under the form of eternity,” a contemplation that could indeed only be reached through serious work of thought, but which is nevertheless rather of an artistic than of a scientific kind. The attainment of such a contemplation stood for Spinoza as the highest good, as the only thing that could bestow lasting and deep satisfaction. In this contemplation the most inward life was combined with the most serious reflection upon life, and the joy of knowledge that was awakened by it cast its radiance over the whole picture of the world and obscured the disharmonious traits it presented when one remained at the finite and limited standpoint. Every feeling and every experience can give its contribution to this highest spiritual state, and access to this good stands open to everyone who strives. The strife that finite goods can awaken between human beings falls away here, and the joy in it grows the more there are who gain access to it.

Many of the representatives of this type have supposed that in the highest idea or the intellectual contemplation, which for them was the highest thing, they had a result of the highest science. This rested on an illusion, which was founded on an imperfect investigation of knowledge’s conditions and limits. If it is philosophy that these spirits end in, then it is not philosophy as science, but philosophy as art.³⁰ But this type’s great

merit is then precisely to have asserted thought's significance for life, even there where thought moves at its own limit. The art of thought is of great importance for the art of life, and it would lead to spiritual barbarism if this type came to lack representatives.

With the need for contemplation there naturally combines the need for intuition. In Plato and Spinoza the need for visual images seems to have ruled in the imagination; they have been visual. The same holds of the author of the Gospel of John. Although not only the opposition between light and darkness, but also the opposition between life and death, frequently comes forward in his circles of images, it is nevertheless the first opposition that rules, and life and death are themselves often represented as day and night.—In contrast to this, Paul in his highest states has been partly vital (in that the life of ideas was often determined by the life-feeling corresponding to inner organic states), partly motor (in that ideas of movement are frequent in him). The highest could not for him be shaped according to the experiences of the eye or the ear, and the most inward need brings forth unutterable sighs. He has a great capacity to “speak in tongues,” a decidedly motor trait. Life and death appear for him as opposed inner states that are sensed in the limbs. Chasing and struggle, longing and hope, flesh and spirit lie at the foundation of characteristic turns of phrase in the Pauline epistles. Visions and auditory hallucinations are subordinate in relation to sensations of life and movement.—The hallucinations of presence which by some mystics (Saint Teresa and Cécile Vé, for example)³¹ are definitely stated to be different from “imaginative” hallucinations (hallucinations of sight and hearing) probably belong under sensations of life and movement.

In contrast to contemplative or intuitive natures, in whom a concluding total conception easily forms, stand the reflective natures, in whom the activity of thought itself, not its conclusion in a total picture, is the chief matter, and who perhaps even lack the capacity and the need to form and hold fast definite images. Reflection in such natures turns quickly towards the points where the total picture's insufficiency shows itself (where “the similitude” limps), and it perhaps even feels a shudder at the contradiction that arises from the attempt to present the infinite in finite form. Schleiermacher³² is a characteristic example of a reflective type, but at the same time an example of the fact that the intellectual dispositions need not determine the whole type. There is a constant reciprocal relation between the intellectual, the emotional, and the volitional dispositions. In mystics it will especially be the inward feeling that brings with it the conviction of the insufficiency of concepts and images to form an expression. Hereby there arises a certain spiritual kinship between mysticism and criticism, even where they are not united in the same person. Many of the arguments Carneades used against the

dogmatism of the Stoics are found again in the Neoplatonist Plotinus, and in more recent times the combination of mysticism and criticism is not rare either. Living feelings and clear thinking can far more often join hands than one as a rule supposes.

While the last-described form of religious faith is characterized by intellectual dispositions, we come more over into the domain of the will when faith appears as *confident venturing*. Luther and Zwingli have, often in sharp opposition to the Schoolmen's doctrine of faith and knowledge as differing only in degree, strongly emphasized bold confidence (*fiducia*, *Vertrauen*) as faith's essence. Especially in "the Great Catechism" Luther has with energy uttered this thought, so that it even serves him as the foundation for a definition of God: "A God is that from which one is to expect all good, and to which one is to take one's refuge in all distress, so that to have a God is nothing else than to believe and trust him from the heart, as I have often said, that it is the heart's faith and trust alone that produces both a God and an idol. If the faith and the trust are right, then your God too is the right one, and conversely, where the trust is false and wrong, there neither is the right God."³³ In this bold confidence, which indeed presupposes a feeling of disharmony and distress (whereby we are reminded of the first type, see §30), but which aims at this distress's being able to be overcome, indeed at its being overcome, lies Luther's chief thought, the fundamental thought of the new religion he founded without knowing it. If the movement—as in the first type—is to be made again and again from disharmony to harmony, there is no time and strength left over to take part in the interests and works of human life. The bold faith that one is—as regards the essential—well provided for makes it possible, on the other hand, to place oneself in a more positive relation to actual human life and to take part with a full heart in the development of culture. In his little work on "The Freedom of a Christian Man" Luther remarks that the Christian who has made himself the servant of all thereby attains precisely the right to rule over all things. Freedom and the great strength spring from bold confidence in life's ground. This confidence is won (or is presupposed to have been won) through struggle; thereby this type recalls the first and stands in opposition to the second (§31) and the third (§32), which are predominantly characterized by an immediate unfolding of the soul's forces.

33. Yet another type (of the many that are possible besides those now mentioned) must be brought forward. It is characterized by the fact that it gives up its own standard, but otherwise stands nearest to bold venturing (§32). It is determined by *adherence to a model, an authority*; faith is here an echo, a reflex, but an echo that becomes possible through inward devotion to the model. Faith is here therefore grounded not on direct and

independent experience, but on trust in the experience of others. One's own experience is not wholly excluded: it must indeed be experienced that one can lead one's life by building on trust in one's model, find light by being led by the model's light.—Within the relation to the model, which is also a relation of faith, highly different types—thus all those described in what precedes—can come forward again.

There is hardly any human being whose view of life—whether it has the character of religious faith or not—is built right through on his own first-hand experiences. Models and traditions determine us all, and they determine especially also the experiences we come to make and the manner in which we take them up into our life. But where a decisive weight is laid on a certain sum and a certain form of religious ideas as the only valid content of faith, there the dependence on model and authority becomes unconditional and comes at last to stand as the only virtue.

When the Church had by the road of theological speculation worked out a series of doctrines which had to lie far above most human beings' powers of comprehension, it was nevertheless so humane as to declare that in the case of the most speculative doctrines (for example the doctrine of the Trinity) it was not necessary to believe on one's own account, but that it was here enough "to believe something because one believes that the Church believes it." And in this willingness to hold to the Church's faith one found something meritorious, because it sprang from "the love that believes all things." Innocent III and later popes have acknowledged such an "undeveloped faith" (*fides implicita*) in order to secure the unlearned against becoming heretics through innocent errors in theological specialities. It is this kind of faith that has received the name of charcoal-burner's faith, after a tale (reported—somewhat differently—in Luther and in Erasmus of Rotterdam) of a charcoal-burner who, on being asked what he believed, had only this answer: "In what the holy Church believes!"—without his being able to say what it then was that the holy Church believed.³⁴

In his Protestant zeal Luther declared that he who had no other faith than this charcoal-burner's went to hell. But the Protestant Church cannot—as little as any church—dispense with charcoal-burner's faith. When it distinguishes between the individual believer's experiences and "the church community's common experience," and when something is to be believed that by the nature of the case cannot be an object of personal experience, then it is impossible to avoid the acknowledgement of indirect faith (*fides implicita*). It is Protestantism's honour that it has so energetically asserted the individual's duty to make his own experiences and draw his own conclusions; but it has dragged so much along with it from the old Church—for example the doctrine of the Trinity, precisely the

doctrine that gave the medieval Church occasion to set up the concept of *fides implicita*—that it is an illusion when one believes one can dispense with this concept.—Besides, this concept has its great humane and pedagogical significance. All human beings begin their development with childlike adherence to authorities and models. Their first expressions of freedom consist in their experiences leading them to choose other models than the original ones, when they are not confirmed in adherence to these by the course of life. Development can lead to an increasing predominance of the results of independent experience, and in quite a few—the great ones in the world of the spirit—creative self-activity goes so far in depth and extent that they themselves come to stand as models for the race.

The spirit of Protestantism demands that access to free investigation of experience, its foundation and its results, stand constantly open. Traditions and models must be investigated with historical criticism. Psychology must test whether the “experiences” are natural and immediate; logic must investigate the inner coherence of the assumptions; ethics must discuss the genuineness of the values. If this testing is ever cut off, one ends in barbarism or in convulsive attempts to hold fast the absurd. The religious consciousness has a tendency to drag traditions along with it which have neither religious, intellectual, nor ethical significance, dead values that can no longer really be lived through by anyone, but which one dares not throw away for fear that they should draw more with them in their fall. As RUDOLF EUCKEN has said: “one holds fast the impossible in order not to lose the necessary.”

Every personal development begins with childlike adherence to transmitted ideas; but there may be many degrees and nuances in the manner in which one later draws nourishment from the tradition or step by step removes oneself from it. Some natures never notice any difference between their own lived experiences and the transmitted symbols. Others notice a difference but shudder back from it, fearing the apparently self-abandoned “subjectivity,” and throw themselves, with greater or lesser personal truthfulness and intellectual honesty, back into the common forms. There are peculiarly ecclesiastical natures who live and breathe immediately in what is transmitted, and who are always able to find both the end and the beginning of their experiences in the transmitted forms. An immediate unity of word and experience, of name and thing, prevails in them. They have no need for individual symbol-formation, which often hinders spiritual fellowship, but will on the contrary be inclined to make the possibility of such a fellowship, of a church, the criterion of the genuineness of experience and faith. Even for theologians of liberal tendency the possibility of forming a congregation

and founding a cult is the mark that a real religion is present: "Only in the capacity to found a cult does the genuine religion, borne by unbroken conviction, make itself known" (Troeltsch). What matters is then not what the individual has lived through and uttered, but whether a congregation can gather and a tradition form about definite facts and ideas (Kaftan).³⁵—In modern theological discussions the invocation of the congregation therefore plays a great role.—A dominant tendency in the history of religion is so far in agreement with this, in that it designates its task as that of presenting the faith of peoples, of the great masses, and not the faith of the individual great personalities, however significant this may be.

34. It is more individual types that we have hitherto brought forward. I now pass over to the great differences that have found their expression in the highest popular religions. These types have developed under reciprocal action between older religious traditions, racial characters, and the experiences of centuries. There appear here especially two chief types of deep and abiding significance for spiritual development.

The one chief type is characterized by a need to raise oneself above the struggle for existence, *to be freed from change and opposition, from all "twoness" and difference*. With difference follows suffering, with change follows unrest, and the suffering and the unrest bring it about that one sets oneself as an end the attainment of better states—but these are attained only to prepare a so much the more bitter disappointment! This whole surging is to be halted and abolished. Only in the eternal and unchangeable is there rest! But since all ideas are drawn from experience's world of difference and instability, no positive expression can characterize the eternal and unchangeable state that is yearned for. And since all change and movement is an illusion, this very yearning comes at last—when that state is attained—to stand as an illusion. One yearns to be free of all yearning.

This type recalls partly the first (§30), partly the third (§32) of the individual types. *Indian religiosity*, especially as it was concluded in Buddhism's doctrine of Nirvana, is the most characteristic example of it. Nirvana is not pure nothing. It is a form of existence to which none of the properties that ever-shifting experience presents applies, and which therefore, in relation to the states we know from experience, comes to stand as a nothing. It is a liberation from all need and suffering, from hatred and passion, from death and birth. It is attained by the highest degree of concentration of thought and will of which the human being is capable.³⁶—In *Neoplatonism* and in *the mysticism of the Middle Ages* kindred traits are found.—In all religiosity the opposition between the unchangeable and the changeable plays an essential role; but in this chief type it is the wholly decisive

thing.

With the second chief type it is likewise a matter of redemption from strife, but the opposites do not here stand equal, for the human being attaches himself to one of the contending powers, so that redemption is reached through this power's victory, and not merely through the human being's being raised above the sphere where there can be any question of strife at all. Life is a strife between good and evil powers. This strife shall and must be carried to its end; it has a positive reality, and everything depends on which side the human being has attached himself to while the strife goes on.—*The doctrine of Zarathustra and Christianity* are the great representatives of this chief type, whose significance rests on the decisive weight laid on *historical development* and ethical striving. Time and *life in time* acquire here undoubted reality. (Cf. §11.)

There are naturally many intermediate forms between the two chief types and many combinations of them, already for the reason that the one chief type historically works upon the other. The Indian-Greek type has through Neoplatonism worked upon the Christian type, and the collision and reciprocal action of the two types is noticeable in Augustine's thought, so influential for the whole European development. The opposition between the unchangeable and the changeable has a tendency to thrust itself forward in place of the opposition between good and evil. The proposition that God is the most changeable of all beings, which has been uttered by a religious personality within Christianity, could not have been uttered by an Indian or a Greek, scarcely even by Augustine.

Common to both chief types is that there is experienced an opposition between times in which the goal (whether it be redemption from the strife, or victory in the strife) stands as reached or at least as certain and present, and other times in which darkness, dullness, and hopelessness prevail. And these states will mutually heighten one another by *contrast-effect*: for him who has known the high and bright states, where one feels oneself in unity with the highest, dark and depressed states become doubly painful and comfortless, while conversely the former acquire a double radiance by their opposition to the latter. Here there is use for faith (as faithfulness, see §29), in order that there may be continuity in the personal life. The bright moments easily come, in the dark moments, to stand as illusions. What matters then is to hold fast the right connection, in firm conviction that even the dark times can purify and strengthen, and that all value is not extinguished even in times when one must "do without all consolation."—That these oscillations must be stronger and more frequent within the second chief type than within the first is a natural consequence of the two types' distinctive characters

severally. Within the second chief type, where the temporal relation acquires decisive significance, there will be a far greater difference between the different moments, and there will perhaps even be a need to live through and endure extreme states, to oscillate between opposite moods, in order that the consciousness of victory may be the more glorious. In cult this need will especially manifest itself.

35. To the concept of faith corresponds the concept of God. From a purely theoretical (epistemological-metaphysical) standpoint the concept of God can only mean the principle of existence's continuity and thereby of its intelligibility. From a religious standpoint God means—as faith's object—the principle of the persistence of value through all oscillations and all struggles—if one will: the principle of faithfulness in existence. If the religious problem could be completely solved, it would have to be demonstrable that these two principles—the persistence of energy and of value—quite coincide. The analogy between them is clear; but from that there is a great step to their identity, and it is a great question whether this step can be taken in such a way that it leads to a contradiction-free concept. We shall in another connection come back to this question.

Religious experience may be said to be an experience of "God," in so far as it leads to a faith in the persistence of value in spite of everything and through everything. He who would experience "God" must train his eye to find a valuable kernel behind reality's hard shell, and train his mind in patient hope that such a kernel will always be able to be found. He who would work for "God's kingdom" must work to find, bring forth, and assert the valuable. "Thou feelest him each time thy heart beats with holy desire; thou hearest him in thy best thoughts as an eternal voice."

Of the justification for using the word God in this manner there holds what was remarked above (§26) about the word religion. Psychologically the kinship between different standpoints is often greater than it might purely dogmatically seem.

As regards the hypothesis of religion's essence as faith in the persistence of value, the investigation in the section of the psychology of religion that we here conclude has on the whole confirmed it, in that a discussion of the nature of religious experience and religious faith has decidedly led us to see its probability. Religious experience acquires its distinctive character by being experience concerning the relation between value and reality, and religious faith acquires its distinctive character by not merely itself being a firm, continuous direction in the mind, but also by asserting a continuity of value through all existence's oscillations. But we shall in a later section (D) return to it in order to test how far the most significant forms of positive religion can be traced back to it.

3.2 The Development of Religious Ideas

3.2.1 Religion as Drive

*Various enough have been the religious symbols, as men stood in
this stage of culture or the other and could worse or better
body-forth the Godlike.*

CARLYLE.

36. The philosophy of religion has neither any ground nor any capacity for investigating religion's historical beginning. Its task is to treat the religious problem as this presents itself for us now, under our present conditions of culture. To that end it uses, among other things, the history of religion; but it interests itself more in the question whether, in spite of the changing forms of religion, a constantly operative foundation for religion can be pointed out, than in the historical origin of religion. And even if one could point out the historical beginning of all religion, this would hardly have any philosophy-of-religion significance. From a being's first beginning one cannot always learn anything with respect to its real nature, for the transformations and displacements that take place during development can bring about properties that could not be observed in the first beginning. A being's real nature consists in the law of its whole development.

For the history of religion too, religion's first beginning in the human race will probably continue to stand as an unsolved problem. Even the lowest-standing savages we know have run through a long development. One merely cuts the knot if one assumes that any of the now existing religions should be the primal religion. And at any rate this primal religion, if it could be found, would not necessarily be the "real" religion, so that if it could for example be shown that religious development in the human race began with fetishism, then all religion should "really" be fetishism. It is an inference of the same kind as that according to which, by Darwinism, the human being is "really" an ape. Inferences of this kind are drawn both from theological and from anti-theological standpoints. It rests on a complete misunderstanding of the nature of all development. From the theological side one has for the most part thought it necessary to assume a primal revelation to the first human beings, a perfect religion which they lost by a falling away; and this primal revelation one then constructed out of one's own religion, which was to be its restitution. The fetishism theory has after all a more natural stamp. For, of two things one, it is nevertheless easier to understand that the more perfect can develop out of the more imperfect than that the more imperfect should spring from the perfect.

For when the perfect contains the possibility of, or the germ of, the imperfect, it is not perfect; whereas the imperfect can, by supplementation or by transformation, develop in the direction of perfection. History shows us no first beginning of religion, but a series of different, lower and higher forms of religion, a series that does not advance evenly, but swings back and forth, even though through all the oscillations a general direction of development can be traced, especially as regards the religious ideas, the most easily accessible side of religion.

When we start from the description of religious phenomena given in what precedes, we must expect that religion everywhere unfolds on the basis of a certain conception of reality. The human being cannot have religious feeling when he cannot to a certain degree arrange his observations of the world. Religious feeling is indeed determined by experience of the relation between value and reality, and thus presupposes that a reality is known. In investigating the development of religious ideas I shall proceed by beginning with the simplest forms of religious idea and advancing to the more composite, everywhere trying to explain to myself the transition from one stage to another on the basis of purely psychological laws.

37. In characterizing the most elementary forms of religion one has often laid too great weight on the ideas, in that one has made primitive religion one with primitive conception of the world. In spite of their great merit in the science of religion, the English investigators, especially TYLOR, SPENCER, and FRAZER, have nevertheless given way too much to the tendency to conceive religion as a matter of knowledge, and in the elementary religions have predominantly laid weight on certain ideas, their associations and their displacements. Elementary or primitive religion was then described as belief in spirits. In contrast to this the French sociological school, especially ÉMILE DURKHEIM, has maintained that belief in spirits is indeed found everywhere where there is primitive religion, but that it is not the foundation but is derived. The foundation is everywhere formed by a deep need to feel oneself at one with what can bear and secure life. It is by virtue of this need that the human being distinguishes between the holy and the profane, the fundamental religious distinction, which at the most elementary stage known, for example among the Central Australians, is a distinction between what conditions the tribe's persistence and welfare and what is indifferent or hostile to it. The individual feels himself at this stage in solidarity with the tribe to which he belongs, and therefore with the totem, the natural object that stands as the expression of the tribe and its conditions of life. Through the tribe's cult its totem is secured, nourished, and honoured, and through the individual's participation in this cult he becomes a partaker in the holy and

in its sustaining power. Cult is a social power through which influence is exercised not only on the minds of human beings, but also on the course of nature, on fertility, rain, and successful hunting.

Through the characterization Durkheim (in his work *Les formes élémentaires de la vie religieuse*)³⁷ has given of the most elementary religion known, I find confirmation on two chief points of the philosophy-of-religion theory I maintain. It shows in the first place that religion's foundation does not lie in the intellectual domain, but must be sought in a need that is not bound up with clear consciousness, a need for the securing and unfolding of life. And it shows in the second place that when we try to interpret this religious need, it is to be conceived as a need to hold fast a persistence of the valuable that is experienced, out beyond the limits within which human beings can work for it.

Since the totem is common to the tribe and stands fast through the changing generations, the idea of the forefathers naturally acquires a prominent place; their souls are assumed to be constantly at work, and a belief in spirits forms on the basis of the customs of the cult and as an attempt to interpret them. In its further development this belief in spirits can become a conception of the world, whose traces can be pointed out right up into the highest religions. This conception of the world, which is found again everywhere on earth among human beings who stand at the lowest stage of development we know, one is accustomed to call (after TYLOR)³⁸ *animism*. Animism is a conception of the world, not in itself a religion. But it acquires interest for the philosophy of religion because it is the most elementary conception of the world that religion has taken into its service. Its distinctive character consists in this, that events—especially striking events—are explained by the intervention of souls, of personal beings. Its arising is due in great part to the influence of dream-ideas: in dreams the savage gets experiences that must stand for him as just as valid as the experiences of waking life, and in these dream-experiences he himself and other beings—human beings and animals, the living and the dead—appear in a freer manner, more independent of space, time, and material conditions, than the experiences of waking life led him to regard as possible. The dream-world, which here stands as indubitable reality, is then consistently used to explain and supplement the world of waking life. Consciousness is especially taken up with the spirits of the dead; in their lifetime these beings had intervened more or less deeply in what went on; it is then natural that one supposes oneself to trace their doings and workings now too, since from the dreams about them one knows that they not merely continue to exist, but even exist under more perfect conditions. The involuntary tendency to personify, to conceive things after the likeness of ourselves and therefore to conceive natural processes as

personal actions, had to be supported by these ideas, even if these alone should not be enough to explain animism.

Animism occurs among all tribes round about on the earth at a certain lower stage of their development. It is the human being's most elementary philosophy. And even in the highest, most fully formed religions, with their ideal conceptions of gods, exact and unprejudiced investigation meets many traces of this circle of ideas.

38. In totemism the individual's ideas are predominantly determined by the tribe's. But within the social tradition individual processes of ideation can nevertheless be traced, and such are indeed also a presupposition of the social tradition's coming into being, even if it hides in the darkness of the ages. The individual does not always hold to the tribe's fetishes (the objects to which a magical effect is attached), but may choose himself a fetish on his own account. It is then a single definite object, a special occasion, that leads the human being to assume a power that decides whether something valuable for him happens or not. In such a process of choice is contained the simplest formation of religious ideas we can imagine. The choice is quite elementary and involuntary, just as elementary and involuntary as the exclamation that is the simplest form of value-judgment. The object that is chosen must in one way or another stand in connection with what strongly occupies the mind. It perhaps awakens the memory of earlier events at which it was present or played a role. Or it presents a certain likeness, often very distant likeness, to objects that formerly helped in distress. Or it is quite simply the first object the human being catches sight of in his state of strained expectation. It fixes attention upon itself and is involuntarily placed in real connection with what is to come about—with the possibility of attaining the goal one has set oneself. It may be both hope and fear that leads to this choice; probably it is from the first predominantly hope, for the human being is sanguine by nature. There is no reason why it should be fear alone that creates gods. It seems, to be sure, to be a rule that evil beings are worshipped rather than good beings; but they may be worshipped in hope that one can make them favourably disposed.

In such phenomena religion appears as *drive*. The first manner in which ideas (as different from sensations) appear is as elements in drive (according to the usage that distinguishes between drive and mere instinct). Drive contains an idea of something that can satisfy a need or in general cause pleasure, and the idea has here therefore immediate practical significance. The thirsty man's idea of water is quite practical, expresses the goal of the yearning and is held fast by the need or by the expectation. Thereby the thirsty man's idea of water is different from the chemist's or from the painter's. Religious

ideas are religious only by this connection with need and expectation, thus as elements in a drive. One and the same idea can therefore look highly different from the religious standpoint and from the theoretical-psychological or the historical-critical standpoint, and one understands the significance of religious ideas only when one holds fast the connection with drive that is their real soil. Fetishism in particular is understood only in this way. When the young Indian is to choose his "medicine" (thus he calls his fetish or talisman), he withdraws into solitude and gives himself up to fasting; the first animal he meets when he again leaves his solitary dwelling becomes his "medicine." A negro goes out of his tent in the morning to set out on an expedition and sees a stone lying glittering in the sunshine; involuntarily he takes it to himself and relies on its help. In such examples the religious idea is formed or chosen by a kind of *improvisation*.

There need be no connection between the different religious improvisations, although habit and tradition will soon exercise their influence. The fetish is provisionally merely the momentary dwelling of a spirit. It is what HERMANN USENER has aptly called a *momentary god*: "In full immediacy the individual phenomenon is deified, without any generic concept, however limited, playing a part. The individual thing that you see before you, and nothing else, is the god!" As examples Usener refers to the custom among the old Prussians and Lithuanians whereby the first or the last sheaf in the field is treated as the dwelling of a god who had to be celebrated if the corn harvest was to be good, and to the bouquet of Saint John's wort that young Lithuanian girls plucked and set on a pole at the entrance to the house, and which was worshipped with reverence. Both the sheaf and the Saint John's wort were originally fetishes. Among the Greeks similar examples are found, as when a hero in Aeschylus swears by his sword.³⁹

The tendency to form such momentary gods can constantly be traced in the involuntary personifying and symbolizing that can make itself felt when one stands in a living and interested relation to things in the surrounding world. One may for example find an omen for the outcome of an undertaking begun in the circumstance that one succeeds in getting the fire to burn in the stove: the momentary expectation that arises during the work with the refractory fuel passes over by feeling-expansion to apply to the greater undertaking with which consciousness is constantly occupied. With this expansion there then follows the idea of the successfully produced fire as a kind of helping and encouraging genius. When one notices the kind of momentary mythologizing that does not occur seldom, one has in it a hint towards understanding the most elementary formation of religious ideas. Only that what is for us now merely a fleeting meteor on consciousness's horizon becomes a guiding star at animism's standpoint.

39. Momentary gods can historically be pointed out only approximately. For on the same occasion the human being naturally returns to the same idea of a god, and this is then not produced anew in each single case, for example at each new harvest. The gods then gradually appear each with certain constant properties and with dominion over certain definite domains. By the constant property and the definite domain the individual god acquires a firmer form in consciousness. Just as development is needed to raise oneself above the individual moment, so development is also needed to raise oneself above the individual special manner of expression and the individual special domain. But it is nevertheless an advance when what is constant in property and domain leads out beyond what is momentary in the simplest ideas of gods. Therefore *the special gods* (A. Lang's departmental gods, Usener's *Sondergötter*) denote an advance in relation to the momentary gods. Thought does not yet, however, raise itself above multiplicity and differences, but assumes a principle, a guiding power, for each distinctive domain. A New Zealand chief said to a European: "Is there among the Europeans only a single one who produces all things? But there is one who is a carpenter, another who is a smith, a third who is a shipbuilder. And so it was in the beginning too. One produced this, another that. Tane produced trees, Ru mountains, Tangaroa fish, and so forth."

Usener has especially pointed out this stage in the development of religious ideas in the older Roman religion, as it was before the Greek influence. In the liturgical books of the Roman priests (the so-called *indigitamenta*) were found lists of the special gods who from ancient times were invoked each on his special occasion and in his special capacity (*dii proprii, dii certi*). "For all actions and states that could be of importance to the human being of the time, distinctive gods have been created, and they are named by specially formed words; not merely actions and states as wholes are in this manner deified, but also all more prominent sections, acts, moments within the actions and states." Thus in the cultivation of the field one invoked not merely the earth (Tellus) and the god of fertility (Ceres), but twelve special gods: one for the first working of the fallow, another for the second ploughing, a third for the last drawing of the furrows, a fourth for the sowing, a fifth for the ploughing-in of the seed, and so on and so on.—Among the Lithuanians and the Greeks too such special gods, restricted to a single property and a very limited domain, can be pointed out, and—we may add—they are found among nature-peoples round about on the earth.⁴⁰

Such special gods correspond—like the momentary gods—to a need in the religious consciousness to know a power in its neighbourhood that is exclusively taken up with bringing it the help that is needed. The old special gods often pass under altered names

into the new religions. Christianity's saints often appear with properties and functions that show that they are the heirs of the special gods; often a saint is worshipped at the same place where in antiquity a corresponding special god was worshipped. The saints have their departments like their predecessors, and they satisfy, like these, the need for professional divinities. It is taken from life when a young Roman girl in one of Ludvig Bødtcher's Italian poems answers the question whether she is not afraid of earthquakes: "Ah, Madonna graciously protects our little house well enough, and when the danger really approaches, St. Emidius helps." St. Emidius is precisely the special protector against earthquakes.—An interesting example of continuity in the development of religious ideas Usener gives in the idea of the mother with the child. She is first worshipped as a special goddess under the name of "the child-nourisher" (Kurotrophos)—without a proper name. Later this name (Kurotrophos) became an epithet of different goddesses (Leto, Demeter), and her worship glided over into the medieval worship of the Madonna with the child. This continuity testifies that precisely towards this figure of a god, which represented motherly love, there has been present a distinctive need for adoration.

In the opinion of some, the Jewish people's oldest god is to be regarded as a special god. "The Jahvism of the earlier time," remarks a historian of religion, "was a power hostile to culture. Jahveh meets us above all as destroyer: storm-god in nature, war-god in the life of the people—the god to whom, after a victory won by fighting, everything living is consecrated to death!" Only through reciprocal action with the ideas of gods of other tribes is the Jewish idea of God said to have acquired its universal significance and taken up elements that could make Jahveh a divinity for a people of culture.⁴¹

3.2.2 Polytheism and Monotheism

40. The drive-like personifying that is characteristic of the religious consciousness in its most elementary form does not yet produce ideas of personal beings in the proper sense. A personal being possesses at once several different properties; it is the bond of unity between them, just as it is the bond of unity between the different moments in which its life unfolds. The formation of ideas of such beings presupposes a spiritual development that cannot be present at the most childlike stages. It is a distinctive mark of the ideas of children and savages that they attach themselves to a single side and property of the thing and recognize it by that; hence the baroque juxtapositions and the many confusions to which both the child's and the savage's speech testifies. There must be acquired a capacity to raise oneself above the momentary and the special and to connect the individual experiences into a whole, for a personal being is not exhausted by

a single situation or a single property. It is the capacity to form typical individual ideas that must be present. A typical individual idea is an idea that fits an individual being in all the different states in which it appears. Great art is needed to form such ideas when they are to hold for beings that are of a more composite nature and in constant development, and a complete conclusion of such ideas is often not possible. Our ideas of personal beings as a rule acquire an artistic rounding-off that cannot be fully grounded by observation, and our knowledge of a personal being's distinctive character is rather a faith than a knowledge.

Just as the transition from individual observations and individual ideas to typical individual ideas is psychologically regarded one of the most significant transitions within the life of ideas, so the transition from momentary and special gods to properly personal gods is one of the most significant transitions within the history of religion. It is the transition from animism to polytheism. A more definite distinction is now drawn between the divine beings and the natural phenomena to which they are attached. The figures of the gods themselves acquire a richer and deeper content, and only now can there be any question of a proper faith, since there is now a relation of distance between the god and his manner of revelation which could not be present at the more elementary stages of development. There lies here one of the rare advances in the history of religion that benefits at once science and faith. By the more definite difference between the gods and the individual natural phenomena, these latter can the more readily become the object of objective observation and investigation. If science stands in any debt to religion, this was incurred rather at the transition from fetishism to polytheism, not, as has been supposed, at the transition from polytheism to monotheism. But first and foremost that transition benefited religious faith, since the figures of the gods could now become deeper and richer and be attached in a more inward manner to the life of feeling, when individual natural phenomena no longer stood as the immediately corresponding expression for them. The human being has now begun to live in an invisible world.

The significance of this epoch in the history of religion has already been strongly and aptly emphasized by AUGUSTE COMTE. In later times HERMANN USENER has, on the basis of interesting historical and linguistic investigations, strongly stressed it. When this excellent historian of religion reproaches the philosophers of religion for letting religious development begin with polytheism, Comte's example already shows that this reproach is unfounded. And no less unfounded is the remark that the philosophers "treat concept-formation and the gathering of the individual into species and genus as a self-evident and necessary process in the human spirit." In Aristotle already the problem

of individual concepts appears, and in more recent philosophy it has since John Locke's time been discussed again and again. When in psychology a distinction is drawn between individual ideas (corresponding to a single trait, a single property), concrete individual ideas (corresponding to a phenomenon in a single, definite situation), typical individual ideas (corresponding to a series of different observations of the same phenomenon), and general ideas (concepts of species and genus, corresponding to a series of observations of related phenomena)—there is thereby given a satisfactory framework within which the phenomena of religious history stressed by Usener can also find their place. The transition from the one kind of ideas to the other naturally does not take place without hindrances and always presupposes favourable inner and outer conditions.

Usener has especially shown that only at a certain stage of development, namely at the coming-into-being of polytheism, do the gods acquire proper names. The special gods are named only adjectivally, after the individual properties with which they appear. As an example may be named Apollo, who is characterized as the light-bringer, the god of prophecy, the god of song, the reconciler, or the god of healing. Usener ascribes to the formation of proper names for the gods a decisive significance as a condition of the transition from momentary and special gods to personal gods. But there is here as everywhere a constant reciprocal relation between idea and word. The proper name becomes intelligible only when several properties and states can be gathered up in one idea. The word is a help and a support for holding fast and developing a result won in the life of ideas, but cannot be the exclusive cause. Usener therefore also expresses himself somewhat waveringly. Sometimes he lets "concept-formation stiffen into a proper name," or he lets "language help to pave the way"—here, then, the reciprocal relation between the formation of ideas and the formation of words is acknowledged. With the bare word a significant period in the history of religion cannot begin. The word cannot be the beginning or be in the beginning.⁴²

Historically one naturally cannot sharply point out the beginning of polytheism. When momentary and special gods already presuppose a "personifying" tendency and capacity, and when—especially on account of the influence of habit and tradition—pure momentary and special gods can hardly be pointed out, it already follows from this that there are many transitional links between the stages that we here in theory place in sharp opposition to one another. The same will show itself to hold of the relation between polytheism and monotheism.

41. Neither the development of ideas nor the formation of words gives in and for itself an exhaustive explanation of the transition to polytheism. There constantly co-operates

an influence from the life of feeling. The historians of religion strongly emphasize *the conservative, restraining influence* of cult, and thereby of the life of feeling, for in cult feeling has its immediate foothold. When a cult in a region or among a people has been organized about a special god, it becomes a hindrance to the formation and acknowledgement of more composite ideas of gods. The influence that cult has on the religious life of ideas appears strikingly in the very word God, when we hold to those etymologies of this word that are said to have the greatest probability on their side linguistically, according to which the word properly means "he to whom sacrifice is made," or "he who is invoked."⁴³ The connection between the idea of God and cult brings it about that a thoroughgoing alteration in the former must effect an alteration in the latter, and here now, by the experience of all ages, the organized cult offers a strong, often violent resistance. Old ideas maintain themselves long by being attached to old customs, and old customs can maintain themselves longer than the corresponding ideas. In a village church in Zealand it is said to have been the custom even in the nineteenth century that one made a bow when one passed a certain place on the church wall, but no one knew why one did it, until on the scraping away of the whitewash a picture of a saint was found on the wall: the custom had thus survived Catholicism by three centuries; it was a part of the old cult that had maintained itself. Here it was now a matter of mere habit. But the life of feeling will on the whole only slowly leave the bed once formed for it. It has accommodated itself to the transmitted ideas, and a transitional time full of unrest and disharmony must be lived through before the accommodation to the new ideas can be accomplished. In such a transitional time the two tendencies in the life of feeling, the tendency to remain in the old bed and the tendency to expansion, wage a hard struggle with one another. Or rather: the struggle is waged between the old and the new feelings' tendency to spread over and colour the whole of consciousness; the feelings attached to what is transmitted have namely also an expansive tendency, and they will constantly try to colour and transform the new ideas which they cannot wholly displace;—in case of need the old ideas are transformed after the new, when only in that way can they be preserved.

The restraining and inhibiting influence of feeling on the life of ideas is, however, only the one side of the matter. The new experiences can work so penetratingly that an alteration of the ideas takes place through *selection, idealization, and combination*.—USENER, who otherwise lays the chief weight on the development of words and ideas, therefore also remarks that the different special gods cannot have the same value for consciousness: "The god of the heavenly light that bestows life and blessing, the tutelary

god of the house and of the peace of the house, the saviour, the averter of all evil, must each have far greater significance than a god who makes the harrowing or the weeding succeed well." The special gods that awaken the strongest and most lasting feelings will come to rule over the others.—As objects of particular attention they will acquire a distinctive place; comparison with other divinities will be kept away, and consciousness will on the whole not dwell on what could leave them standing as limited. There thereby takes place an involuntary idealization.—With the selection and the idealization there naturally combines a combination, in that all valuable properties and effects that present any likeness to or contact with a god's original attribute will be referred to him. He stands once for all as the author of something especially valuable, and the new valuable thing that is experienced is then involuntarily referred to him too.—

The history of the light-gods is an interesting example of this development. Light's great significance for everything living, by effecting the more vigorous and healthy course of the life-process and by making activity and security possible, and its ideal significance as a symbol of truth and justice, condition transitions of ideas of the most manifold kind, which are nevertheless always borne by the immediate experiences of the value of light and of the forces symbolized by light.

Quite especially will those gods that stand as guardians of common goods—as the protectors of the family, the clan, or the people—become the object of these different processes. When the human being in his life together with others and in his own inner life experiences the opposition between good and evil, and when this opposition acquires a predominant place in his consciousness, he will also transfer these ideas in idealized form to his gods. The idealizing personification will become of great ethical significance by creating radiant divine models for human life. The transition hereby takes place from nature-religion to ethical religion, a transition that has rightly been called the most important in the whole history of religion, but which takes place according to the same laws as all other transitions. Just as little as human beings would have believed in the thunder-god if they did not experience the power of thunder, just as little would they have believed in good gods if they did not experience the good as a reality in life. The idea of the gods as the bearers of the ethical values in existence presupposes that the human being has himself come to know these values. (Cf. §26.)—

Besides the inhibiting, selecting, idealizing, and combining influence that feeling can exercise on the development of ideas, the significance of *contrast-effects* in the domain of feeling must further be emphasized. The contrast between two moods will react back upon the ideas in which the two moods severally find expression, or by which they

are motivated. If an ideal idea has thus been formed, the ideal will be further raised in power by the opposition between the perfection represented and the human being's own limitation, and conversely this limitation will be represented the more glaringly, the brighter the mood that the idea of the ideal had called forth. This moment is therefore of importance not only in the development of the figures of the gods, but also in the development of the consciousness of sin, which plays so great a role in many religions.

42. Outside the circle of the properly divine ideas, the belief in the transmigration of souls presents a good example of the selecting and transforming influence of the feelings. The idea that souls after death pass over into other bodies has hardly arisen in the first instance from religious motives. It hangs together with general animism and has arisen among different peoples round about on the earth at a very early stage of their development. It is frequent among East Asian peoples; it is found among the Central Australians, the Guineans, and the Zulus; among the Greenlanders and among North American tribes we meet with it too.

Now we find that it plays a very great role in Indian religion after the Vedic age. In the Upanishads it is of great significance, while it is not found in the Indians' earlier religion as this appears in the Vedic poems. It has then been supposed that the doctrine of the transmigration of souls arose because religious thought sought to explain to itself the great inequality which, already as regards original endowments and conditions, shows itself to be present between human beings in an ethical respect. What could not be explained as an effect of the human being's conduct in this life, the old Vedanta thinkers are then supposed to have explained as an effect of his conduct in earlier existences. By a similar road the Pythagoreans and Plato are supposed to have come to the mythical idea of the transmigration of souls. According to this conception, which is espoused by DEUSSEN,⁴⁴ the need for redemption among the Indians has partly created the idea of a transmigration of souls, in order to explain the inequality in inner and outer conditions, and partly developed the idea of absorption into Brahman (and later of Nirvana), so that the two ideas arose independently of one another.

This conception in the excellent connoisseur of Indian philosophy hangs together, however, certainly with his overlooking animism's constant after-effects, which can be traced in the exalted Vedanta doctrine itself. In the Upanishads' emphasis on the significance of the dream-state one notices one of the fundamental thoughts that are distinctive of animism. "In sleep," it is said, "the spirit casts off everything that belongs to the body and floats up and down, creating for itself, like a god, all manner of shapes." Indeed, even the naive consequence of the animistic dream-theory is not lacking, that

one must not too hastily wake the sleeping, since “it is impossible to heal a human being whose spirit has not found its way back to him.”⁴⁵—When even the Vedanta doctrine itself thus contains traces of very elementary ideas that are akin to the ideas of the transmigration of souls, then the most correct explanation of the great role that the doctrine of the transmigration of souls came from a certain point of time to play is perhaps that this doctrine was not produced all at once by an artificial speculation, but that it arose because older ideas (perhaps among subjugated peoples), to which one had hitherto ascribed no religious significance, now—as a consequence of an alteration in the religious life of feeling—were taken up into the circle of the properly religious ideas and interpreted as the expression of religious experience. Under the overwhelming impression of life’s evils and restless doings one could explain to oneself the unhappy conditions of life only as a consequence of the earlier existences to which popular belief testified, and one besides took so dark a view of things that not even death brought peace, when there was no security against a new life in finite form following after. RICHARD GARBE thus connects (in his work on the Sankhya philosophy) the significance that the old doctrine of the transmigration of souls now acquired with a remarkable change in the whole feeling for life of the ancient Indians. “In the old Vedic time there ruled in India a bright view of life, in which we see no germ of the later idea [of life as a burden] that dominated and cowed the whole people’s manner of thought; one did not yet feel life as a burden, but as the greatest of all goods, and one hoped for a life after death as the reward for a pious life. All at once there enters—without our gaze being able to find transitional stages—in place of this childlike joy in life the conviction that the individual’s life is only an agonizing wandering from death to death.”⁴⁶ If this explanation is the right one, there lies here a classical example of how an alteration in feeling works selectively, idealizingly, and intensifyingly upon the ideas. At the same time the contrast-effect here comes out clearly: for in opposition to the constant life-process, not interrupted even by death, with its unrest and despondency, the complete abolition of temporal and finite existence had now to become the goal. The doctrine of redemption of the Vedanta and of Buddhism unfolds in a definite relation of contrast to the doctrine of the transmigration of souls.

A striking analogy to this course of development is presented by the development of Greek religion in the time between Homer and Plato. Here too it was under the influence of a new and darker view of life that the belief in the transmigration of souls was taken up and applied within the circle of religious ideas, and the concern for the soul’s fate in another world, a concern that was unknown in Homer, became prevalent in

wide circles.⁴⁷—The idea of personal immortality has on the whole hardly had religious significance in the first instance; it is due to the circle of ideas from which animism sprang, and has only later, under the influence partly of an altered feeling for life, partly of ethical ideas, furnished motives for the development of religious ideas.

An instructive counterpart to the significance that the doctrine of the transmigration of souls acquired for the Indians and the Greeks at a certain point of their development is afforded by this doctrine's appearance among the Egyptians. The Egyptians assumed, indeed, that the soul after death could pass over into different shapes; but this transmigration of souls was not at all placed in connection with ethical ideas.⁴⁸ One has here had no use for a motive that became of such great effect in Indian and in Greek religion.

43. I now return to polytheism. Its development presents a swarm of psychological and historical processes which the history of religion does not give sufficient material to illuminate, and which psychological analysis, even were it more perfect than it is, would hardly ever be able to unravel. What can be traced nevertheless testifies that in the religious domain no other psychological and logical laws prevail than in the other domains of the life of the spirit.

It might seem to be a psychological absurdity in polytheism that the human being here feels himself dependent on several different divine beings. The one of these seems as though it must come to stand in the way of the other; the thought of the one seems as though it must displace the thought of the other. The religion of drive already, with its momentary and special gods, could call forth this astonishment.—The solution lies in the fact that the human being in the moments of lived experience and emotion is so completely absorbed in what now stands before the imagination that no juxtaposition and comparison, perhaps not even any recollection of other gods, takes place. There is indeed on the whole in the spiritual life a rhythmic alternation of immediate absorption and of reflection. In the moments of reflection we can juxtapose and compare the ideas that have made themselves felt in us in the moments of strong and deep moods. There may then perhaps show themselves contradictions that must be abolished, and that we strive to abolish, in so far as new lived experiences do not seize us so strongly that we forget reflection's difficulties and problems. This holds at all stages of religious development and for all religious standpoints. During this rhythmic alternation the one wave will nevertheless be able to acquire influence on the other. When it is then real difficulties that reflection brings forward, there will slowly take place an alteration in the character of the lived experiences, just as conversely reflection is altered by the experiences of the enraptured moments. There will always be an involuntary tendency

to bring about harmony between the ideas that in the different lived experiences have come to stand as the expression of feeling's object. On polytheism's ground the solution will here lie in the idea of a race of gods or a world of gods, within which each individual god has his definite place. It will be so much the easier here to find a solution because there stand ready to hand obvious analogies from human relations. Partly the family, partly the state can furnish models for the harmonious co-operation of personal beings, and it is not least through these analogies that human beings' ethical-social development acquires influence on the ideas of gods. The relation between gods and human beings too is presented by the help of these analogies, as when the god is called the father and lord of human beings, and when the world is represented as a great state, common to gods and human beings.

Nowhere does the process of religious ideation run its course under the exclusive influence of a people's own experiences. The ideas of other peoples work along with them by reason of peaceful intercourse or conquest. The different worlds of gods collide when the peoples collide, and a historian of religion has even set up the proposition that "religion has never at any time developed except when several different religions have come into contact with one another."⁴⁹ Thereby the course of development of the religious ideas becomes still more complicated and obscure. The possibility of combinations and assimilations, contrast-effects and expansions is thereby increased beyond survey. Here lie a series of problems for the history and psychology of religion of the future.

44. The idea of a world of gods, a divine kingdom, is a station on the road from polytheism to monotheism. When one has found a quite distinctive difficulty in the transition from polytheism to monotheism, it is because one has looked at the matter too externally. Within polytheism there already expresses itself in many ways that need for practical and theoretical concentration whose full consequence is monotheism. And the same psychological laws that lead from the religion of drive to polytheism lead from this to monotheism—in so far, that is, as outside dogmatic speculation (and even there!) there is any real monotheism in the word's strictest sense.

The transition to monotheism can take place under two forms, which nevertheless pass over into one another through many nuances.—In the first place, within the world of gods a single god can become predominant, so that he is raised high above all other gods and above other peoples' gods and at last comes to stand as the only god. With this there will as a rule also follow a purification and deepening of the idea of God; or conversely, a purification and deepening of the idea of God leads in a monotheistic direction.—In the second place, an idea of the divinity can be developed which does not particularly

support itself on a single figure of a god that is deepened and enriched, but is grounded on the divine in all gods—on that in the gods which first makes them gods (to use Plato's expression, *Phaedrus* p. 249 C), and which in the different gods is represented in different ways.

In the first direction the development goes among Assyrians, Babylonians, Egyptians, and Israelites. Jewish prophetism presents the best known, the most fully carried through, and the historically most significant monotheistic process of development.

The development of Jewish monotheism is one with Jahveh's development from special and national god to universal god. It is due to the deep effect that the historical events exercised on the minds of the prophets. The prophet stands in the midst of his people and of its traditions; but in contrast to the people and its spiritual and worldly leaders, it is the people according to its ideal essence and according to its constant persistence beyond the momentary conditions of the time that is the object of his concern. With ecstatic absorption in the great world-events he combines the capacity to assert in mighty images the ideal conception of his people and its significance which he has drawn out of its history. A distinction can be drawn between a predominantly world-historical and a predominantly ethical consideration as the foundation of the development of Jewish monotheism; but common to both is that it is the very endeavour to hold fast under new conditions the transmitted religious ideas that leads to a higher, more ideal development of them: only by becoming a world-god instead of a national god could Jahveh avoid sharing the fate of his people in its downfall as an independent people; and since he came to stand as the upholder of higher ethical ideas than had hitherto been attached to the idea of him, that superiority became possible which stood in so cutting an opposition to the fate of the people whose national god he had been.

The historical consideration first comes forward in Hosea and Amos (c. 760 B.C.). It was not—they teach—by the help of their own gods that the Assyrians conquered, but by the fact that Jahveh wished through their armies to punish his disobedient people. The great unknown prophet who is usually called Deutero-Isaiah (c. 540 B.C.) goes a step further: the people of Israel suffers not merely for its own sins, but in order that it may be purified to bring peace and salvation to all peoples. There forms for the prophet's intimating vision the picture of a figure who wins and brings the highest through the deepest lowliness and abasement, because in inwardness and in fellow-feeling there lies a greater value than in the great unfolding of power among the conquering world-peoples. The historical and the ethical consideration here pass over into one another. In Jeremiah (c. 620 B.C.) the ethical consideration in particular is carried out, though Amos

already knows it too. As the God of righteousness, Jahveh must rule everywhere where righteousness holds or is to hold—thus he must be the God of the whole world, who is not limited by national barriers. And since the true relation to Jahveh is an inner relation in the heart, outer forms and their difference become at last without significance. The time shall come when everyone bears the law in his heart, and already now the prophet praises other peoples' faithfulness to their gods in contrast to Israel's unfaithfulness to Jahveh. Both the universality of the ethical ideas and the inwardness they demand lead out beyond the national limitation.

Jesus of Nazareth set up no new concept of God in relation to that which had worked its way forward in the great prophets. But he himself stood with his personality as surety that the time had come to which the prophets in intimating visions and thoughts had looked forward—the time when an inward and infinite relation to God could come into force. By the deep movement in the minds of human beings that the picture of Jesus's personality awakened, a movement that let all outer conditions and differences vanish in value, it became possible that monotheism could become a popular religion on a larger scale. The one true God was a God such as the one to whom a human being like Jesus could testify, and whose emissary he could be.

In the second direction the development takes place among Indians and Greeks.—Among the Indians it is not any single god that becomes sole ruler, but there is a going back to the very force that makes all gods what they are: the inward yearning and need that finds vent in prayer and sacrifice. By an extraordinarily remarkable development of thought, that which drives the human being to worship gods comes itself to stand as the true divine power.

Bráhma means according to some swelling, thereafter yearning, then prayer, and at last the principle of existence itself, in that the idea passes over from the movement to its goal, from the need to its object;—according to others it means the magically creative word. If it is asked more closely (as the gods themselves ask in the *Upanishads*) what Bráhma then properly is, no other answer can be given than that it is one with Atman, the soul, which the human being knows from his own inner life. There lies here, as we have earlier (§15) seen, the first attempt at metaphysical idealism (c. 800 B.C.). The gods of the popular religion stand under Bráhma as its forms of revelation. The relation of the Indian gods to Bráhma recalls the relation that according to Plato prevails between the Greek gods and "the ideas."—This relation of subordination was acknowledged only after serious struggle. It was provisionally as a "secret doctrine" (this the word "Upanishad" is said to mean) that this monotheistic tendency came forward, and it was, as Deussen

conjectures, first developed by thinkers who had come from the warrior caste, while the Brahmins (the priests) long held fast the literal understanding of the transmitted ritual and only reluctantly went over to an allegorizing that made it possible to unite the new doctrine with the old cult.—Among the Greeks the monotheistic tendency comes forward especially in the philosophers. XENOPHANES (c. 500 B.C.) combats polytheism partly through a comparison of the Greek gods with other peoples' gods, partly through a criticism of anthropomorphism. Each people represents the gods in its own shape: the negroes' gods are black, the Thracians' blond, and if oxen had gods they would represent them in the shape of oxen. In his zeal against all finitizing and degrading ideas Xenophanes raises himself to the thought of a principle of unity that cannot be the object of vivid representation. But he also applies an ethical criticism to the polytheistic popular faith, and it is especially from this side that Plato later continues his work.

In India the thinkers' endeavours after unity were outstripped by the popular need for a manifold representation of the divine, and in Greece the result of thought was likewise unable to become the content of a popular religion. This became possible only where—as in Jewish prophetism and its conclusion in Jesus of Nazareth—the thoughts are developed through the people's own experience, its own fate, and where they are woven into the picture of a personality who stands as a revelation of the highest inwardness and love and thereby himself becomes a symbol of the value of the thought for which he fights.—

The psychology of religion cannot here, any more than on many other points, get further than to point out points of view that can make the transition from polytheism to monotheism intelligible. But there lies here no special psychological mystery, as has sometimes been maintained in a somewhat advertising manner. There may therefore both psychologically and historically be riddles enough left.

But when is the transition from polytheism to monotheism accomplished? When is there a pure monotheism, and is such a thing possible at all? When one represents the divinity as appearing in several "persons," and when it stands in opposition to a "world" that is its limit and its hindrance, can the concept of God then properly be said to be purely monotheistic? When "the world," the other thing that exists besides God, is a real reality, not a nothing, then it has a force that is *not* vanishing in comparison with the divine force, and is so far itself a god within its limits, just as well as "God" within his. The same holds when one assumes a "free" will (in the word's metaphysical, not in its psychological or ethical sense) or believes in a devil. And since assumptions such as these are found in all popular religions, there is no reason to lay so great weight

on the opposition between polytheism and monotheism as one often does. Just as there are monotheistic tendencies in polytheism, so there are polytheistic tendencies in monotheism. WILLIAM JAMES rightly maintains that popular theism has a polytheistic character.⁵⁰

The most energetic attempts to carry through a monotheism have been made by philosophers: by the Vedanta philosophers, by the Eleatics, and by Spinoza. But it has precisely in these attempts of thought shown itself clearly that the problem of the relation between unity and multiplicity in existence cannot be solved by making one of the two terms of the relation the only one. One will then never without witchcraft be able to get the other term forth. Whether the “reborn” knowledge that some theologians have spoken of would here be better placed than natural knowledge will show itself only when the logic of this “higher” knowledge is one day written, which it is not yet.—But a closer discussion of this would lead us back to the epistemological philosophy of religion.

45. The two tendencies that appear, more or less pronounced and in different mutual relation, in every religious circle of ideas—the polytheistic and the monotheistic—point back to the two tendencies in the nature of the religious need that we have already had occasion to point out (§18).

There expresses itself on the one hand a need for gathering and concentration, for absolute devotion, for getting beyond all strife, resistance, and change. This need comes to unfolding in mysticism and monotheism; it meets with the intellectual need for a conclusion in an absolute principle of unity.

But in the religious consciousness there expresses itself at the same time, more or less energetically, and in rhythmic alternation with that first need, the need to have a fellow-combatant at one’s side in the midst of the strife, a fellow-combatant who from his own experience knows what it is to suffer and to undergo resistance. This need will counteract the carrying through of monotheism. And it will be supported by various other motives. There will stir a need for vivid representation, a need for images, which leads to the formation of limited ideas of the divine—or rather to ideas of the divinity as limited, since only the limited can be shaped into an image. It is what has been called “the antinomy of religious feeling,” that the infinite and exalted is nevertheless represented in limited form. The need for images can be so strong that it becomes a shyness of infinity and thereby comes into the strongest opposition to that first need.

The reason why this opposition is not always noticed we already know. The religious consciousness is absorbed in the individual mood and lets it unfold and express itself as fully and wholly as possible. Only where memory, juxtaposition, and comparison become

possible is the opposition or the contradiction between the different ideas discovered. It goes with religious experience on monotheism's ground as it goes with it on the ground of the religion of drive and of polytheism. Religious faith's best—and often only—weapon against criticism of every sort is to demand that all juxtaposition and comparison be kept away. Again and again back to the whole and full moods, to the moments of religious affect! He who for example—as has been demanded—reads the Bible only “on his knees” will escape all criticism's difficulties. He is absorbed in the individual account, the individual content—and even of that he involuntarily takes only what he can use. He will not come to investigate whether the different accounts of Jesus's resurrection agree, and so forth. The problem of how God's omnipotence is compatible with the human being's “free” will naturally falls away when, at the moment one thinks of the one of these things, one does not think of the other at all. When one—as Rasmus Nielsen and Henry Mansel attempted—distinguished sharply between religion and theology, the possibility of this distinction lay in this opposition between states where the great differences are forgotten and states where they are juxtaposed and compared. But without an intellectual asceticism this opposition will not be able to be carried through. There are at any rate those who will not lie on their knees but stand upright and look freely about them in the world, and who do not find that the highest they know suffers thereby. It is orientalism that would force us to our knees; but it is as the heirs of the Greeks that we hold fast the conviction that an upright posture in life's highest questions is possible.

46. But in the opposition mentioned between the different states there may lie the germ of tragic conflicts. Juxtaposition of the ideas that express the opposite tendencies in their extreme form leads, in intellectually developed and yet passionate natures, to the convulsive holding fast of the paradox. In quieter form and more unconsciously it works in what I will call religious bashfulness. For religious bashfulness stems not merely from a natural shyness of expressing oneself about the inmost lived experiences, but also from a certain indefinite intimation that every image and every word in which one would express the highest can always give only something finite and limited, and thereby not merely provokes criticism from others, which is the least of the matter, but awakens in the individual himself doubt about the validity and value of what has hitherto stood for him as the highest. It brings with it for many natures a great spiritual pain to make up the final reckoning on this point, especially where piety towards the transmitted forms works along to keep these outside a juxtaposition and comparison that would otherwise lie near at hand.

By taking these relations into consideration we shall at once understand criticism's unavoidability and its slow influence. Perhaps it is the eternal strife that we here stand before. But it is a strife that must be carried on, and which—even if it should never end—is not at every time fought on the same ground and with the same weapons. The strife's eternity therefore does not exclude progress. The battle of the Einherjar was constantly the same, but the battle of which there is here question is never the same; thereby it stands above the battle in Valhalla. That the strife constantly repeats itself comes from the fact that a change in the life of ideas takes place more quickly than a change in the life of feeling; a theoretical criticism of religious ideas therefore does not reach down to the bottom of the problem; the decisive point is the valuation of the feelings that lie at the foundation of the religious ideas, and that after every critical cut are able to bring forth new shoots on the stem of the religious ideas. A constant relation of oscillation and reciprocal action takes place between the different poles of the life of the spirit.—The valuation of religious feeling itself belongs in the ethical philosophy of religion.

47. An advance will already have been made with the serious and consistent acknowledgement of this constant reciprocal action, which makes a definitive solution impossible. Let us try to take this experience up with us into the religious reckoning. The idea of a finished divinity then becomes impossible. If, on the other hand, the religious consciousness can reconcile itself with the idea of a divinity that is not finished and concluded, but in constant becoming and development—as the religious consciousness itself is, but on a larger scale—then there will be the possibility of a religion of hope, which assumes that new tasks are constantly set, but also new possibilities for the treatment of the tasks. Every state then comes to stand only as provisional, at most as a station on the road—on existence's road in the large, on the individual's road in the small; and one will then not be surprised or offended that “the goblin moves with us,” since the old problems are posed in new shapes. The new dwelling to which “the goblin” follows us may very well be a better dwelling, and why should “the goblin” absolutely be an uncanny being? He expresses a law for our thought and perhaps a law for existence. When the divine unchangeableness consists in, or makes itself known in, the fact that all change takes place according to definite laws, and that the law of development itself is a fundamental law in existence, then the contradiction between unchangeableness and changeableness falls away. The unchangeable is then the law of change itself, and even if the individual law is altered, it happens always by virtue of a higher law. Only a few steps can our thought climb up the graduated series whose possibility here shows itself; but this very

capacity to climb is sufficient to call forth a concluding hope, a faith in the persistence of the valuable, a holding fast of the great *Excelsior!* which is the noblest element in all higher religions, only that the dogmatic formulas so often hinder its full unfolding. If the conclusion we can win were more than a concluding hope, more than a subjective conclusion, then there would be no constant *Excelsior!* But when neither our experience nor our thinking leads to an objective conclusion, the reason for this might indeed be that existence itself is never concluded. That would be the most thorough explanation of the fact that no dogma and no image suffices.

If one will say that this thought leads out beyond what can rightly be called religion, I shall not quarrel about it, but let the word fall, especially if one will give me another in its place. We are free and will not make ourselves slaves of the word.

3.2.3 Religious Experience and Tradition

48. The form and content of religious faith will never be able to be understood from the individual's religious experience alone. The preceding investigation already teaches that: the development from the religion of drive through polytheism to monotheism takes place through long ages and many generations, and each individual stands at a certain point within this development, determined by what goes before and determining what follows after. Even if he has made the deepest and most independent experiences of the relation between value and reality, the manner in which he expresses and explains these experiences will be conditioned by the circle of ideas that stands at his disposal, and will thus be more or less determined by tradition, whether he himself notices it or not. Ideas can be involuntarily interwoven with what he lives through and feels, so that their content itself seems to be immediately lived through. Only on closer investigation is the difference discovered between the immediately given elements and the elements interwoven with them.

To illuminate this relation more closely I shall bring forward a series of historical examples.

49. Among *nature-peoples* already the relation between the individual's lived experiences (especially in ecstatic states) and tradition appears clearly. Among a Siberian tribe the young man who would become a shaman goes out into solitude, roams by night in woods and mountains, and here sees visions in which the tribe's gods and the spirits of the forefathers reveal themselves to him. He now sees what he has previously only heard about. It goes likewise with the shaman when he is about to lose consciousness by whirling himself round: in the ecstatic state thus produced he sees before him what

he otherwise knows only from tradition. A strict and long time of preparation must be gone through by the young Central Australian before he can be initiated into the tribe's secret faith.

What thus holds for the crudest stages of ecstasy and vision holds in principle at higher stages too. The visions that the enraptured and inspired human being receives are determined in detail by the ideas he has had beforehand. One can even produce hallucinations of a definite kind by commanding an individual who has been brought into a hypnotic state to see a certain object before him at a later moment, or by affecting him with definite sense-impressions (colours, tones, tastes, and so on). Charcot and Pierre Janet have in these ways been able to determine their patients' visions. To this comes the fact that the hallucinations that lie at the foundation of the visions are often very indefinite and elementary, so that only by being combined with and interpreted by ideas that the individual involuntarily draws from his own memory do they acquire definiteness and significance. The individual gets, for example, hallucinations of points of light or of a gleam of light and involuntarily forms from these a white figure, which at last perhaps even speaks to him. An example of such a transition of the vision from the indefinite to the definite and articulate is presented by the peasant girl Bernadette's vision, which gave occasion to the worship of the Madonna at Lourdes. Still more clearly this characteristic mark appears in one of Swedenborg's visions. One morning he sank into religious brooding, and when he raised his gaze he saw above him in the sky a radiant light; when he fixed his gaze on it, the light drew aside; heaven opened for him, and among much else wonderful he saw the angels standing in conversation; kindled by a lively wish to know what they said, this too was granted him, so that he first merely heard a sound (*sonus*) that expressed heavenly love, and thereafter formed speech (*loquela*) that was full of heavenly wisdom. Thus both as regards the hallucinations of sight and those of hearing a progressive articulation takes place in the course of the vision's unfolding. And although it was unutterable things the angels spoke of, things of which most cannot be expressed by human speech, Swedenborg was nevertheless able by the help of his earlier visions to understand a good deal of it: it is a kind of Unitarian theology that the angels develop. An orthodox theologian would quite certainly have heard the angels utter other dogmatic views.—

Purely elementary hallucinations are far more frequent than one as a rule supposes; but only under special conditions, with strong movement and tension in consciousness and under the influence of dominant, feeling-toned ideas, do they become proper visions. The value of such visions may be highly different, although the psychological explanation

of them is essentially the same. A hallucination is called a vision only when it has a certain value; but in a psychological respect there is no difference of principle to be made. All visions bear the stamp of the visionary personality's character, memories, and stage of culture. As a single example of how ideas that were previously alive in consciousness can determine an elementary hallucination and give it its significance, I shall (besides the vision of Swedenborg mentioned) adduce a vision of Vincent de Paul which he had when his pious friend Mme de Chantal died: he saw a luminous globe rise into the air and up in the heights unite with another globe of light, whereupon both together were absorbed into a still more radiant globe of light, and an inner voice now told him that it was the pious woman's soul which, in union with the soul of the earlier departed François de Sales, became one with God!—It will therefore especially depend on which ideas prevail beforehand of the visions; and if these ideas are formed and organized, they will be able both to interpret and to soften strong visionary and ecstatic movements in the religious domain. It is a phenomenon that repeats itself again and again in the history of the religious life. Paul saw the heavenly Christ in the shape he knew beforehand, although he had regarded it with other eyes.⁵¹

When the ecstatic *cult of Dionysus* made its way to Greece from Thrace, the oracle at Delphi succeeded in organizing the wild movement by bringing it into connection with the existing cult of Apollo. Whereas those seized by the Bacchic frenzy had previously known virtually no rule other than the promptings of the swarming feeling, they were now brought under the influence of a clearly formed and harmonious circle of images. The Delphic oracle generally, or in other words: the Delphic priesthood, stood as a kind of authority that expounded and ordered the movements of the religious life. Plato calls "the god at Delphi" the interpreter transmitted from the fathers. Since the oracle was consulted by all the Greek states concerning the ordering of cult, the Delphic tradition acquired a significant influence on the development of Greek religion.⁵²

50. In the history of *the Jewish religion* the finding of the book of the law (Deuteronomy) in the Temple under King Josiah (c. 620 B.C.) is an important event. A thoroughgoing organization now stepped forward over against the free individual movements in the domain of the life of cult and of prophetism. A closed priesthood now stood as leader of the religious life, whereas previously the head of the household had attended to the cult for himself and his own. The opposition between clergy and people was sharpened; prophetism was soon succeeded by the priestly system. Judaism got its canonical book, a codified expression of the tradition; it became a religion of the book, something in which Christianity and Mohammedanism later imitated it.⁵³

At the coming-into-being of Christianity the religious traditions co-operated in the people and the time in which Christianity's founder came forward. We are cut off from knowing the inner life of Jesus of Nazareth prior to his public appearance. But however his life of feeling may have unfolded, he used his people's traditions for its interpretation and formation. In the Sermon on the Mount he presented his ethical teaching as an inwardization and spiritualization of the Mosaic law. In the chiliastic expectations, the hopes of a coming kingdom of consummation perhaps transmitted from Parsism to Judaism, he found (or his disciples found, under the impression of his personality) forms and images for the great hope he implanted in the race. Thus even the most significant religious personality that history knows developed by means of tradition and exercised influence upon it. This does not exclude independence, for the old becomes new by being taken up and applied by a deep and original genius.

In the same way as Jesus was placed when he was to form his religious ideas, his disciples were placed when they were to interpret and express the effect that the Master's personality, his life and death, had made upon them. They conceived him either as the expected Messiah (*the three first Gospels*), or as the Logos, the eternal Word (*the Gospel of John*), or as the sin-offering (Paul), or as a spiritual high priest (*the Epistle to the Hebrews*). These are different roads along which they sought to make clear what the Master was for them.

51. The picture we get through the apostolic epistles of the first Christian congregation shows us no fixed organization. Enthusiasm and ecstasy stirred strongly and freely. But if a congregational life was to develop, it was not enough that individuals gave themselves up to inner lived experiences which in violent rapture made it impossible to form definite thoughts and words, so that the outbursts became unintelligible to others. "Speaking in tongues" has consisted in inarticulate and therefore unintelligible outbursts. "The spirit" worked so violently that "the understanding" did not get to speak too. Paul therefore admonishes the Corinthians to limit these ecstatic states, when they hold their gatherings, to such cases where an interpreter can test and interpret them, so that what is lived through in these states may benefit others. *The fourteenth chapter of the first epistle to the Corinthians* gives an insight into these matters (see also 2 Cor. V, 13). The interpreter must probably have been able to enter so far into the state of the one "speaking in tongues" that he could find the thoughts and words through which what moved in the mind in this state could be expressed. An immediate sympathy, an involuntary inference from analogy guided by sure tact, formed the presupposition of the interpretation, just as everywhere where one is to be guided by others' expressions

and movements to understand what goes on in their inner life. But at the same time, certainly, partly the Old Testament writings, partly the apostolic teaching furnished norms for the exposition. Perhaps this lies in the demand set up in the Epistle to the Romans (XII, 6), that the gift of prophecy is to be exercised “in agreement with the faith,” if “faith” here denotes the content of faith. Thus the individual’s inner lived experiences were early brought under traditional norms.

Later on—as the Church became organized—the stream of individual enthusiasm was more and more dammed in.

In the apostolic age it was especially regard for the edification of others that motivated the limitation. But now everything depended on preserving agreement with tradition and excluding heresy. The free individual movements were then pushed back as dangerous—in so far as they did not cease from lassitude. Among lay people the capacity for visions and for speaking in tongues fell away first—quite naturally—later among monks and priests. Comparison and misgiving began to prevail. One did not rely on the immediate promptings, but tested them according to norms that became ever more precise. In the so-called *Pastoral Epistles* (the epistles to Timothy and Titus) “sound doctrine” is already inculcated over against heretical errors. The history of the Church shows how organization and the fixing of dogma advance in the course of the centuries. In place of expansion came organization and articulation. The setting up of a canon (*the collection of the New Testament writings*) was the most important link in this course of development. It is the Church that here, at a certain point of its development, once and for all established which books are to be regarded as genuine testimony to the true doctrine.

Only through the ecclesiastical authorities could it from now on be decided whether a formation of religious ideas was valid, whereas earlier the revelation was constantly continued in the inner life of individuals. The Church now became the guardian of the gifts of grace. It went here as with the miracles: only the Church is to decide whether a religious truth is present. Even as regards religious conduct of life the Church demands that its tradition be followed: when Francis of Assisi wished to renew the apostolic life (after the tenth chapter of the Gospel of Matthew), the Church carried through the formation of an order after the model of the older orders (*exempla antiquorum*). The Church here turned, as so often, against the renewal of the original when this conflicted with the traditions that had formed in the meantime.

The Catholic Church nevertheless maintains that new dogmas can be formed. When the religious need has led to the formation of certain ideas, the Church’s head can declare such a content of ideas to be ecclesiastical doctrine. The new dogma then stands

as the valid expression of something the Church has fundamentally always believed, but of which it has only now become fully conscious. Before the proclamation of the dogma of Mary's immaculate conception, Pius IX sent out a circular in order to learn whether the congregations longed for this dogma, and the result of this approach was such that an inscription could afterwards be set up in St Peter's declaring that the Pope by the proclamation of the dogma had fulfilled the longings of the whole Catholic world (*totius orbis catholici desideria explevit*).⁵⁴ Catholic writers sometimes regard the whole ecclesiastical fixing of dogma—right down to the dogmas proclaimed in the nineteenth century—as further unfoldings of what Jesus in the forty days between the resurrection and the ascension spoke of with his disciples.⁵⁵—The history of the dogma mentioned affords an interesting contribution to the psychology of religion by the clear manner in which the relation between need of feeling (*desideria*) and idea there appears. One felt the need for an intermediate link between the Jesus exalted to God and humanity. And besides, there was felt a need to have the element of womanliness, and especially of motherly love, represented in the religious circle of ideas. In an extraordinarily beautiful and instructive manner *Yrjö Hirn* (*Det heliga Skrinet*, 1909, chs. 11–12) has depicted the development of the worship of the Madonna and thereby given an example of how a religious need leads to cult and through this in the course of time to a dogma.

But as in every psychological process, manifold factors here too work together. No dogma can be explained out of a direct religious need alone. The Church's inner and outer circumstances in particular play an essential role. The Church feels itself bound by its traditions (as it itself understands these), whether it follows them in blind habit or seeks to form new ideas in analogy with, or as a supplement to, the ideas already formed. It combats a "false doctrine" and therefore strives after a formulation that rejects it as sharply as possible. Or it seeks to unite and reconcile contending tendencies by a shrewd compromise, often a shrewd indefiniteness or ambiguity. Or it strives to form ideas that can correspond to its cult, as this has once for all developed. Harnack finds in his history of dogma that it was eleven (11) different factors—namely ten besides the properly religious need—that co-operated in the development of the ecclesiastical dogmas (the content of the present orthodox dogmatics) in the first centuries.⁵⁶ To these many elements there ought perhaps to be added an aesthetic element. It is according to *Yrjö Hirn* not merely religion that works upon poetry, but pictures and poetic works can often only be understood through "the great, anonymous, and collective poetry that one can read out of the whole ecclesiastical system of readings."⁵⁷

52. What thus appears in the history of a religious community shows itself still more

clearly in the religious life of a single personality, when this personality has the capacity and the need to describe its inner development. A great example of this we have in Augustine's *Confessiones*. When Augustine composed this work he stood on the firm ground of ecclesiastical tradition. He believed, by his own statement, in the Gospel only because the Church transmitted it. But the central religious process—a feeling that strives after expression in a content of ideas—can nevertheless be traced in him. The tenth book of the *Confessiones* in particular is characteristic in this respect. Augustine here seeks to become conscious of *what* it is that is the object of his inner need. "What is it that I love, when I love thee?" he asks his God. He goes through a long series of beings and forms that experience presents; but none of them satisfies what his feeling yearns towards. Only in his own inner life, in his own spirit, does he find an analogy he can use. In a profound development, extraordinarily interesting for the history of the fundamental psychological concepts, he points out memory as the distinctive characteristic of the life of the spirit. God must be a being who works after the likeness of the force that works in our memory. And he works indeed also in our inmost soul—far further within me than the inmost that I myself know! In the inner man truth dwells. But (now there is a passing over from the psychological to the ecclesiastical consideration) nevertheless: God is not merely something thus inwardly operative; he is first and foremost himself the object of a memory—the memory of the ecclesiastical preaching (*ministerium prædicationis*), from which fundamentally we know him alone!⁵⁸

Never have deep personal experience, energetic thought, and ruthless faith in authority entered so close and characteristic a combination as in this greatest teacher of the Church. In him too, indeed, the opposition between self-absorption and dependence on outer tradition appears clearly. Go not outside yourself, for truth dwells in your inner life! he exclaims. But it is the Church's tradition that he thinks he owes everything to. As if that did not also come from outside! Yet the strong dependence on tradition is unable to veil the fundamental psychological relation between feeling and idea that is distinctive of the religious domain. Especially in the utterance that was above set as the motto for the first section of the psychology of religion does this fundamental relation appear definitely: a predicate is sought that can serve to determine what makes itself felt in the feeling. If doubt during the spiritual struggles of his youth had not led him to cling to the Church's authority, and if he had not later, when he stood as a churchman, felt so strong a need to assert this authority against "dissolving" elements, the movements of his inner life could have led to freer and more universal results. To this came the fact that he lived in a time when the world—by his own statement—had grown old (*senuisse*

jam mundum);—the boldness for a free and independent shaping of the inner life does not thrive in such a time.—

A certain analogy to the development in the tenth book of Augustine's *Confessiones* is presented by the line of thought in the *Upanishads*. Just as Augustine asks: what is it that I love, when I love thee?—so it is asked in an Upanishad: what is Bráhma? And the answer is: Bráhma is Atman (breath, spirit, soul)! Thus the principle that bears the whole of existence, and which itself (if Bráhma means yearning or willing) is a projection of feeling's need—this finds (at any rate provisionally) its best expression in ideas drawn from the life of the soul itself.⁵⁹ The old Indian thinkers stand in a freer relation to tradition than Augustine was able to; therefore the psychological process appears more clearly in them.

53. In the mystics of the Middle Ages we find interesting examples of the reciprocal action between feeling, the formation of ideas, and tradition.

According to a terminology frequent among the mystics, "the will" or love is placed in opposition to memory and understanding. In the highest states all these faculties slumber, since the will is overwhelmed by overflowing blessedness; all suffering is forgotten, and no search after causes of the state, no comparison with other states, becomes possible. Not even any vision is possible in the highest, ecstatic moments. And in such a state the human being cannot communicate himself to others either. "The will" remains in this state longer than memory and understanding, and as soon as these can work, the formation of ideas and communication become possible. The mystic can then have written down what he thinks he has experienced. But the difference between what is really lived through and the thoughts and words in which it is expressed is very strongly emphasized by the mystics.—"It is felt, but not expressed," says HUGH OF ST. VICTOR, and using the images of the "Song of Songs" he says: "Thy beloved comes invisibly; he comes hiddenly; he comes incomprehensibly; he comes to embrace thee, not to be seen by thee!"—ANGELA DI FOLIGNO speaks of a vision in the following manner: "What did I see? God himself! I can say nothing else about it. It was a fullness, an inner, filling light, against which neither words nor comparisons avail. It was the highest beauty, that which makes all lips close, and which contains the highest good!" When she read what had been written down about what she had lived through at her dictation, she often could not recognize it again.⁶⁰

But although the mystics sharply emphasize the difference between lived experience and description, they nevertheless maintain no less strongly that what they live through agrees with the teaching of the Bible and the Church. It is a psychological riddle how they

can convince themselves of the agreement between the content of their lived experiences and the Church's teaching, when there is so great a difference between lived experience and description; for it is only by the help of a description that the comparison with the Church's teaching can take place. It also appears clearly enough that the agreement with the Church's teaching is expressly willed, not merely found. In the interpretation and description of the lived experiences one watched attentively that nothing came in that conflicted with the teaching of the Bible and the Church. There are express declarations about this from some of the greatest medieval mystics. Suso thus says of himself: "In the working out of his chief work [the Book of Eternal Wisdom] he was not in a state like that of one who is active and dictates, but like that of one who is seized by the divine (*divina patiens*). When what was inspired in him had been formed in writing, he came to himself (*ad se revertens*) and investigated with care (*diligenter rimatus est*) whether there was anything found in it that deviated from the utterances of the holy fathers." The difference between rapture, self-collection, and anxious submission to authority appears clearly here. And self-collection here works not, as in Augustine, to find by the road of one's own reflection an expression for the lived experience, but is used predominantly to see to the agreement with the Church's teaching.—In the female mystics obedience to the Church's authority appears still more definitely than in the male mystics. The apostle Paul had indeed forbidden women to speak in the congregation and referred them to enquiring of the men in religious matters. And since they lacked the male mystics' scholastic education, they had to feel themselves easily uncertain. However sure they were that their highest lived experiences had a divine origin, they nevertheless acknowledge throughout the Church's authority as decisive. Angela di Foligno's visions and lived experiences were written down by a monk who declared that he had added nothing, but had left out "many things that were too exalted to be contained in his wretched understanding"; thereafter the book was repeatedly examined by learned monks. And her confessor even found authority for her strong erotic expressions in the description of the ecstasies: "the Song of Songs belongs to the Bible too!" (This last trait I owe to a young Swedish friend who has particularly occupied himself with the subject).—SAINT TERESA describes how, in order to avoid going wrong, she questions everyone who could instruct her, and she clings—she says—so firmly to her Credo that even if she received all possible revelations, indeed even if she saw heaven open, her faith would not waver concerning the least point that the Church teaches! And if the thought occurs to her for a moment that what she hears might yet be just as true as what the fathers had heard, then she is sure that it is the devil tempting her! The decision

whether her book agreed with the Church's teaching she laid in the hands of a learned and pious Dominican monk.⁶¹

There is here a reciprocal relation present. For just as the lived experiences are interpreted and tested by the help of tradition, so they are also often called forth by living into the transmitted ideas. It is then reading that sets the mystical absorption and lived experience going. Both Hugh and Teresa therefore also mention the significance of reading. One is reminded here how the persons in the van Eycks' and Memling's religious pictures are frequently so absorbed in their books that they forget everything and everyone around them.⁶²

And yet the mystics had also a purely subjective criterion of the validity of their lived experiences: the inner peace and rest in the mind that was produced. So long as the need for submission to Bible and Church was strong and living, this inner peace and rest could indeed only be reached when one had brought one's ideas into agreement with the transmitted teaching. But there was nevertheless a possibility that the immediate trust in the experiences of the inner life, and the intellectual activity in the work of shaping them into thoughts, could become so vigorous that submission to tradition was no longer possible, but the old leather bottles were burst by the new wine. In this way the way can be paved for great religious conflicts, and this way all founders of religions and reformers have gone, often after an honest attempt to find peace within the old forms. It is then discovered that a new living garment must be woven for the divinity. In a Protestant mystic of our own time (discussed in my book "Oplevelse og Tydning," especially pp. 96–100) the opposition between lived experiences and tradition appeared—in contrast to Angela and Teresa—very sharply and decisively.

54. In *the Reformers* too one notices the psychological process in which the immediate experiences of the personal life meet, are shaped, and are limited by ecclesiastical traditions. In Luther's case we have already seen how he—in a manner recalling the line of thought in Augustine—seeks an expression for what moves in him. God is, he says indeed, that in which you have the highest trust. But the closer development of his concept of God Luther wins only by simple adoption of the old ecclesiastical doctrinal determinations. He let the scholastic doctrine of the Trinity stand as it stood, while he set his personal stamp on the religious ideas that stood in immediate connection with his personal lived experiences, thus justification by faith and the sacrament of the Lord's Supper in a form closely akin to the Catholic conception. That Luther thus took up other and more than corresponded to personal lived experience was a half-measure that finds its explanation in his faith in the Church, but which became fateful

for Protestantism's later development. A clear principle that can be consistently carried through Protestantism gets only when it supports itself on the free conscience and the personal experiences that individuals make concerning the relation between value and reality.

Still more clearly than in Luther the psychological foundation of the religious assumptions appears in ZWINGLI. While Luther halts his independent train of thought when he has defined God as the object of the highest trust, Zwingli goes a step further and thereby comes to his absolute doctrine of predestination. Zwingli stresses more strongly than Luther the unconditional certainty of faith that the individual can have of attaining salvation, and to this subjective but unshakable certainty corresponds the faith in divine election. And if this election is to reach its goal, it must stem from a power that makes all resistance give way, an absolute, infinitely exalted power. Even if Zwingli in carrying through this line of thought is also under the influence of his philosophical studies (of Plato and the Stoics), it is nevertheless the personal experience that gives the impulse by which the line of thought gathers speed. Only an experience like Zwingli's could introduce a line of thought of this kind.⁶³

Within Protestantism attempts have been made, still more definitely than the Reformers made them, to trace religion back to the mind's own experience, to let all religion be a cult of the heart. Rousseau and Schleiermacher are the most important representatives of this endeavour. But they too, when they attempt to shape their lived experiences into thoughts and words, are referred to ideas they take up from the spiritual atmosphere in which they live, and these ideas they are inclined to regard as just as immediately given as the lived experiences themselves. Rousseau "felt" immediately "the truths of natural religion," and although Schleiermacher proceeds with greater psychological sense and critical circumspection, the obvious confusion of feeling's expression and its cause is nevertheless found in him too.

Personal experience for the most part stands immediately and naively over against the transmitted ideas and forms in which the religious need of earlier times found expression, and it thinks it takes them as they are. Only a closer consideration discovers the constant displacements that here take place. The mere fact that the emphasis is laid on other elements in the content of ideas than before brings with it a nuance. Something similar happens here as when in the history of art a type of picture is taken up by a new race of artists. Of the older Italian painters' relation to the transmitted Byzantine Madonna type, JULIUS LANGE remarks that they did not place themselves revolutionarily towards it, but little by little carried it over into a wholly different and opposite direction: "Into the

fundamental features of the transmitted lifeless mask they begin to insert their personal opinions about the gracious beauty that was to be characteristic of God's Mother. Thus Guido of Siena. It is still the almost circular contour of the crown of the head, the face's elongated oval. . . . But how fresh, how lively and amiable does this Madonna not look out of her eyes!"⁶⁴ In the history of religion the displacements are not to be pointed out in so vivid a manner. They take place partly by one's letting those elements in the tradition come into the foreground to which feeling particularly finds attachment, partly by certain elements' being involuntarily reinterpreted, understood poetically, symbolically, or rationalistically, or else wholly omitted, without one's being provisionally conscious of thereby deviating from the tradition's original meaning. It was a great relief to Augustine when in his youth he heard that the bodily expressions the Bible uses of God could be understood figuratively, not purely literally, and he later applied the allegorical interpretation confidently on a large scale when there was something in the ecclesiastical teaching from which he could not otherwise wring religious value. That God's spirit at the creation floated over the waters means according to Augustine that the human being by the gift of the Spirit, which is love of God, raises himself above the bodily; that God "created [both] heaven and earth" has for him the symbolic meaning that within the Church there is both a more spiritual and a more literal understanding. *The mystics* went still further along this road, in that they, as has been aptly said of them, "wished to abolish every barrier between themselves and Scripture's content, to know everything [that Scripture relates] as an eternal present." Meister Eckhart for example interprets in a sermon the idea of the raising of the widow's son at Nain thus: the widow is the soul, and the dead son is the reason.—In a similar track the edifying religious discourse moves more or less at all times, led by the endeavour to find in accounts of what happened millennia ago immediate nourishment for the spiritual life of the present. A double meaning is then ascribed to the old utterances, without one's as a rule forming a clear idea of the relation between the two meanings. Even in philosophers of religion in the nineteenth century—in men like Schleiermacher, Hegel, and Coleridge—we find the assurance that the conversion of the content of ecclesiastical tradition into the forms that agreed with their own life of feeling and thought does not alter this content's original meaning. Even SØREN KIERKEGAARD, who wished precisely to deliver the dogmatic content from the speculative evaporations, nevertheless comes to push the objective content of dogma back; he appropriates at any rate only what his passionately strained life of feeling consumes, and in such a meaning (often a reinterpretation) as he can use it in.⁶⁵

Where such an accommodation is no longer possible on account of the inner life's energy, the old forms are burst, and if the religious life is to be continued, new forms must be produced. We then stand—as already remarked—at a breakthrough where something new comes into being. The question then becomes how the psychology of religion is placed towards such breakthroughs and towards the prophetic personalities in whom the new comes into being.

But before I enter upon this question, there is still a general consideration to be made concerning the relation between feeling and idea in the religious domain.

3.2.4 The Scientific Conclusion of the Psychology of Religion

3.3 Dogmas and Symbols

3.4 The Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.1 More Precise Determination of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value and of its Relation to Experience

3.4.2 Psychological-Historical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.3 General Philosophical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.5 The Principle of Personality

3.5.1 The Significance and Justification of the Principle of Personality

3.5.2 Buddha and Jesus

3.5.3 Is the Principle of Personality a Principle of Growth or of Dissolution?

3.5.4 Layman and Scholar

Chapter 4

Ethical Philosophy of Religion

4.1 Religion as the Foundation of Ethics

4.2 Religion as a Form of Spiritual Culture

4.2.1 Psychological Considerations

4.2.2 Sociological Considerations

4.3 Primitive Christianity and Modern Christianity

4.4 We Live on Realities

Notes